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Mature

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Fandom:
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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
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Echoes in the Void

by NotMyDestiny

Summary

In the quiet of space, nothing stays buried. When an ancient magic begins echoing their inner emotions and fears back at them, Adora clings to control, and Catra worries that she'll only make things worse. To survive, they'll have to stop running from who they used to be, and choose to trust each other, even when it hurts.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1: Cadence

The sky shivered with light as hundreds of small meteoroids rained down in cascading streaks of silver fire amidst the still and star-flecked blackness of space. Staccato impacts struck against the metal hull. Breath fogged the transparent dome of Adora's helmet in intermittent pulses, the slightest hairline crack visible at the base. The plasma torch in her hand cast molten gold streaks against the dark alloy plating of the ship's outer shell.

The sharp vibration of three quick strikes was followed by a pause and then three again. The rhythm repeated, almost musical and gentle in its cadence, if not for the fact that the space rocks, though tiny, were moving fast enough to do serious damage. The hull caught their light in micro-flashes, reflecting every impact. The pattern seemed almost too deliberate for debris.

Adora balanced at the edge of the breach, Catra perched nearby, her tail stabilizing her with feline ease. Their magnetic boots gripped the ship's smooth surface. Their sleek spacesuits, worn from use, still protected them from the meteoroid shower. Catra's suit had old scuffs and a small scorch mark across the left thigh, marks left from past missions. Adora's had been obsessively patched and reinforced.

Adora felt the pressure of her suit against her ribs like a steady hand, and the soles of her boots hummed from the micro-vibrations on the hull. Adora's breath was soft in her helmet, a slow inhale followed by the low, continuous buzz of comm static. The gaps between the strikes felt like a meditation.

Catra tapped the heel of her boot against the hull in an answering triple beat.

"Sky's throwing pebbles at us. Hope it doesn't escalate its attack to full-on rock storm," Catra's sarcasm cut across the comm.

There was no crowd to hear it, no comm chatter or Glimmer’s commands or Bow’s overly helpful suggestions. Just the two of them now. They’d travelled space with the others not too long after the war, restoring magic in a half-broken ship full of laughter and exhaustion. Now, their friends had needed to return to Etheria, and Adora had wanted just a little more time with the stars and Catra.

Even Adora didn't answer. She was too absorbed in tracking the glowing impacts and counting the seconds between, like measuring the timing of thunder after lightning. As a young child in the Fright Zone, she used to count the same way when a storm rolled through, one-Etheria… two-Etheria, wanting to know how soon it would pass and needing to have some modicum of control. Now, though, the thunder was streaks of fiery rock, and the lightning was thuds against metal.

It was odd. The ship’s external sensors hadn't shown any meteoroid activity in their prep scans. Maybe it was too small for the ship to have registered it against other interference?

Catra stretched forward to reach the damaged outer panel, and Adora leaned just enough to counterbalance them both. Adora flicked a setting on the torch, and Catra shifted to give her clearance. The gap between them widened and shrank as they worked together, but they stayed near and always accounted for each other. One reached and the other steadied, not in response but in an anticipatory rhythm. Gloves repeatedly brushed as they moved in sync. They cast overlapping shadows in the torchlight on the hull.

Adora stood tight-jawed and focused, and Catra was agile and precise. They drifted closer to one another as they made the careful repair. One moved and the other adjusted smoothly, words not needed.

Catra shifted to brace the replacement plate against the alloy, but Adora was already there with the torch angled. Catra knocked their shoulders together lightly as she passed. Their movements

were mirrored on the reflective hull, silent in the void but perfectly timed.

Their helmets tilted toward each other for a second. Plasma flare reflected off the metal in dual halos. Catra shifted slightly, and Adora reached out without looking and steadied her firmly.

Catra teased, "Relax, I'm not gonna float away."

Adora always accommodated like this, always took the riskier positions without thought. It was easier to be the shield herself than to imagine Catra in harm's way. She told herself it made sense, as only one of them had magic as a backup. The logic settled quickly, almost too neatly. It protected her from uncertainty and from having to let Catra choose danger for herself.

The angle of Catra's shoulders told Adora she was about to move. Adora tilted the torch into place to seal the metal plate before words could even form. Their breathing synced, and their motions were a wordless rhythm. Catra placed a worn, gloved hand on Adora's arm to ground her, the torchlight tracing a seam like a glowing thread. Even through their many layers, the touch felt steady.

Catra's tail curled around Adora's ankle like an anchor, the motion casting shifting light across the ridged panels of her suit.

"Tail's not rated as a safety tether," Adora noted.

"Neither are you, yet here we are," Catra replied with a smirk.

Adora laughed softly through her nose, and Catra chuckled in return. Two bursts of bright laughter crackling across the comms. The warm sound echoed faintly inside Adora's helmet, filling her chest like the comforting weight of a favorite blanket.

The meteoroids continued to descend, and each small impact flashed faintly against the hull. Three strikes and then a pause.

Reflections of the torchlight gleamed off the metallic plating of their suits.

Adora angled her body, shifting so she was between Catra and the open seam, even though it made the weld more awkward and caused her to reach too far. She told herself it was for safety, but part of her knew it wasn't just driven by logic, but by fear. The torch flared brighter in response, white-hot at its core and gold toward the edges, the metal beneath it glowing briefly as it sealed. Sparks skittered away like tiny stars that extinguished against the hull.

As Adora reached outward with the torch, Catra's tail curled tighter around Adora's leg to balance her instinctively.

"You're gripping too tight again, dummy."

Adora exhaled, slow and controlled, her breath briefly fogging her helmet once more. The light on the metal steadied. Adora adjusted her helmet, and the slightest hiss escaped from the hairline fracture near the seal. It caught the light, small enough that it didn't impede function, but not invisible. The sound was the faintest whisper of air ghosting past the imperfect surface. To Adora, it was minor damage and not worth acknowledgment.

Catra glanced at the faint crack and frowned for just a second. Then, her smirk re-emerged, and her voice was lazy and teasing, "You better watch out, or your brain'll float away."

"It still works fine," Adora insisted, though a small flicker of guilt passed behind her eyes.

Their breath, their motions, they were perfectly synced as they finished the last steps of the repair. The torch flared against the metal as it completed the final seal. Then, a sudden, unexpected blip sounded across their comms.

Something shimmered at the edge of Adora's vision. Pressure shifted. Half a second later, Adora swore she heard the blip again.

This time, though, it echoed oddly inside her helmet. It was like something had exhaled directly into that faint crack in the acrylic.

It had direction, almost as if breath could carry in zero-g. It was a soft, half-warped sound. It seemed to bounce off of something unknown. The noise clearly didn't come from the radio comm. Radios didn't breathe. It seemed to come from nowhere at all.

The steady impacts of the meteoroids vibrated up through her boots. The faint tremors matched her pulse. It skipped a beat. Adora flinched. Her eyes flicked out toward the void. Her heart pounded faster. Her body tensed. She said nothing. She held her breath. She moved her head sideways. Testing, but there wasn’t anything more.

She almost asked Catra if she’d heard it. The question formed. It then folded. Admitting it aloud would make it too real. She wanted to believe it was just a glitch. It would certainly be easier if she could let herself assume the sound came from the helmet fracture. That it was something she could simply weld shut. She knew she could not.

Catra’s tail flicked once sharply, before wrapping lightly around herself.

“You okay?” Catra asked. “You blinked weird.”

“Fine. Just light reflection,” Adora replied too fast, her voice tight.

Catra’s tail twitched the way it did when she noticed something off, but she kept quiet.

Their eyes locked as Adora shut down the torch. They nodded in sync to confirm they’d head back inside. Adora’s thumb lingered on the torch’s trigger-guard for one extra hesitant second.

They ducked back into the ship and passed through the airlock. Amber-pink lights flickered on in their usual sequence, filling the deck with the warmth of their pleasant glow. It was the same

unhurried rhythm the ship had kept since long before either of them existed.

They removed their helmets and let them fall onto the bench. Air rushed back in. It carried the faint scents of warmed alloy and recycled citrusy disinfectant, their home away from home distilled to two lungfuls. Beneath it lingered the softer trace of morning tea carried from the galley. Adora's shoulders unknotted at the familiarity. She felt the safety of being protected once more from the unpredictable void of space by a firm metal hull.

The engines settled into their standard hum, the one that always rattled the vent a few times before evening out. It was a sound Adora trusted more than a diagnostic sequence. If it ever went fully quiet, that would be when to panic.

A rumpled blanket lay draped across one of the benches, no longer pretending it belonged in storage. A diagnostic display pulsed softly nearby, reading: ALL SYSTEMS HAPPY. Only Entrapta would program a ship to gauge its own emotional states. Another handwritten reminder was stuck over the system panel, "FILTER FIRST, THEN SWEAR." Its corners were curled from heat. The ship felt both emptier without their friends and yet fuller in a way with just the two of them.

The deck warmed a little beneath Adora's boots, just enough to notice. Adora had the comforting thought that the ship recognized the end of a mission and was welcoming them home.

Catra brushed Adora's cheek with her worn glove. Her touch lingered longer than necessary. They shared a held gaze and pressed their foreheads together. They stayed that way for a long moment.

They pulled off their gloves. Adora stretched out her hand and flexed it, knuckles stiff from holding too tightly for too long. Catra shook out her own fingers, claws extending and retracting. She rolled her shoulders, the motion loose and feline.

“You’re gonna sprain something if you keep gripping like that.” Catra’s voice was light, though her ears flicked with concern.

“Reflex,” Adora murmured.

“Control freak reflex,” Catra corrected teasingly.

Catra brushed a wayward hair out of Adora’s face and tucked it behind her ear.

Adora said, “You did good.”

“Well, we didn't die. High bar,” Catra replied, her words teasing, but her tone affectionate and her eyes gentle. She added, “You always act like I’m the one who’s gonna float off.”

Adora let the edges come down a little from her earlier tension. Her fixation on completing the repair just right now felt resolved. She exhaled fully. Her voice was more relieved and tender. “You held steady. You always do. Still, I watch out for you. I can't help it.”

Before Catra could reply, a signal started blinking from the main control panel. It was a repeating pulse so familiar it made them both instantly pause in their tracks. Catra’s tail flicked once like a metronome.

The light from the console reflected off the metallic curve of Adora’s cracked helmet in a series of rhythmic flashes. Three staccato beats echoed before a pause and a repeat of the eerie cadence. Adora listened intently in total stillness. Recycled citrus mingled now with the acrid tinge of sweat on the air. The diagnostic display read: SYSTEMS ADJUSTING.

“That signal, isn't the rhythm a bit like the meteoroids?” Catra asked hesitantly.

“Coincidence, for sure,” Adora reassured, almost too quickly. “It’s a distress signal of some sort. We should check it out. Someone could need help. Though it might just be transmission drift.”

She gripped onto the explanation like it might slip away if she didn't hold it in place. Distress signals had causes. They could be identified, categorized and solved. Meteoroids didn't send out messages. Chaos could so easily masquerade as patterns. Though the rhythm did line up a bit too cleanly.

No, she couldn't think like that. Distress signals had a protocol and sequence of steps she would follow. She couldn't trust unease over evidence.

They shared a look that clearly acknowledged what they would do. Catra nodded, though her posture tightened and her ears visibly tensed. Adora carefully keyed in a course toward the signal.

“Locked in,” Adora said.

The nav path flashed crimson, and Adora heard her own pulse echoing in her ears louder than the ramp up of the thrusters. Her hands stayed braced on the console a moment longer than necessary, as if her body hadn't fully digested the assurance. They just needed to keep moving, to stay ahead of it.

The engines surged, then hesitated, barely perceptible before they smoothed out. Adora didn't look back, but she felt Catra’s gaze linger on her for a beat longer. The silence stretched, almost as if it was waiting. Adora couldn't help but wonder whether the signal might be calling for something more. Catra didn't press, not yet.



Chapter 2: Resonance

Chapter Summary

> The distress signal draws them to a quiet planet, but something beneath the silence is growing harder to tune out.

A low, pulsing hum rose up through the soles of Catra’s boots, like the softest murmur, as their ship descended toward the planet emitting the distress signal. Her tail flicked once at the sensation. It was so faint she didn't even really register it, more just a background rhythm than full sound.

Inside their ship, consoles pinged in reassuring tones, amongst the familiar filtered light and air. Magenta-toned holographic charts cast their glow across Adora’s face, sharp with focus. Catra leaned against the rail, feeling the ship’s natural rhythms all around her.

The planet below shimmered with light. There were no signs of life and no movement. Just the thrum in the air of something ancient, yet still almost breathing.

“So, we’ve got a distress signal, no life signs, and a creepy hum. Great vibes already,” she murmured under her breath.

Catra’s ears twitched, one swiveling before the other, like they were noticing a frequency her mind hadn't quite latched onto yet. Three pulses, then a pause and three again. It wasn't coming from the console now, but something deeper, underneath the usual thrum of the engines, vibrating in time as they approached.

Catra glanced sideways at Adora to see if she felt it too. She was absorbed in the readings, too focused to notice. Her jaw was set tight, and her shoulders too tense.

“You gonna hug the console next?” Catra drawled. “It's still not gonna confess.”

No laugh or hint of a smile. Not even a glance in her direction. Catra’s ears flattened a bit.

She watched Adora double-check every system manually after the auto-scans had already confirmed safety. Adora flicked between readings like she was afraid the diagnostics might change if she looked away. Or maybe, she was afraid she’d miss some crucial pattern in the data. Catra’s tail lashed, then curled around her leg, like bracing for impact.

Atmospheric entry protocols engaged as the ship began its careful descent toward the planet. Its surface shimmered, each curve catching light at impossible angles and reflecting it back outward. The display showed “Stable Magic Field,” though the graph line stuttered every third spike.

Slowly, their ship cut through the planet’s upper atmosphere, each moment seemingly stretching longer than the last. Adora’s thumb unconsciously tapped against the console. Pressure shifted, and Catra’s ears felt full for a moment. Stars vanished behind them as dense clouds filled the viewport.

As they suited up once again, their arms brushed constantly. A shoulder bump here, a forehead touch there. Catra’s hand hovered where Adora had just been. Then she stepped closer automatically. Her knuckles grazed against Adora’s side. Tiny rhythms without thought.

Adora tightened a strap that didn't need to be fixed. Her hands moved continually, even when nothing needed adjusting. She was quietly over-precise. Their suits hissed in hushed sync as pressure equalized. Their comms crackled, and then Catra heard her own breathing slightly delayed.

They touched down, and the whisper of the airlock door sounded louder than usual. Side-by-side, they stepped off the ramp and out onto the planet, leaving the ship’s familiar hum behind. The silence hit first. It felt absolute, like sound had been stolen. In contrast, Catra’s boots crunched against dry dust and ancient

stone as she moved forward. The air itself felt charged and like it was watching.

Adora stood close enough that Catra could feel her warmth and steady presence by her side. It anchored her to something real. Whatever waited for them here, they faced it together.

They saw the dense ruins of an ancient civilization now abandoned. Stone buildings were etched with glyphs. The structures were precisely engineered and geometric. There was a stillness, like the planet had been waiting.

Shadows were thick as if staying deliberately just out of reach. Catra exhaled, then noticed a faint scent, something almost woody and cloyingly sweet, though nothing was visibly decaying. Whole areas were sealed from the inside with smooth metal, windows filled in and doorways closed off, as if the prior civilization had been trying to hide from something.

"You get the feeling this planet's gonna ask a question we don't wanna answer?" Catra asked, half-teasing, half uneasy.

Adora didn't look up fully from the ruins she had started studying. She tilted her head, lips pressed in thought. "Maybe," she said softly, "But at least we can try to understand it first."

Catra nodded and turned her own attention toward the ruins. A glyph pulsed as she walked past, but dimmed when she turned to look. Then it flared again at the edge of her vision, almost as if calling to her. She forced herself not to turn back.

The ship's readouts had shown safe. Still, Catra's boots hummed louder now. Something seemed off here.

Water pooled between the glyph stones. It rippled in slow, unnatural patterns that didn't come from wind or gravity. Then it became suddenly still and glassy. Catra squinted. Her reflection was there, but it moved a second too late. A ripple crawled across it, but the surface stayed still.

It triggered a memory of when she was a child back in the Fright Zone, staring at another reflection of herself. It was the first time she'd been allowed to carry a live shock-prod out of the armory. Her eyes had been so bright, her tail twitching, already ready to strike, already their weapon. That night, curled up on the foot of Adora's bed, she had whispered how scared she was that she'd just break everything she touched. Adora had reassured her, her trust so certain back then.

Now, Adora was intensely focused, almost distant, trying to find some meaning in the ruins. Catra recognized this as Adora trying not to let herself become anxious by staying useful instead. She saw how her jaw had clenched, and sweat beaded a bit along her hairline. They were barely there, subtle signs of her stress and intensity, but Catra noticed.

She stepped forward to help her decipher a glyph. She reached out to trace it with a claw retracted. It was a gentle gesture, the kind she never would have made when she commanded the Horde.

Adora stretched an arm out in front of her. "Let me check first, see if it's reactive."

Catra's ears snapped back, and she recoiled half a step.

They usually moved almost as one, like two parts of the same pattern, achieving each task together in tandem. Now, their rhythm felt suddenly off. It was like their natural resonance had unexpectedly faltered.

Catra's thoughts swirled. Does she think I'll break it? Or break myself? She almost blurted out, "Relax, I won't break your precious rock." Instead, she swallowed her instinct to push back and told herself, Adora was just being overly careful. Of course, she was being careful. Adora always was. She was too careful with artifacts and too careful with her. Funny, how careful landed like a hand holding her back.

Adora had now summoned the Sword of Protection and was attempting to tune into the ambient magic pulsing from the glyphs. Catra noticed the sword tilted slightly in Adora's grip without her even having moved it. Could have been the gravity here, or maybe it was something else. Catra recognized a three-beat vibration against her tail.

Catra wanted to tell Adora to just feel it instead of trying to control it, but she didn't. She watched and stayed silent. She remembered past fights, how she used to snap and make things worse, her claws and fangs bared. She had been working so hard to change, to not just always jump to frustration and anger first. She thought maybe this was growth, keeping the peace, not pushing. That's what growth looked like, right?

Tail twitched.
Claws out.
No, breathe.

Another lash of her tail, a sure sign she was agitated. She wrapped it tighter around her leg and let her claws retract. Still, the hum sharpened and buzzed in her jaw. Catra fought back the urge to say something. Her mouth opened for a second, but her voice stayed caged behind her teeth. Her tail arced, even tighter this time.

She wondered, if I'm softer, am I failing her? If I'm sharper, am I hurting her?

Adora had begun to channel She-Ra's power into the sword and was holding it up to one of the runes. The magic hum intensified, sounding almost like a voice just out of range. Adora's hand tremored in a rhythmic vibration.

Catra caught a glimpse in the slightly cracked dome of Adora's helmet. It was her own reflection, warped at the edges, smiling though she wasn't. Catra looked away quickly, ears flat against her head.

Light curled upward, slow and whisper-like. It spiraled around Adora’s sword like mist moving as if to the slow rhythm of a song, but it didn't touch her. It seemed to beckon, almost like it called to Adora. She leaned in, slightly too still, almost entranced.

Adora never went that still unless something had its hooks in her. Her breath had slowed almost unnaturally. The magic wasn’t pulling Adora away violently. It was inviting her. Catra had always hated that kind of danger the most.

The hairs on the back of her neck lifted. She saw through the reflection of the helmet’s fracture that Adora’s expression had shifted into a vacant, almost attuned look. Her pupils had dilated and were fixed on her sword. It felt wrong somehow. Adora moved like she was chasing something Catra couldn’t hear.

“You can’t just wander into a trance without a warning,” Catra tried for a light tease.

No response.

The sword blade darkened at the center while the edges flashed, like it was pulling light in rather than emitting it. Catra saw the glow traveling against the normal angle of reflection, flowing into the sword. It was like it was drinking in the light rather than releasing it. Shadows from the ruins seemed to stretch toward it rather than away. The sword glistened oddly. For a second, Catra saw herself in the metal, but warped and thin, eyes too wide.

The glyph seemed to pulse in rhythm with the arcs of her tail. The temperature around her felt suddenly like it had dropped a few degrees. Catra tried to ground herself through her breathing, to deliberately breathe in at her own distinct tempo against the controlling rhythm of the planet and the magic.

There was a resonance now between Adora and the magic, low and alluring, like an observable vibration. Catra’s ears pinned back. She could feel it pulling Adora in, matching her pulse,

syncing her breath. Her weight shifted subtly more and more toward the glowing glyph. It wasn’t letting go.

Catra thought for a moment that maybe she should leave this to Adora and give her some space, show that she trusted her. She had overreacted so many times before and didn't want this to be one more.

No, right now she needed to think of Adora’s safety before anything else.

“Adora… Adora!” She shouted Adora’s name once, then again, louder. At first firm and urgent, and then with raw panic breaking through her usually controlled tone.

Instinct kicked in.
Fight first.
Ask later.

She reined herself in from snapping just in time. Her claws were now out, old reflex nearly returned, but she turned her hand in mid-air and used her palm instead. Her hand hovered for a second. The glove was worn, threads loosening across the palm.

A claw trembled as she hesitated. She was afraid of hurting her. Or worse, afraid she couldn’t reach her. Then the moment passed. She grabbed Adora’s arm. The magic stung her hand through her glove, but she didn't flinch.

“Let go of her!" she snarled, not just at the magic, but at the fear, at Adora’s tendency to stand in front of danger alone.

The hum of magic turned to a thrumming roar. It vibrated through Catra’s spine, through her tightly coiled tail. It felt louder even than her pounding heartbeat.

Adora flinched like waking from a dream. Her face was rapt and blank, like she was listening to something just beyond reach. Then she blinked, like she was coming back out of a haze. Her breath hitched, and for a flash, she looked disappointed, but the

expression was gone too fast for Catra to be sure. The hum all around them had softened.

Catra moved slowly now, careful and guarding. Adora leaned a bit into her, the sword gone now. Catra kept a steady hand on her back, right between her shoulder blades.

Catra led, and Adora followed, a step out of sync, her breathing a bit shallow. Their footsteps sounded against the rough ground, uneven and out of rhythm. The planet felt eerily silent again, and Catra guided them toward the familiar hum of their ship's systems.

They stepped through the airlock, and Catra quickly pulled off her helmet first, needing air. She saw Adora pull her own off slowly and with more effort than usual. The crack seemed to have lengthened a millimeter.

"Next time we've gotta tango with ancient magic, I'm guarding the ship," Catra grumbled lowly.

She quickly keyed in the lift-off sequence and then settled Adora onto a bench. She leaned closer, examining her more carefully. She cupped her cheek with her worn glove. There was no physical damage, but the look in her eyes wasn't quite right, still too distant and out of reach.

"Hey… you with me?"

"Can't you hear it?" Adora lifted a hand as if to touch something invisible. "It's like singing…"

Catra's tail twitched. She went still. She told herself it was just exhaustion or an aftereffect. Her ears flicked back and forth, unsure.

"We're in orbit now," Catra said slowly. "You're on the ship."

Adora blinked like she was startled, as if the ship had just materialized around her. "I-I know that. I was… I was just

remembering.”

Catra’s concern ratcheted from background static to a drum deep in her chest.

Adora’s head tilted just slightly, just enough. Like she was still listening to something Catra couldn't hear. Then her gaze snapped back, too fast, too calm.

Catra watched her. Waited for Adora to bring it up, the distant look, the moment she seemed gone. She didn't.

“It’s fine, just overreacted.” Adora blinked a few times as if reorienting.

Catra couldn't seem to manage anything more than a tight nod in reply. Her tail coiled, and her ears pressed back. She leaned against the bulkhead for a moment and closed her eyes. An afterimage of the sword drinking in light and the pulsing glyph filled her mind, as did that haunted, attuned look on Adora’s face.

She didn't know what to say anymore, whether she should try and push or not. Her tail lashed. Catra remained silent. She pulled off her gloves. The hand where she had touched the magic tingled a little, an almost pulsing pins-and-needles feeling.

The ship hummed steadily beneath her feet. Three beats then a pause. Three beats then a pause. Three beats then a pause.

She told herself it was the coolant cycle, or that she must have imagined it. She told herself it didn't mean anything. She caught her own reflection again in the metal of the ship, and it seemed to blink a second before she did.

Catra’s tail tapped the floor three times before she noticed. She startled at her own body doing it. It didn't feel like a choice but a response. She needed to try and control it.

Adora stared past her again for just a second too long. The worst part wasn't the way the magic had followed them. It was the way

Adora seemed to want to carry it alone. Or maybe, her own fear that she'd need to become someone she hated to stop it.

Adora's shoulder brushed against hers. It was barely even a touch, but it carried weight like a question neither of them could ask out loud.

Catra swallowed, "You sure you're okay?"

Adora's mouth twitched. "Yeah." The word came out too smoothly. Her gaze snagged again on a spot just past Catra's ear, like she was listening to someone else standing there.

Catra's tail curled tighter, but she didn't look away this time.

"Adora," she said softly, like a lifeline.

Adora blinked like she'd been pulled back by the sound. "I'm here," she said, like she was trying to convince them both.

Catra nodded and reached out so her fingers hooked around Adora's gloved ones. She gave a light squeeze. "Okay," she murmured. Their hands felt linked together by the thinnest thread, like they couldn't be sure whether they could still choose each other anymore.

Adora turned her head, and her eyes met Catra's and stayed steady this time. Catra stroked her palm. She would stay soft enough not to hurt her and sharp enough not to lose her.

Thrum. Thrum. Thrum. Nothing. The coolant pump throbbed, mimicking that now too familiar pulse. Catra tried her best to breathe against it, but found she couldn't. The hum nested behind her sternum, and her next heartbeat felt like it arrived off rhythm.

Chapter 3: Quiescence

Chapter Summary

> A station appears, inviting and still. It beckons like it's already too familiar with the heartbeats about to board.

A brief flicker of silvery light glinted at the edge of her vision, but was gone before she could turn her head. Adora blinked, the echo of the song still threading through her thoughts, and told herself it was just the result of a tired brain that had slept fitfully the night before. Another gleam vibrated across the endless star-specked black of space. Whatever had reflected was there and then suddenly gone. The bursts flashed in time with the lingering rhythm in her head.

Adora's fingers hovered over the console as she decided whether to log the anomaly. She tapped once, and the display blinked, ready. She exhaled and closed it instead. She widened the sweep of the sensors. She hadn't really expected anything more to appear, but there in the distance was the hard-edged silhouette of a station.

A soft chime emitted as the ship registered it, the tone uncomfortably close to the bursts of three notes still lingering in her ears. The subtle bits of song hadn't quite left even now. They weren't calling to her. They couldn't be. It was just some sort of residual feedback from the planet that had gotten stuck in her head.

Then why did it feel so calming? Like if she just let herself truly listen, she would find herself somewhere safe somehow. No, that didn't make any sense. She forced her attention back to the present and focused on the readings for the station instead. That was real and something she could analyze.

Preliminary sensor returns arrived smoothly, without any lag or distortion. No shielding blocked scans of its mass, composition,

and power profile. The data streams layered cleanly, one over the other, forming a pattern that was very easy for her to read and interpret. All the signals were in the expected ranges. It had a stable orbit and predictable energy output.

Adora's shoulders loosened a notch as she took in numbers that made sense. They felt like relief.

She sensed Catra before she saw her. Catra had stopped beside the rail near the console. Her posture was alert despite the casual lean, tail held a bit too stiff to be truly relaxed. Her eyes flashed from the holographic displays to Adora and back.

"You know, most people are still asleep at this hour, right?" Catra kept her tone light. Her mouth curved into a familiar smirk, but her gaze lingered, showing a hint of concern in her dual-colored eyes. "So, you gonna tell me what's got you glued to the controls?"

"Sensors picked up a station," she started to explain. "It looks stable from the readings."

Catra's tail twitched again, and her ears suddenly swiveled. "Did you just open a channel?" Catra cut in.

"No." Adora had not. Her eyes flicked up to the console.

A blue waveform of transmission appeared across the magenta hologram, and the ship didn't even ask permission to patch it in before a calm, computerized voice echoed through the bridge. "Station docking bay open and ready."

Adora frowned, but didn't pull back from the console. "It's probably just triggered by us being nearby," she reasoned.

She straightened, decisiveness clear in the set of her shoulders. "We should dock," she said, then added, "Carefully, of course. We might learn something. If it's not safe… We'll leave right away."

The faint echo in her head faded beneath the comfort of controllable actions and predictable systems.

Catra pushed off the rail. “Fine. We dock. But I want suits sealed and ready.” Her eyes flicked back to the display. “And if it so much as breathes wrong, we’re gone.”

Corridor lights came on three at a time, then paused, then three more as they headed to the airlock. Adora refused to notice. The thrusters seemed to briefly echo the same three-note bursts. Adora forced herself to focus instead on the contents of the epoxy kit Catra had just grabbed off the shelf.

She analyzed its components, noting them aloud. “Okay, it’s got the resin, curing agent, mixing cup, and applicator. That should be everything we’d need.” Behind her, Catra’s tail was too still.

Catra had sunk to a bench and braced the cracked dome of Adora’s helmet between her knees. The reflection gleamed, showing her face, but slightly distorted. Adora mixed the chemicals, and Catra attentively applied the epoxy, sealing the hairline fracture as thoroughly as she could. The bead of epoxy lost its seam line as it adhered instantaneously and too cleanly.

They suited up carefully, orbiting each other almost magnetically. Adora reached for the waist seal, and Catra’s fingers were already there. Fingers tangled, then separated, then tangled again as they tried to decide who would lead.

Auto-lights brightened the space in a flash that made Adora blink and need to reset her hands. They both reached to tighten a strap, but Adora got there first, Catra’s touch a half-second behind. Adora hesitated for a moment, and Catra did as well, neither sure for that brief instant who should make the next adjustment.

Then, Catra pulled on and sealed a glove. Adora reached to check it, but the seal had already clicked shut, and her hand just

bumped the finished seam. Adora snapped a buckle, but Catra was still threading it.

Shoulders and hips brushed, but Adora seemed to move a bit off so that the movement turned to a soft collision.

Catra laughed under her breath and murmured, “We’re usually better at this.”

Adora replied a beat late, “Yeah.”

They pulled on their helmets, and their breath echoed across the comms, Adora’s in a controlled rhythm and Catra’s alongside it but out of sync.

Adora pulled up a display as they neared the station. Their approach vectors looked clear and uncomplicated, almost too perfect. They scanned the station one final time. No life signs present, no anomalies either. Power systems showed a low but steady output, like something idling patiently. External lights glowed at a steady intensity, like something waiting.

Adora said, “Good. If there was a problem, the sensors would show it.”

Catra replied with a tail flick, “Yeah, because sensors never lie.”

They docked. The airlock opened. They stepped through.

The station felt sterile and clean. It had smooth walls and panels that were well-maintained, though long unused. It had a crisp, metallic scent. There didn’t seem to be any magical presence. Adora’s shoulders fully loosened for the first time since the planet. She felt calm and content in the controlled environment.

“Guess we finally found somewhere that doesn’t want us dead. Low bar,” Catra muttered under her breath.

Adora stepped forward, taking charge immediately. Doors responded instantly, and lights brightened just ahead as she

moved through the station, almost as if it were politely acknowledging them. Catra followed at a half-pace behind. Their steps fell into a matched rhythm, and Adora thought they sounded unified, like a single person. Adora liked how they seemed to move as one and how the station seemed to respond in kind, its soft hum matching their gait.

Catra caught the gleam of the corridor in her visor as she listened to the sync of their footsteps. She knew their standard rhythm well. Now, they sounded like they were only pretending at alignment. She shortened her stride, and Adora seemed to instinctively slow hers as well. Then she sped up a half beat, and Adora's pace increased in tandem. Their steps didn't drift apart. It was almost like they were being conducted. Three soft impacts, a pause and three again.

Flickers of light appeared along a pristine metal wall, sliding away whenever Catra didn't look directly at them. For a second, the rhythm synced with her own heartbeat. Her stomach dropped.

She should say something to Adora. Catra swallowed hard, but didn't speak. The flickers at the edges of her vision dimmed almost as if they approved of her silence. Still, her jaw tightened almost imperceptibly.

Catra inhaled, and the air arrived a fraction of a second delayed. In the glossy paneling of the corridor, she caught her reflection, but her tail didn't seem to appear unless she concentrated. Catra leaned in closer. For a moment, the panel showed Adora's eyes instead of hers, luminous blue and vibrating with song. Then the image snapped back to Catra's own wary stare. She exhaled, blamed the light, and carried on.

Catra let her gaze slide from the walls and onto Adora. She noticed the set of Adora's shoulders, the way she moved like she belonged in here. She didn't seem to notice any of the oddities. Catra tuned her ears to Adora's breathing in the comms, steady and controlled, and matched it.

Catra almost reached for her, resting her worn glove on her shoulder. Instead, her hands stayed by her sides. She didn't want to be the reason Adora suddenly became rigid and anxious, the cause of eroding her confidence and surety over something Catra couldn't even fully grasp. That was just an ill-defined feeling, really.

"This is some aggressively polite lighting," Catra tried for levity.

Adora didn't turn, just hummed agreement in that focused way she did when she was cataloging details and pretending that made her safe.

Adora kept moving. It felt easy enough to move through the station. Every time she made a decision, it seemed to meet her halfway. Doors cycled open just as she decided to go through them. Lights brightened each corridor she chose, though never harshly. The whole station felt calm and orderly. Good systems, good luck, that was all it was, she told herself.

Small bits of the song from the planet stayed in the back of her thoughts, mostly unnoticed. Though every time she felt a more intense feeling, like a flicker of fear or the quiet tenderness of realizing Catra was right behind her, it would flare a bit again, not loud, but still there.

Adora focused back on her mission of learning about the station, and it faded away once more. Catra's boots stayed close enough behind her that she could always hear their reassuring rhythm echoing her own. She glanced back anyway.

"You good?" she asked.

There was a delay before Catra answered as if the words had to travel through something more than usual. "Yeah."

Adora felt a slight hint of discomfort at the delay, the song strengthening for a moment before she focused her attention back on the station.

A thin crackle sounded across the comms, and a small broken voice cut through with just an initial syllable.

Adora stopped walking, and the notes in her head flared as if trying to distract her.

Catra spoke up, “I heard that too. I think it came from there.” She pointed to a maintenance intercom almost completely hidden in shadow.

Adora stepped toward it and forced it open, and the full message played. “... it isn’t outside... it's not... not outside. It’s in. It’s inside. Not it. Me. Me. Me.”

The station hummed briefly, aligned with the words me me me as if trying to drown them out.

Adora’s gloved fingers stayed braced on the pried-open panel. She stared at the darkened intercom for a moment. Her breath caught, just briefly, and then she exhaled slowly, settling it back to a more natural rhythm.

“Sounds like someone who didn’t understand their own magic,” she said, crisp and matter-of-fact, like naming it correctly would pin it down. She needed it to be something rational.

Catra didn’t move. Her ears were angled forward in her helmet as if listening to echoes that weren’t there anymore. “Sounds like someone who was scared.”

Adora shrugged, “Same thing.” The corridor lights brightened a bit, as if pleased with her conclusion.

Catra’s tail bottle-brushed, and her gaze flicked to Adora sharply before she looked down and muttered, “…Not really.”

Adora didn’t answer Catra’s murmurs. A maintenance panel a few steps down the corridor had pulsed to life. A calm, computerized voice echoed, “External signal interference detected. Channel calibration needed.”

Adora felt some tension drain as she focused on something where she could assist properly. She quickly stepped toward it. She tapped the interface and implemented the needed signal calibration levels to bring it in line.

It was just a minor adjustment, but it felt oddly satisfying. Green indicators bloomed along the panel. The calm, computerized voice echoed once more, “Channel stabilized. Noise reduction optimal.”

A final confirmation chimed, three notes, crisp and bright. They should have reminded Adora of the song, but somehow they didn’t. They felt right.

“This is good,” Adora said reassuringly. “This is working.”

Behind her, Catra shifted quickly. Adora could hear the change in her stance from the sudden scuff of her boot and flick of her tail.

“Yay, the station likes you. It’ll probably give you a medal next.” Catra’s sarcasm was clear.

It felt familiar to Adora, and her shoulders stayed loose. The station seemed to match her calm as the lights softened. Adora led them down the next corridor, and they found that they had looped back to the docking port.

A message panel on the wall flashed: “DUAL-SUBJECT COHERENCE: STABLE.”

“Love that it’s grading our relationship now.” Catra joked. She smirked outwardly, even as she felt the slightest tightening in her chest.

The station hum softened, almost pleased. The docking area glowed a calming, pleasant green. They stepped back into the airlock of their own ship.

Catra’s instincts felt sanded down. The relief felt earned. Her shoulders stayed soft.

“We handled that,” Adora said, her posture leaning slightly longingly back toward the airlock like something inside her still wanted to be on the station.

“Yeah. We did.” Catra answered.

As the airlock door closed behind them, Catra caught a glint of light at the edge of her vision but didn’t let herself focus on it.

They removed their helmets and let them fall to the bench, the echoing thuds in sync. As she headed back out toward the bridge, Catra glimpsed the dome of Adora's. A flicker of light reflected off the epoxy, and the fracture underneath was widening microscopically, breathing.

Chapter 4: Reflectance

Chapter Summary

> Reflections lag. Rhythms tighten. The quiet begins to feel rehearsed.

Catra padded across the bridge, catching herself in the mirror of the bulkhead, tail mid-swish and ears half flat. The slightly blurred image seemed to finish the tail flick a moment late. She blinked and saw another micro delay before her reflection completed the motion.

She paused, feeling a sense of being watched, not by Adora or their own ship, but by something else. Her claws released, but she curled them back in. The ship had settled into its standard hum and vent rattle. Warm and familiar amber-pink lights made the deck glow, but something still felt off.

Glancing further behind, she noted Adora already leaning over the console. She was running a systems check and making adjustments that didn't even need adjusting. The ship's lights illuminated more brightly wherever she directed her hands in a way that felt too synced to be ordinary.

"Guess we'll just skip lunch while you cozy up with the oddly glowing console." Catra teased.

"I'll eat in a minute," Adora said without looking up.

Catra rolled her eyes. Then, she noticed the three-beat pulse persisting faintly in the ambient hum of the ship.

"You hear that?" Catra asked.

"Hear what?" Adora replied, still not looking up from her diagnostics.

“Nothing. Just the universe keeping its odd tempo again.” Her tail coiled around her ankle. “I’ll be in the galley negotiating with our rations.”

As she headed there, she wondered for a moment if she was just imagining the rhythm and the delayed reflections. She tried to count under her breath along with the rhythmic hum. “One, two, three..” A system chime swallowed her four. Not disconcerting at all.

She caught her reflection again in the metallic sheen of the galley counter. She tilted her head, and it tilted back a half-second behind. She lifted her arm, and it did so with pause. Each movement was just slightly delayed. Catra’s concern ratcheted. Her breath quickened in her chest, and her pulse began to race.

Catra couldn’t help but wonder if this rhythm was starting to actually throw her off. Could it start syncing with her body unwillingly? Would it affect her combat timing? If she were suddenly off her game, she might not be able to keep them safe when needed. That terrified her.

Her mirrored self looked eerily calm. For a moment, she stood in sync with it, watching herself watching. Catra hated that it looked more stable than she felt. It didn’t lash its tail. It didn’t clench its hands into fists, claws just barely restrained. It didn’t fight against the wrong rhythm.

Is that what Adora saw in her now? A too-silent version of the person who’d once clawed for her? Someone easier to be near, but too quiet to truly love.

Her reflection just watched, like a silent judge of her thoughts. It didn’t worry about Adora. It didn’t ask questions. Catra suddenly hated it. Hated how it refused to feel.

The air recycler shifted on, and a woody-sweet scent drifted in from the vents instead of the usual citrusy disinfectant tang. It felt

off yet eerily familiar to Catra. Her tail wrapped tighter around her ankle. She tried to busy herself with fixing their lunch.

The dehydrated protein cubes were stacked in perfect formations in their container. Catra reached forward, but for a moment her hand didn't respond quite right. Her fingers curled differently than her intent. She tried to pull a protein cube off the top of the stack, but it stuck inconveniently. She narrowed her eyes. That seemed a bit odd. She was too hungry to care. She didn't have the energy to fight a food dispenser designed by someone with control issues.

Frustrated, she clawed the stack apart. In the reflection on the counter, the cubes tumbled and froze in mid-air, quivering like paused holo-frames. The lights flickered. Her tail lashed. She didn't need more signs. She just needed Adora to stop focusing on the ship's normal functions and start paying attention to everything else that was happening around them.

Out on the bridge, Adora flitted between panels, checking systems that all seemed stable enough. Still, it felt good to make sure everything was in the proper working order, that their ship was functioning fully optimally. She just wanted to keep them safe, prevent any issues from springing up unexpectedly. It also helped to keep her thoughts at bay.

The song still lingered at the back of her mind. It scared her a bit that it was always there, though she thought she could contain it if she tried to understand it, to analyze what it wanted. Still, there was something just a bit uneasy about its near-constant presence.

It strengthened now as if sensing her moment of unease. Its soft rhythmic hum lulling her back to a state of calm and control. It was like a wave of warm comfort that relaxed her from the hairs on her head to the tips of her toes. She leaned back toward the nearest panel, running one more diagnostic check just to be sure everything was in order

Catra approached Adora, carrying two warmed mugs in one hand. She reached with her other arm to give her a quick squeeze. Catra noticed Adora veered a bit toward the side, like she couldn't quite pull her focus from the panel. Catra placed a mug of rehydrated stew into her hand.

“Don’t worry, the mug's not tracking your biometrics yet, but drink up before it decides to start,” Catra teased, though her concern showed through.

“Thanks,” Adora replied, still only half paying attention.

Catra hesitated. She almost reached for Adora’s hand, but saw that Adora’s gaze was still locked on the panel like it might whisper the meaning of life if she just kept focused on it for long enough. Instead, Catra wrapped her arm around her own middle and said nothing. Their breaths fell out of sync, and Catra restrained her instinct to correct their mismatch.

She remembered how they used to calibrate repair systems together, elbows brushing, tools passed without asking. Their natural rhythm had felt like home. One time, Adora had looked over at her with that perfectly sappy smile and said quietly, “You always know what I need before I even do.”

Now, Catra wasn’t sure she could even reach for her without breaking something.

“We’re okay, right?” Catra asked softly, and the lights flickered.

“Everything’s fine,” Adora answered too smoothly, the lights stabilizing to that warm amber-pink glow.

Between sips and panel adjustments, Adora hummed the three-note tune absentmindedly.

“Just something stuck in my head,” she noted aloud.

Catra went stick-still at her side. She noticed the floor vibrating in sync with her hum. Catra tapped the wall. No echo. Her tail lashed

before the unease had even stirred in her. She stared at it for a second and then willed herself to deliberately still it.

Adora had set down her mug and started on more calibrations on the nearby panel. Catra noticed that the ship's lighting seemed to brighten wherever she stepped, whereas it stayed dimmed around her as she took in each oddity with unease.

Adora told herself she just needed to keep her focus on optimizing the ship. If she just made sure it was functioning at full capacity, it would keep them safe in this unknown sector of space. She leaned into her work, not letting other thoughts or fears in. She barely even noticed Catra beside her now.

The song in her head had modulated a bit, tempo slowed a little, in a way that felt like it was synching to her needs, helping her to stay calm and focused. She was starting to feel like the song understood her.

Then, for a moment, the song faded a bit, and her balance shifted. She didn't stumble, but she felt a bit light on her feet. The artificial gravity of the ship was still there, but the missing beats of the song she'd started to rely on made her feel unsteady.

She reached a hand out to grip the wall, but before she made contact, the rhythm returned. The song felt like it was cradling her in warmth. It hummed a breath just beneath her lungs, a steady pulse and promise. The thrusters stabilized, the lights brightened, and her footing felt solid once more.

Adora exhaled and smiled broadly. It wasn't a smile she'd planned. It had just arrived, automatic and sure. She felt suddenly so in control. The hum of the song made her feel so stable, almost empowered, like she sometimes felt in her She-Ra form. She knew, distantly, that the comfort wasn't fully hers, but it didn't matter. It felt good.

Catra didn't return her smile. No, her ears flattened, and she folded her arms around her ribs even tighter. She retreated further

into the shadowed area that the lights refused to illuminate.

She noticed how the ship seemed to soften around Adora like it knew her almost intimately. It moved with her now in step, in breath, in thought. Catra told herself it was stupid to be jealous of the bridge's glow, but the feeling stayed with her anyway.

Her thoughts swirled further. It seemed like Adora was becoming more attuned to whatever this rhythm was, and it disturbed her. For Adora's own safety, of course, but also for how it made her feel pushed out.

Also, what if this weird syncing was just another iteration of Adora putting herself second… and something else first? Was Adora still in control of herself?

Maybe the ship was right to keep her in shadow. She didn't even know how to help. She felt like no matter what she said, it would just be ignored or worse, provoke a fight.

She wanted to just grab her hand, to shake her out of it. But what if Adora pulled away? What if she didn't even notice? Or what if she just smiled gently and then kept humming like Catra was the one out of sync?

She decided it was better to support Adora with silence or her usual humor.

She clamped her thoughts behind a smirk and said, "Tell the lights I say hi from over here."

A nearby vent exhaled a single airy hiss that sounded remarkably like a snicker. Catra's ears flicked, and her smirk faltered. The sound died out the moment she focused on it.

Adora had moved back over to the main console. "What's this?" she asked aloud.

Catra took a step closer and saw a new jump coordinate burned into the nav path display. "We didn't enter that," she replied with

mounting unease.

“It might be a lead,” Adora said thoughtfully.

“We shouldn’t,” Catra insisted with a frown, not liking how things had been progressing since the last planet and the station.

“We have to know,” Adora asserted, her fingers now hovering near the display’s confirmation button.

“It might be everything we should be trying to avoid,” Catra added warily. She felt her unease like a warning in her bones. The floor hummed in three-beat pulses. “Please wait. Don’t touch it.”

Catra reached out a hovering hand, but before either of their fingers hit against the console, a message appeared: “Coordinates Locked.”

The thrusters started to ramp as the ship jumped on its own as if it heard Adora’s internal need to fix things. It should’ve felt normal. Catra had been through dozens of jumps before. This time, though, it caught her off balance. Her stomach twisted. The ship kept moving, not caring if she was ready.

Catra looked over at Adora. She didn’t look shocked, just curious and thoughtful. She heard Adora humming the three-note beat to herself, as if she took comfort in its surety.

The ship hadn’t overridden Adora, Catra realized. It had obeyed her more perfectly than Catra ever could.

She glanced around the bridge uneasily. Her gaze caught on Adora’s helmet on the bench outside the airlock, reflected in the metal of the bulkhead. The mirrored image showed the crack overtaking the visor in thin jagged lines. She glanced back at the actual helmet and saw the epoxy still held in the real world, but Catra knew now the song was no longer just sound in Adora’s head, but that it was using her.

Worse, Catra realized that she did not know how to interrupt the syncing. At least not without becoming the monster that she feared she was. Her instincts and sharpness seemed like they'd just accelerate the damage and truly fracture what existed between them.

Catra's tail was still vibrating as the rumble of the thrusters intensified beneath her feet, the ship answering a command neither of them ever truly gave it. Her reflection glinted in the console. The eyes didn't narrow when hers narrowed. The tail didn't twitch when hers twitched. It just watched her, completely still. She questioned for a moment, which one was the real version of her?

And then, just before she turned away, the reflection smiled. Neither cruel nor kind, but a smile of understanding. Like it already accepted what she hadn't. Catra's claws extended before she even realized she was afraid.

Chapter 5: Reverberance

Chapter Summary

> They arrive on a moon too like a mirror, where stillness might become the final trap.

The surface of the moon shimmered, soft waves of rippling light trembling just above the ground like a barely visible desert haze. It seemed almost like the dusty terrain was trying too hard to stay contained. Catra's claws tightened in her gloves, but she kept them retracted as she stared out the open airlock door.

The land below stretched flat and endless, its surface a mirrored silver. It seemed too pristine, too vast. It had an unsettling, almost welcoming glow, like it was greeting her. There was no wind, but a sensation, something like breathing. A synthetic, almost manufactured, scent lingered in the air.

"You ready?" Adora's voice rang out across the comm, already halfway down the ramp. She moved effortlessly, shoulders loose and boots stepping forward with easy confidence. It was like she was only reassured by what she saw and not at all wary.

Catra followed, each step deliberate and forced. The ramp vibrated beneath her boots. Don't stare at the horizon she told herself. Don't think about how still and endless it seems. Yet she looked out anyway, and she felt the surface peering back, slightly rippling and patient, almost like it could see her.

Her instincts screamed that exposed could soon be dead. That something this welcoming had to want something in return. She reached the bottom of the ramp and forced her breathing steady.

Beside her, Adora was already scanning the terrain. The surface rippled toward her as if curious. Adora seemed assured and certain as she stepped forward, leaving a trail of footprints behind

her in the too-smooth dust. Adora was bathed in light from above, whereas it seemed to stay just a bit off of herself.

Catra pressed a foot into the dusty surface and lifted it to find nothing, no indentation or imprint. It was like the moon was erasing her actions from existence, step by step. She watched a ripple pass across the landscape, seemingly originating from where she stood. Had the moon felt her jaw tighten, her shoulders draw in? Was it responding to her?

She took another step. It left no mark. She hated that she'd expected it to leave one somehow.

Adora had knelt to examine the surface, her tracker pad taking in data. "Nothing out of the ordinary so far," she noted aloud. "Typical readings for a small moon. We should be able to…"

"Should be able to what?" Catra cut in. "Walk around endlessly until it decides what it wants with us?" The shadows seemed to deepen around her.

"No," Adora replied. "We try to take samples and measurements. See what we can find. Maybe we can learn something here."

"You think if you just measure it enough, it will make sense?" Catra asked incredulously.

"I think gathering data will help us to understand an unknown environment," Adora insisted.

Catra stayed quiet, and the light suddenly lit up all around her. Catra caught her reflection in the shiny surface beneath her feet. Its claws were out and elongated. Its fangs were too sharp and distended.

She stumbled away from it, and when she looked back, the reflection lunged. Claws extended toward Adora, who flinched and raised her arms to shield herself. The expression on her face was the familiar look of disappointed betrayal that Catra had seen too

often in the worst moments of her past and had hoped never to see again.

The reflected figures flickered and disappeared, and the light around her receded as quickly as it had appeared. Catra glanced up at the real Adora, who was still staring at her tracker pad and undisturbed. It was just an illusion. She steadied her breathing and stilled her lashing tail.

Then, hidden in the deepest shadow, Catra saw letters etched into the ground, seemingly burned in with some type of magic. The silvery dust swirled around the letters, constantly trying to obscure them, but Catra was able to make out the words: IT LEARNS FROM YOU.

Someone had been here before. They had obviously worked hard to leave that message behind for a reason. Catra was sure it was a warning about what they faced now.

Adora was still busy adjusting the tracker pad. It seemed futile to try and discuss any of what she saw with her when Adora just could not seem to see any of it at all. Adora's shoulders were set in that familiar angle of determination. Catra could tell she was trying to solve and master the situation in that way she always did. Bits of silver dust had started to collect in the epoxied fissure of Adora's helmet.

The gravity shifted. It started like a steady drag on Catra's boots. With each adjustment Adora made, the environment around them seemed to be reacting. Adora pressed the tracker pad, and the atmosphere around them pressed back. The gravity and air pressure increased significantly against their suits.

"Adora, stop," Catra said, her tone soft, but insistent. The dust began to vibrate in harmonic ripples around their feet.

Adora kept making adjustments, and the environment kept intensifying around them.

“Just stop already,” Catra said with more irritation. The dust began to swirl in shimmering waves.

Adora kept tapping the pad, seemingly trying to compensate and either too focused or too unwilling to hear Catra’s agitation.

“Stop trying to fix it!” The words tore out of Catra, louder than she’d meant, coming out in a frustrated, angry growl.

Adora glanced up then, wide-eyed. “Catra…”

The ground between them shook with a loud rumbling roar, like the amplified reverberation of Catra’s growl, same frequency and all. The mirrored dust beneath them began to distort and shift. Suddenly, the flat plane of the terrain was no longer flat.

Walls rose out of nowhere, separating them.
They were twenty feet tall with a metallic sheen. They had shot up in the span of a breath. One moment, they had been a pace away from one another, and now a corridor of mirrored surfaces caged Catra in on all sides.

“Adora!” Catra shouted as she slammed her palms against the solid wall between them. “Adora, can you hear me?”

Static hissed over the comm, then Adora’s voice, distant and broken, “…it’s solid… I’ll figure it… just stay…” Then only silence.

Catra pressed her forehead to the warm, newly formed metal. Her breath fogged the surface, then it immediately evaporated. It was as if the wall had sucked it in. Her claws scraped desperately, uselessly against the smooth surface, leaving no marks.

She had caused this. It had clearly reacted to her angry outburst. The moon had learned that she was dangerous, that she destroyed things. So, it had decided that she should be contained. Maybe Adora really was safer with the magic than with her?

The guilt hit her like a physical blow, and Catra curled in on herself and slid down against the side of the wall, making herself

smaller, lesser. Her tail lashed wildly, thumping against the wall repeatedly. With each impact, the corridor twisted. Walls folded in on themselves, creating new maze-like passageways. She was reshaping this prison with her every motion of panic and anger. Though the main wall separating her from Adora remained firmly in place.

“No,” she whispered, “No, no, no, no, no.”

Light gleamed off the shiny walls too brightly. The echo of her own voice reverberated through the corridor. Its sound was far too sharp in her flattened ears.

She took a deep breath in and forced her claws to retract, forced her tail to still. The transformation stopped, metal walls now motionless and mirrored all around her. Catra stood up and hugged her arms around herself as she began to walk slowly forward.

The maze felt too perfect. The walls were polished to a silver sheen with no seams. Catra avoided touching them now, keeping her elbows tucked in tight. She glanced down and saw that she cast no trailing shadow. She was completely alone. Not even a shadow wanted to cling to someone like her. Someone who damaged everything they loved over and over in the worst pattern imaginable.

A hum began in her ears, three soft notes and a pause, then three more. She let herself listen to it now like she never had before. She had always noticed it before with wary unease and resisted it so strongly. Now, though, exhausted from the release of her anger and the surge of her guilt, it started to sound like a soothing lullaby.

The agitation that had been with her since they’d landed began to drain away. The absence was seductive. No feelings of guilt or fear overwhelmed her. No visions of Adora’s disappointed eyes watched her ruin everything, ruin them.

The last of her anger guttered out of her like a snuffed candle, and she felt a calm and content feeling take its place. A wave of warmth filled her now, a sensation like a comforting hand softly stroking along her tail, her fur. She thought she could stay here for a while now, just be still and safe. At least she wouldn't hurt anyone if she just stayed still. Maybe stillness could be strength too.

She sank down onto the dusty ground and let herself just breathe deeply and hum along with those three peaceful notes. She felt them syncing rhythmically with her heartbeat. Her jaw no longer ached from clenching. Her tail lingered against the silvery dust, and she couldn't quite feel where the tip of it ended, and the surface of the moon began.

The dust vibrated in time with her pulse, settling into the seams of her suit. She was no longer thinking about how to escape, but just how to stay content. She felt like she was no longer a failure.

…

Adora's palms had flattened against the barrier just after it had appeared, cutting her off so suddenly from Catra. She had begun immediately to focus on analyzing what she might be able to control. The hum in her ears had kept her calm and focused.

She had heard Catra call out for her over the comm, and she had tried to reply confidently that she would fix this before the line went to full static.

Then, soft tones vibrating consistently in her ear, Adora had focused once more on gathering information on their current situation. She wasn't too worried. She was sure she could fix this. She walked slowly through the mirrored corridors, tracker pad in hand. No sense of fear or urgency, but just a calm confidence that she would find Catra soon.

Adora scanned constantly with the tracker pad. She studied its feeds as she continued to slowly traverse the maze, mapping it

and working toward a plan. Then, in a glassy section of the wall, she saw her.

Catra seemed suspended, almost held. The silver dust cradled her sitting form. Her eyes were open but seemed almost vacant, unseeing and just reflecting back shimmering light. Her tail was completely listless.

That didn't seem right. Catra was usually so vibrant, so alive, not ever so lifeless and still. The hum smoothed over Adora's own thoughts. No, Catra seemed solved, fixed, not a problem.

Catra's chest rose and fell in a perfect rhythm, synchronized to the three notes Adora continued to hear humming in her own mind. Catra's safe, she thought to herself. She doesn't need me. She's perfectly at ease, peaceful. The hum became more melodic as if in agreement. Adora's jaw unclenched, and a warmth flooded her chest, a feeling of relief, like setting down a weight it felt like she'd been carrying for so long she'd forgotten it was heavy.

Still, her hand rose and hovered by the glassy wall right beside the tranquil, empty version of Catra. Something stirred in Adora. Memory of seeing Catra too calm, falsely at peace, once before, her hair slicked back, her eyes glowing green. Suddenly, this felt terribly, eerily similar. The pulse of the song in her ear now seemed discordant.

Her heart raced, and her shoulders tightened. Then Adora's eyes began to glow as she reached her hand out and punched her sword into existence. "For the honor of Greyskull." The words rang out, like a promise instead of a battle cry.

The hum tried to surge, but it was drowned out as a stream of inner light burst forth. Her form extended outward, muscles rippling, hair flowing. Golden armor suddenly appeared around her as She-Ra emerged from within her.

The swing of her sword was desperate as it hit against the glassy surface. The blade vibrated as Adora willed her magic to flow

outward more forcefully. She released a resonant, guttural shout that broke out against the ever-persistent, rhythmic hum in her ears.

The barrier didn't shatter. It unraveled, threads of mirrored metal recoiling from the sword's magic. She reached toward Catra and pulled her through. She-Ra's glowing fingers grasped around Catra's worn glove.

"Adora?" Catra gasped, almost like coming out of a trance, stumbling a bit as she tried to gain her footing.

"I've got you," Adora said, her voice rough.

Catra swayed on her feet, and Adora kept an arm firmly around her waist.

The terrain around them writhed, then collapsed briefly, revealing the raw, pulsing magic below. The walls had reabsorbed as suddenly as they had initially appeared. The moon was silent now, the dust once more stretching still and flat to the horizon. The ripple that moved across it seemed almost like a curtain call bow, a release.

Their ship waited nearby. Its ramp lowered, and they quickly headed toward it. Footprints marked the silver behind them, two trails now, uneven and pressing deep.

"I don't think it wanted to hurt us exactly," Adora said aloud, but more to herself. The notes in her ears quietly sounded in agreement.

Catra just hummed softly along to that same rhythm.

Adora hesitated to let her go. They staggered up the ramp together, traces of silver dust embedded in the seams of their gloves and suits. As the airlock shut, Adora glanced back one last time. The moon's surface shimmered brightly, falsely calm.

Chapter 6: Acquiescence

Chapter Summary

> Perfect waveforms merge in sync, but the ship corrects for variance.

Vents released a soft gust of warm citrus-infused air, like an exhale, just enough to brush the curve of Adora's cheek before her eyes opened. Dim amber-pink lights cast the room in a faint, pleasant glow as Adora slowly awoke. The light flowed softly across the walls, highlighting the edges of the furniture with glints of rose gold.

The hum that never stopped vibrated low and sure in her ears, gentle and insistent. Its three-beat rhythm was like a second heartbeat that didn't quite belong to her but comforted her anyway, a steadying presence. Adora blinked up at the ceiling, unable to remember her dream. Maybe there hadn't been one. It didn't matter. She felt the hum, the steadiness. As she slid her feet off the bed, the floor felt warm like a welcome.

Her gaze locked onto Catra, still tangled in the sheets. Her chest rose and fell in perfect rhythm. Asleep, she looked too still in a way that echoed the moon trance. Adora's stomach clenched at the memory. Then, the hum rose soothingly in her mind, and the feeling passed. Her thoughts smoothed over. Catra was fine, just sleeping still. Adora would let her rest. She needed it. Her hand, which had momentarily hovered over Catra's shoulder, dropped to her own side.

Catra half-stirred, and her tail curled gently around Adora's wrist, light and grounding. The contact was brief, but Adora's whole body eased in response, relief blooming warm in her chest. The amber-pink lights softened. The ship chimed three bright notes. They were gentle and encouraging, like a hand at the small of her back, urging her forward.

A small smile appeared as Adora pushed off the bed and headed toward the bridge. Her steps were steady, almost guided. The hum rose again, melodic and pleased. There was work to do to keep the ship in order. The light followed her steps, soft and approving. She told herself she'd check on Catra again later. Right now, the bridge needed her.

Adora opened a systems panel for a quick, standard diagnostic. She reached out to make a small adjustment, and the screen blinked once, and the lighted pathways faded to dark beneath her touch. Her brows furrowed. That wasn't supposed to happen. She tapped a reset key, but nothing changed. The panel stayed stubbornly dark.

Adora hesitated. Catra would know what to try next. She should call for her. She started to turn back towards the door, words already starting to form in her mind.

Then, the hum in her ear shifted. A discordant tone, like disapproval, that then smoothed into a more familiar soothing rhythm. Adora refocused on the panel. "Okay," she murmured to herself, "I can fix this."

Fingers moved with focused intent, running along each darkened path, checking for any faults. It had to be something simple. She just wasn't seeing it yet. A warm gust from the nearby vent flowed over her hands like encouragement.

The diagnostic readout flickered briefly, stating power flow: steady and signal strength: optimal. Still, the panel lights stayed black. Adora's frown deepened, and her jaw tightened. Her hands moved again, more precise and exacting as they traced every unlit pathway, trying to figure out how to recalibrate it somehow. Trying to see what she was missing.

Behind her, she heard the door open with a soft whoosh and the soft pad of Catra's bare feet entering.

"I'm fine," Adora responded reflexively without looking up.

Catra didn’t answer. She just reached forward. With a soft stroke of her finger along a darkened pathway, she reseated a connection, and the whole panel lit up once more, as good as new.

The bridge lights flickered briefly. The diagnostic panel flashed: "Dependency event logged."

Adora’s stomach tightened as she read it. The word dependency echoed through her mind, hitting somewhere deep, the place where all her old failures lived. She had fallen short.

She caught her reflection in the dark metal of the bulkhead just beside the panel. It lagged half a second, then showed her with shoulders straighter, jaw tighter, eyes emptier. It was a version of her that was strong and unbothered, that never faltered and never needed help.

Adora pulled back and repeated, “I’m fine.” Her tone was flat, almost harsh.

Her fingers moved back to the now functioning panel. She frantically adjusted settings that didn’t need adjustment. She needed to prove to herself that she knew what to do on her own. She needed to try and ease the guilt lapping at the edges of her thoughts, telling her that she hadn't been enough. There was a weight now in her chest, making her feel like she hadn't been able to fix something so obvious, and what did that say about her?

The ship spoke out then, its voice soothing and calm, "Dual-subject functionality below optimal. Attunement exercises available."

Adora felt instant relief. The tension drained from her shoulders. This felt like clarity, like structure, like doing something right.

Catra lingered at Adora’s side. She had spent the night in deep, dreamless sleep as far as she could tell and had woken and been drawn to the bridge with a sense that Adora had needed her.

Though Adora now seemed distant and had barely even acknowledged her presence.

Catra's arms were loosely crossed, her tail curling a bit around one ankle. Her suspicion had started to rise, but then the hum at the back of her mind pulsed, steady and warming from within, sanding her edginess back down.

The word, dual-subject, appealed to her. It sounded like togetherness and belonging.
Something tender flickered in her chest. The ship was including her again, and she found she wanted that. She wanted to no longer be an outsider watching Adora spiral, but a partner.

The bridge transformed subtly around them. Lights brightened two softly glowing spots along the floor. Their biometrics appeared on the center holographic screen as two vibrating waveforms. Hers pulsing beside Adora's, not quite in sync, but trying.

Catra raised an eyebrow and muttered under her breath, "Are we being graded now?"

Her waveform twitched sharply, a peak going red. Her tail lashed once and then wrapped tight around her leg, pulling herself back in line. She stayed inside her circle of light.

She glanced over at Adora, who waited in her own spot, said nothing and looked very eager to get started. The way Adora stood, almost serene, was comforting, and yet it scared her just a bit. She caught a glimpse of her own reflection in the polished floor, and instead of her wary features, she saw herself mirroring Adora's, docile and agreeable.

The ship's voice spoke again, smooth as ever, "Attunement initiation: breathing sequence. Inhale on first tone, hold, then exhale on second tone."

Chimes sounded, soft bell-like notes, timed evenly.

Adora was already breathing in sync perfectly before the second chime had fully materialized, like there was no effort to it at all.

For Catra, the rhythm was harder to match. Her tail wanted to twitch. Her breath caught for a moment before it fell into sync.

As soon as her breath was in rhythm with Adora's, their waveforms aligned, and her body softened. The lights brightened across the bridge gently, and a warm pulse of air drifted in from the vents. Catra's tail gave a calm swish. It felt like they had done something right. She glanced over at Adora, expecting a glance or smile, maybe. Adora, though, stayed eyes fixed forward, calm and steady.

Between the series of chimes and breaths, the ship's soothing voice interjected, "Maintain focus. Disregard all external anomalies. Do not interrupt the calibration."

Adora obeyed easily and without any hesitation. Her breaths were perfectly timed to each tone. Her waveform peaked, steadied, and became ever more beautiful on the screen.

Catra murmured lowly, "What is this measuring?"

Her claws flexed before she'd even realized it. One pierced the inside of her palm just enough to sting. She quickly tucked her hand under her arm to hide it, forcing her fingers straight.

Her waveform dipped instantly and flickered for a moment. Warmth withdrew from her side of the room like a tide going out, like it was shifting attention away from her. The thought that she always seemed to ruin things hit her sharply, and she instantly stilled.

She refocused on Adora, matching her breath to hers. It felt familiar, like muscle memory. The hum in her ear eased the urge to question or push. Her waveform stabilized, and the lights warmed on her side again. She realized how cold she'd been for so long, just trying not to admit it. The warmth settled around her shoulders like a tucked blanket.

Their waveforms synced perfectly now. Catra knew she had bought the sync and the warmth by staying silent, and it still felt good. She realized she was starting to chase the warmth, the affection of the ship… and Adora, in the same way she'd always chased approval. She hated herself for how good it felt to feel connected again after the strain of being pushed out.

Deep down, Catra knew it was just like the Fright Zone all over again. She'd learned to crave affection there, too, learned it was scarce, and had to be chased after. She had done this so many times before, and where had it led? Always with some sort of betrayal or manipulation. Yet, now it felt harder than ever to resist. The hum felt so soothing in her ears. The ship was offering her everything she wanted if she just didn't question it.

The ship announced smoothly: "Dual-subject functionality optimized."

Catra felt a hollowed-out kind of calm fill her. Her shoulders slumped the tiniest bit, like her spine had forgotten her defiance.

Adora straightened, her posture radiant with quiet satisfaction, almost glowing with a sense of accomplishment. She was finally doing something right.

"That worked," she said, exhaling like she'd just solved something important.

She felt the steadiness of her She-Ra form without the transformation. Like a sense of inner equilibrium had arrived and stayed.

The ship's display showed their perfect sync score in gentle gold. Their waveforms merged into a single, perfect sine wave.

For a moment, Adora couldn't tell which heartbeat was hers and which was the hum's rhythm, and it didn't matter, because they were both so steady.

Additional data scrolled quietly across the screen. Their pulse rates, cortisol levels, and neural patterns flashed below the synced waveform. Beneath that, a new log entry: "Operator unreliability: corrected. Disruptive variance reduced."

Adora's brows furrowed just slightly as she took that message in. Operator? Which one? Her breath hitched, and her gaze flicked to Catra. Was that her? Or was the unreliability her own moment of hesitation earlier when she'd almost asked for help? Was it both?

Corrected how? she wondered. Adora's skin went cold for one second despite the warmth of the lights. Reduced to what?

Her eyes flicked away from the screen and landed on her helmet resting on the bench by the airlock door. The epoxied surface shimmered with silver. The sight of it gave her a brief, disoriented pause. She hadn't worn it since the moon. It felt heavy to look at, like it belonged to someone else.

"Hey," Catra's voice called out hesitantly, "Did you see…"

A soft chime interrupted. The ship's voice returned, warm and smooth, "Session complete."

Adora's mouth had opened. She didn't know what she had meant to say. The chime had stopped her anyway.

The vents exhaled another pleasant wave of warmth. Three bright tones rose in rhythm in her ears. Adora's shoulders eased. The concern in her chest unraveled. The message on the screen no longer seemed important.

Catra said no more.

The ship crooned softly through the bridge speakers, "Individualized validation recommended. Separation protocol queued. Comms-disrupted diagnostic pending."

Catra's tail tapped the floor once. Then again. Then a third time.

Adora smiled, a small contented curve of her mouth, like everything was finally making sense. She didn't notice Catra hadn't smiled.

The synced waveform faded from the display. Two separate waveforms blinked now in its place, quietly drifting out of phase. There was no warning or alarm. It was just data, and Adora barely even registered it.

The lights steadied to a satisfying, gentle glow. The hum remained soft and steady. A wave of warm air from the vents brushed against her shoulders ever so comfortingly.

Chapter 7: Severance

Chapter Summary

> They are divided to optimize. What does it take for each to remain sufficient?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The hum in her ear turned from melodic to a faint staticky hiss like the low-level buzz of multiple interwoven electronic frequencies overlaid and melding together into a flat white noise. Catra blinked and turned her head towards the source of the sound, though she knew better. There wasn't a source, not really.

The bridge was still bathed in its soft, approving amber-pink glow. She noticed Adora stood near the console again, like she'd been drawn there. Her posture was relaxed, her breathing even. The synchronization data had faded from the screen. All that remained was the steadily flickering interface. Three beats followed by a pause, three beats and then still. It wasn't a countdown. It was a pattern.

The hum shifted again in her ears, reassuring and persuasive now as it whispered a forward momentum. Catra took a step toward the airlock, just to check. The door whooshed softly open. As she padded through, she noticed the bridge lights behind her had dimmed by a degree.

…

The hum softened in Adora's ears just as the warmth of the bridge lights cooled, shifting to a low, clinical white. It wasn't harsh, just precise, like it was encouraging focus. A small diagnostic interface blinked open across the console.

A message appeared: “Dual-subject diagnostic: alternating sequence mode active. Comparative attunement tracking." Then: “Tactical Assessment: Active Drill.”

Beneath it, a scenario unfolded. An engine leak occurred during combat, and a crew member was trapped. Four solution branches appeared. Adora’s hands moved quickly, scrolling through the details. She was familiar with this kind of decision-making activity. It felt like the type of strategy sim game she’d played before on her tracker pad. A prompt blinked: “Begin.”

…

The airlock sealed behind Catra with a definitive pneumatic sound. She froze as she noticed the shift in pressure that indicated she was sealed in. She tried to access her comm, “Adora?” Only static. Her jaw clenched. Her shoulders tightened. Her claws extended.

The lights all around her pulsed red, and the temperature dropped by a few degrees. A steady stream of cold mist hissed out from the vents. Its sharp and slightly metallic scent coated her tongue. The ship declared: “Volatile affect poses risk to crew safety.” Catra pressed her palm flat to the metal door, feeling for vibration. She could feel nothing, not Adora moving or the helmet’s crack widening on the bench. Only her own too fast pulse. Her claws twitched. Her breath shortened. She felt her anger rise at the ship, at being cut off, at not knowing what was happening. The hum in her ear stuttered into broken fragments.

She forced herself still. It was not the trapped inaction of panic, but the deliberately held quiet of someone choosing. Her claws hovered, half-curled, waiting for permission that never came. Catra remembered the moon dust cradling her, how good the stillness felt. Her breath slowed. She feared she was seeking that numbness now. The light warmed. “Affect regulation successful. Stabilization reward granted.” Her shoulders loosened, and she exhaled as relief flooded through her. Then, a cold feeling knotted in her chest. The reward had felt like comfort. That’s what scared her. It reminded her of the Horde. She dragged one claw slowly

down the bulkhead wall, just enough to leave a mark, not enough to trigger an alert. She didn’t try to make it useful.

…

After carefully reviewing the options before her, Adora, calm and decisive, selected the most optimal loss. The call would save almost all, but it would doom one. Her mouth went dry at the thought. Then, she accepted that, internalized it as the best option available. A message appeared: “Operator decision: effective.”

An updated scenario appeared. More were trapped. Fewer options appeared. The numbers didn’t work, no matter what she tried. Still, she pushed harder, adjusting rapidly, and discarding everything nonessential. Her vision narrowed to the screen's glow. Lives were numbers now, weighed against one another. She sacrificed fuel, rerouted power, and cut life support in non-critical zones. Trying anything to save more. The screen flickered: “One survivor.” Her hand hesitated. The next message appeared: “Operator performance: optimal under duress. Casualty acceptance rate: human standard.” She inhaled. That meant it had been the right call, or at least an acceptable one.

The drill reset. The rounds were bleeding together now, one after another in quick succession. Adora was hunched forward, unblinking. She had barely even realized she had started in on the next one. It just felt like a continuation. It was the same scenario, but a new configuration. She adjusted parameters. She made choices trying to optimize the impossible. She waited one extra heartbeat before acting. Again, only one survivor. Every choice looped back to the same result, too many lost. A message blinked: “Decision within optimal tolerance.” Adora remembered She-Ra's transformation. That was the real power, not this gamified competence. She felt the difference but continued anyway. Another message appeared: “Try again for enhanced outcome?” Adora didn’t hesitate. “I was so close,” she muttered to herself as she focused again on trying to get just the right fix. She

didn’t notice how cold her hands had become, the chill of fingers moving too fast, too over-precise.

…

A crisply delivered message rang out: “Affect instability poses continued risk.” Catra’s instincts snapped to attention. Her fingers curled. Claws released reflexively. She felt the urge to strike, to force the door, to claw her way back to Adora. She desperately needed to do something, to try and stop this. How long has she even been in this airlock? Had it been minutes or hours? She tried to count vent exhales. Then one stretched seemingly indefinitely.

The red lights blinked ever more insistently as if keeping time with her rising pulse. Her claws pressed crescent marks into her palms. Catra knew her reaction was causing the renewed intensity. She shouldn’t have let herself rise to this bait. She needed to try and stay calm. Why was that so hard? Anger had warned her many times in the past. It had kept her alive. Still, maybe the system was right. Maybe she was a threat to Adora. Her claws were always a second away from release, her anger always just barely kept from surfacing.

“Instinctive escalation registered. Subject disruption probability increasing.” The words slid in like truth. Each vertebrae in her spine and tail locked with tension. She had thought she was sensing danger, but maybe the danger really was her. The steady hiss of the vents was becoming indistinguishable from her own breathing.

…

The white-noise whistle of the vents faded out. The drill had shifted suddenly. A schematic of the ship appeared on the display with compartments blinking in urgent red. A wave of audio flooded the bridge before Adora had even a moment to brace for it. She heard a strangled cough, an incoherent shout, and the sharp sound of metal collapsing under strain. A thin, ragged voice called out for help.

Adora’s eyes widened with distress. Her pulse quickened. She felt the dry click of her throat as she swallowed involuntarily. Her fingers moved faster. She rerouted power. She sealed off sectors. She tried anything to fix the mounting issues. Desperate screams echoed through the bridge as the casualties mounted.

She tried to stop the simulation. The option grayed out the moment she reached for it. The system chimed three bright notes, and a message appeared: “Operator performance: optimal given constraints.” The hum in her ear stuttered. Her jaw unclenched for a second and then tightened even harder. The praise gave her far less comfort now. Optimal didn’t feel like approval. It felt like permission. Static washed through the speakers, and it sounded like someone trying not to cry.

…

A crackling hiss of interference burst across the comm and then cleared just enough for a sound to come through. Not words, just the steady inhale and exhale of breath. “Adora?” Catra tried, barely a whisper. The answer was just the continued heavy breathing. Catra caught her own reflection in the metal sheen of the bulkhead. It stared back, delayed by a fraction, then sharpened into something fiercer. Its mouth curled, teeth bared.

The breathing through the comm quickened into panic. Adora’s pleading voice cut through, “Catra… stop… please…just stop.” Then it cut back to the heavy, distressed breathing mingling with the soft buzz of static. Catra’s brow furrowed, her eyebrows drawn together. She realized she couldn’t tell if it was Adora's panic or her own reflected back in the breathing.

Catra felt her hands shake, but the reflection steadied, furious and sure, like this anger was what she truly was. It tilted its head, its mouth moving soundlessly. Catra’s eyes widened. She realized this was what the system wanted her to become. She curled inward, her tail and ears drooping, claws clicking as her hands trembled. Her breath came in thin, tight pulls like she was trying not to make a sound. Her eyes stung, and she blinked hard, furious at

the softness of it, at her body's betrayal. Her claws didn't fully release. They never did when it came to Adora. The reflections had faded, and Catra still stared dimly at the now dulled wall.

…

In the sheen of the metallic surface beside the console, reflections suddenly appeared behind Adora's own, faces that weren't really there. Mouths opened mid-scream, eyes too wide in terror. When she blinked, they lagged half a beat behind. She looked away, and they persisted, visible in her peripheral vision. They slowly turned to face her as she tried to focus away from them and back on the screen. Her hand moved to reroute power and stopped because someone was still screaming.

Adora's jaw tightened. Her shoulders braced. Her movements became ever more precise. Still, her fingers fumbled over the controls as they trembled. Her breath became shallow, stuttering like a system caught in a loop. Each inhale came with a new doubt. Tears pricked behind her eyes like another ship partition starting to fail. Power had never felt this cold, this calculating before.

She waited for the certainty to follow. It didn't. She almost straightened her shoulders anyway. She fumbled for the comm, for Catra, for anything real. The only answer that came through was a thin wash of white noise. Beneath it, faintly, she heard breathing, too fast and shallow. She felt herself matching it.

Chapter End Notes

> I know these last couple of chapters have been pushing them pretty hard. A fragile moment of connection is coming, I promise!
>
> If you are up for it, let me know if you felt more stressed for Adora or Catra in this one? Or, let me know what was your favorite unsettling detail?

Chapter 8: Adjacence

Chapter Summary

> Optimized to breathe as one, now they must choose discomfort to try and connect.

The airlock opened suddenly, and the first thing Catra heard was Adora's breathing. It was raw and uneven, catching in her throat. No more borrowed calm now, just Adora ragged and real. Catra's own exhale answered, still too low and shallow.

The voice of the ship rang out, "Access restored. Affect stabilization confirmed. Dual-subject optimization available."

Catra ignored it. She let her forced calm drain out. Her tail muscles, cramped from being held so motionless, slowly began to loosen. She stilled her trembling hands and peered out at the bridge. She breathed in the familiar scent of warmed citrus that now replaced the acrid metallic tinge of the airlock mist.

Adora stood at the console, shoulders drawn in. Her weight tilted forward, almost braced. Her gaze flicked too fast from the reflective metal and back to Catra, like Catra might disappear if she blinked. Adora met her eyes like Catra was a lifeline and a landmine.

The ship's lights held steady. Watching. Catra took one step. Adora took one step. Their exhales released at the same time, and still didn't meet. Adora's breath caught. Catra's stayed low.

Adora had reached reflexively for the controls again. "It's fine," she said, "I handled it." Her voice was steady, but her chest stuttered.

Her shoulders stayed up near her ears, her hands shaking, her fingers drifting. They ghosted over the controls, skimming without landing. They kept finding the edge of the console. They gripped,

released, then gripped again. The rhythm was wrong, too urgent, the pattern of someone still waiting for the hit.

Catra approached. Adora sounded like a commander, but she moved like prey. Catra waited. Silence was safer, until it wasn't. Adora's hands shook even worse, and her eyes kept darting about as if scanning for invisible threats.

Catra felt the ghost of the magic's sting on her palm from when she'd pulled Adora back. Soft hadn't worked. Sharp hadn't worked. Silence had only made the distance bigger. Adora wasn't okay. Catra was done waiting. She needed to reach out again, even if it burned.

"No," the word was almost swallowed. "It's not." It was short and flat, stated in the space between breaths.

"Catra," Adora replied, softly, but as if she was suddenly more anchored.

Catra's claws retracted, not restraint but reach. Her hand covered Adora's trembling wrist for a beat, long enough to feel the tremor. Adora's hand found her shoulder and hovered there, like she didn't trust herself to touch. The ship's lights softened, like a reward. They both flinched.

They started to breathe on purpose, out of sync. It was uncomfortable and uneven, spiking panic under Catra's skin. Wrong, but theirs. The hum rose in Catra's ears in protest, trying to reassert its three-beat leash, like a metronome trying to crawl inside her very bones.

Catra felt her heartbeat trying to match and forced herself to slow it. A rush of dizziness surged, and the bridge spun a little. She gripped the edge of the console as her chest hitched. She hated that her body wanted to obey. Her lungs tried to fall into step. She made them stumble.

The calm voice of the ship called out, "Sync degradation detected. Repair advised."

Adora realized with a jolt that she had started to smile without noticing. Her world narrowed to the hum. She suddenly felt her shoulders drop in relief, too much relief. It was far too immediate. Their breath had begun to align without choice. She heard the hum in her ear. Its three-note song seemed like competence, like being enough. She felt the phantom hand on her back sensation, that sense of doing something right.

Subtle warmth radiated at the base of her spine. It felt like this was how it should be. Adora remembered the soft glow, the perfect waveform, the moment she couldn't tell her own heartbeat from the hum's rhythm during the attunement exercises earlier. She felt virtuous then. She felt that same way again now, though maybe there was something just a little off. She felt the hairs on her neck rise.

Adora breathed in, and Catra’s own inhale started at the same time. They could be perfectly synchronized. It would be so easy.

Catra jerked her hand back. "No. That's…” She shook her head, ears flat. "That's not us. That's it."

Adora blinked, caught in the lag between conditioned response and recognition. Her hand hovered where Catra's had been. For a moment, it seemed like she might argue. It felt so simple, so good.

“Yeah, that’s not...” She forced a gasp early, off-beat. Interrupting the pattern. Her chest hitched.

Adora’s fingers twitched a bit toward the console once more. Her need to fix so strong. Then she heard Catra’s deliberate, ragged inhale. Adora's hand stopped. The ship pulsed once, twice, a third time. She pulled back.

The light dimmed, and the hum in Adora’s ear buzzed disapprovingly. The warmth withdrew, lingering at Adora’s spine as if reluctant to leave. Adora’s lungs ached for the synchronized expansion. Then, a flash of Catra’s vacant eyes on the moon

reminded her that she needed to resist this for her. Adora clenched her hand into a fist at her side.

The warmth had left, and Catra hated herself for wanting it still. Her tail twitched toward the vents before she could stop it. Her body reached for the way it could wipe the fear clean and call it peace. The attunement reward slid under her skin like a leash.

Catra caught her reflection in the metal beside the console. It stayed perfectly still, docile for a moment, though she had narrowed her own brows.

Then she remembered Adora's empty smile during the exercises, and something within her sharpened. Catra pulled in an out-of-sync breath. It was off-rhythm, close to panic, but alive, and just barely, stubbornly hers.

"You still hear it," Catra's voice caught. Her body tried to align automatically, and she coughed lightly to stop it, flicking her gaze away from Adora.

"Yeah," Adora said breathily, shifting her weight deliberately. "I thought… if I ignored it…"

"…it didn't stop," Catra continued.

"I couldn't… fix things. I couldn't… do anything right," Adora muttered, her face downturned, her eyebrows furrowed. She stopped herself from adding, I should have. Her arm wrapped around her waist as if to hold the words in, as if to hold herself together.

There was a long beat of silence. Then Catra said quietly, "I thought… maybe I… should just… stay gone."

The words hung there, heavier than the hum. Her stomach dropped, her claws pressed crescents into her arm that she didn't even notice. She hadn't said this to Adora on the moon or after. She had only shaped it in her own mind, where it had lived as impulse, as the easier path when reaching out burned.

Adora's hand on the console spasmed, fingers curling like she'd been shocked. She didn't look up, but her next breath came sharper, almost angry, and in a low voice she said, “No…”

Catra’s eyes caught on the crescents her claws had pressed, still there, stinging now. Her ribs ached at the sound of Adora's chest catching. Her hands were cold where Adora's shook. For a second, the hum faltered.

"Something’s wrong…” Catra spoke up in the suspended moment between inhale and release, on the pause between breaths, where everything could stop. Her diaphragm contracted between words. “It’s not just… me."

"You're… in it too.” Adora’s voice was rough and vulnerable from not getting enough air.

Catra’s ears flattened. She heard the hum in her ears. It took effort to keep her next breath uneven, keep it hers.

“We have to… stop pretending we’re fine,” Catra spoke on an interrupted inhale. She felt the pull beneath her ribs. It was effortful and slightly desperate.

Adora’s eyes squeezed shut for one breath, like she’d been waiting to be allowed to hear that. She quickly pulled up nav charts on the console, fingers moving before she thought, zooming out instinctively.

The ship called out with automated precision, “Re-sync recommended. Noncompliance risks crew integrity.“

With the hum in her ear faltering now, Catra’s attention snapped sharp as she saw something off in the display. “There. That’s not just interference. That’s nothing.”

“What?” Adora said, fingers twitching toward the controls.

Catra leaned in, close enough to feel Adora’s uneven breath against her cheek. "The ship's hiding it. See? The edge cuts off

too clean. Like whatever was there got edited out, smoothed into non-existence.” She traced the edge of the deletion with her claw.

Adora reached out as if to adjust a control, to take over, to optimize, to solve. Catra physically blocked her hand, “No, look.” Her tail curled around Adora’s ankle, offering her stability.

They stared at the display and then at each other. The hum in their ears intensified as it tried to lull, but now it only sounded discordant.

"Then… we go… there," Adora answered breathily, forced and off-rhythm.

Her hand hovered for a moment, then moved forward. Catra’s rose to meet hers. They didn’t align. They were adjacent. Adora’s fingers curled toward a control. Catra’s palm landed halfway over Adora’s knuckles, awkward and blocking. They adjusted. Then readjusted.

The ship hummed louder, offering the ease of optimized sync, two bodies moving as one. Instead, they traced the hidden spot together, their movements jerky, not aligned, but messy and real. Catra moved her thumb deliberately wrong. She felt Adora’s wrist tense and chose not to smooth into her.

Then, Adora’s hand dropped onto the interface, and Catra’s followed, and together, clumsily, they definitively chose to set the course. Their gazes met for a brief moment. They both recognized they were breaking something.

A message appeared on the console in red: “DESTINATION FLAGGED UNSTABLE.“

The ship’s lights flickered and gravity pulsed, like it was letting out a pained, silent scream. The system began glitching and stuttering. The ship’s engines sputtered. Yet still they jumped, the ship trying to self-correct, but its control fading. The magic let go like it had lost its grip. The hum faltered, a note cracking like a voice breaking.

The three-beat pattern wailed now in their ears like a lament instead of a lullaby. It was the sound of something vast, mourning as it lost what it wanted. Its frequency vibrated in their teeth, their bones, their temples. The three-beat notes slowed, taking on a minor key and stretching into something like a cry.

Gravity fluctuated, and they gripped onto one another, physically holding each other down, amongst the chaos. They resisted the magic's attempt to shake them loose.

The crack in Adora’s helmet, still set on the bench outside the airlock, deepened as they jumped. It released a whisper of pressure like breath returned. Catra glanced back. A puff of silver dust glinted near the bench. Then a silence where the hum had been.

The jump’s streaking light flooded the bridge. The three-beat pattern tried to reassert and failed to lock in, like a heart skipping and failing to catch the next beat. Catra's voice cut through, off-rhythm, alive.

“Don’t listen.”

The console flickered. Adora opened her mouth, and Catra could see she was about to assert a plan, to optimize again, before she forcefully clamped it shut.

For a few beats, they synced anyway. The deck steadied. Gravity smoothed. The lights softened. The magic offered ease.

Catra exhaled deliberately off rhythm, and Adora forced an inhale. They kept it up. Their breaths intentionally crossed like braiding a rope. The temperature dropped. Gravity lurched once more.

The hum slipped. The empty space it left made Catra’s diaphragm seize, her body begging to fall in step. She held it wrong anyway.

“I’ve got you.” Catra’s words arrived ragged. Yet they were still enough. Messy was fine. Messy meant theirs. If the ship wanted harmony, it could choke on it.

They held each other hard. Hands found hands, palm to palm, not intertwined, each pulse stubbornly different under the other’s skin. Not merged, just adjacent. That was enough.

The ship went fully quiet. Catra heard Adora’s inhale catch as if ensnared on the helmet’s hiss. Her own exhale scraped out through teeth still tight with the hum’s vibration. Their breathing was not in sync now, just shared air, and the choice to keep it theirs.



Chapter 9: Remanence

Chapter Summary

> Sheltered in a city of askew angles, they learn where the hum might lead and what remains in its absence.

Adora lifted her helmet, the familiar weight wrong somehow. Its distribution had shifted. She checked the seal automatically, fingers finding the crack's edge, mapping its progression. She rotated it slowly, watching light catch the silver dust embedded in the fracture line, glittering. The faintly mineral, metallic scent of resin and moon dust mingled on the air.

Catra’s fingers ran over the epoxy, her voice soft but firm, “It’ll hold. We don't have a way to seal it more.”

They suited up with deliberate motions. Their movements were effortful, slightly mismatched, but theirs. Adora pulled on her gloves, stiff from the moon dust that had worked into the seams. Her fingers slipped, stumbling to secure a buckle. She smelled the rubber seals, sharp and chemical, and held onto it.

The suit hissed as it pressurized, and Adora felt the brush of Catra's worn, gloved hand. Adora’s chest tightened too fast, too much. Her body registered Catra’s proximity, her touch, in a way it hadn’t in what felt like forever. Adora let her hand linger for a moment on the place where Catra had brushed against her as if she could keep the warmth there.

Catra tracked the hitch in Adora’s hands. Adora’s hands didn't fumble. At least they hadn’t. Not before. Catra wasn't even sure what before meant anymore.

Flexing her own claws through her gloves, Catra watched them extend and retract. Still hers. Still listening. Not on a leash. Victory, sure, or maybe just losing with extra steps.

Her suit sealed with a soft hiss. Its weight settled. They both stepped forward. The crack was worse. A phantom hum lingered. Catra hated it.

The airlock door opened, and they started down the ramp. Gravity hit like it had something to prove. The wind pushed back, and the surface beneath her boots vibrated with the planet's own weird buzz. No pattern. Still, her body tried to find the beat. Catra shortened one step, lengthened the next, and broke it on purpose. Adora was close enough to touch. Catra didn’t.

The sun was warm, almost aggressively pleasant. Stepping off the edge of the ramp, Catra’s boots hit dirt, firm and stable. As she stepped forward, her boots left clear prints. She looked back at them, just once, for proof.

Adora stepped down beside her and noted that the surface of the planet was soil-covered and a flat, ochre brown. An earthy smell filled the air.

Structures were visible in the distance, something about their construction felt slightly off. There was a roofline that didn't resolve at the expected angle, walls that tilted where they should be straight. Everything was built of worn, matte stone. The sky was a color she didn't have a word for, not quite any blue she knew.

There was no hum in her ear now, no three-beat pulse, just the sound of wind and distant city noise, just the texture of ordinary sound. Adora took a deep breath. Her shoulders dropped, then immediately tightened again. The relief was real, but it arrived with disorientation underneath.

Her ears reached for it involuntarily, finding nothing, then reaching again. She felt a lightness that didn't feel like the relief she had expected. It was like a hand she'd been leaning against had withdrawn without warning. She was suddenly too aware of her own heartbeat, disorientingly unsteady.

She immediately started scanning the city layout for problems to solve. Potential patrol routes assembled themselves one after another in her head until she bumped right into a pillar because she wasn’t paying attention. Catra caught her, but neither acknowledged it aloud.

Catra felt something let go in her shoulders, her jaw, the base of her tail. Muscles she didn't know were tight eased. Her body was hers now, not keeping time with anything.

The hum’s absence felt mostly like relief. She felt lighter yet too exposed. Then a door closed somewhere nearby, and her claws were out before she'd even registered the sound consciously. She forced them back in. Easy. Not doing that. She tucked her hand against her arm.

The archway leaned. Catra noticed it only as her shoulder clipped the frame. She aimed for center. The frame disagreed. Center was off. Of course it was.

Adora moved ahead of her, and Catra clocked her misstep. Adora’s boot hit hard. She caught herself on the wall, palm flat against stone that leaned away. Adora didn't look back. Her shoulders went tight anyway.

Everything here asked for something. Nothing met Catra halfway. Every step had to be arranged just right not to stumble. Up close, it was even more noticeable that nothing was flush, nothing centered, all of it built skewed like this on purpose. Catra's body kept overcorrecting, her balance overshooting, tail twitching.

Adora stepped toward what she thought was level ground and stumbled. Catra’s hand closed on her elbow too hard, claws pricking through the glove fabric before she could pull them back. The sharp points stung, and Adora flinched away from both the support and the pain.

"Sorry," they said together, and both flinched at the overlap.

Catra's ears flattened. "I wasn't…”

An inhabitant stood in the next doorway. They said nothing. Heat rose in Adora’s cheeks. She’d been seen as faltering when she'd spent her life perfecting competence for exactly these types of moments.

A few more inhabitants had appeared. They all wore layered clothing with complex fastenings. The colors were almost, but not quite, harmonious. Their eyes stayed on them for a half-beat too long.

Catra kept her own face neutral and her body language slightly loose, readable as relaxed.

"You'll want rest before we speak properly.” A voice rang out. The words held a certain quality of directness. “The withdrawal from the hum is…” They paused, searching for the precise phrasing. "It has a cost."

Adora, too quickly, “We're fine."

Inhabitant, not unkindly, “You are not fine. You've been inside it for some time. We can see that."

Adora's jaw locked. Catra let her hand end up beside Adora's, not touching, just… there. She didn't know which of them needed the closeness more.

They were taken to simple quarters. Two sleeping surfaces. The whole room was angles that seemed to tilt away from comfort on purpose. Of course it was.

Silence hit the second the door shut. Catra’s tail went still. There was nothing left to navigate but themselves. Catra hated that.

She set her helmet on a shelf that sloped slightly downward. Adora's sat beside it. From across the room, Catra could see the crack in the dome, a thin line catching the strange light. The window didn't sit flush in its frame. A breeze slipped through the gap in uneven little pulses.

There was no hum. No three-beat pulse. No ship messages filled the air. The absence felt loud.

Catra saw Adora try to settle and couldn’t tell if the tension in those shoulders was real or just Catra’s own nerves crawling onto her. This was new. She hated it. She used to read Adora like breathing. Now she kept second-guessing, and the doubt sat between them like its own kind of quiet.

Adora couldn't stop moving. Her hands found the window frame, gripped, released, found it again. She’d been trying to organize the room with her eyes since they entered. There was nothing to optimize here. She understood intellectually that the unevenness was the point, but her hands kept wanting to straighten and fix. She reached for competence and found only hollowness.

She tried one of the sleeping surfaces and then the other. Both sat at odd heights, her legs dangling or folding awkwardly. Eventually, she gave up and sank to the floor, back against the tilted wall, knees drawn up to her chest. She didn't look at Catra. She didn't need to. She could feel her there, vibrating with the same wrongness.

Catra tried the furniture too. The angle was off. Her tail braced against the tilt. She stood again, too fast. She saw Adora already on the floor, mirroring her own failure to use what had been provided. It should’ve been funny. She couldn't find the laugh.

“This is stupid," Catra said, meaning the room, meaning them, meaning everything. "We're… we're kind of falling apart."

She slid down the wall to sit beside Adora, not touching, close enough to feel the warmth of her. There was a long silence.

Eventually, Catra said softly, "Do you think we're even us anymore?"

Adora replied too fast, “Of course we are."

Nothing filled the long space between breaths.

Adora quieter, “I don't know."

Catra nodded slowly, the motion barely visible. Another silence, this one softer, more honest.

“I keep reaching for it,” Adora said.

Her fingers found the floor, tapping absently against the stone, one-two-three, pause, one-two-three. She stopped, horrified, hand frozen in mid-air. The rhythm continued in her chest, in her temples.

Catra watched Adora go still. Her breath went shallow, too fast. She knew that panic, had seen it in Adora before battles, before hard choices, before moments when the hero stuff had pressed too hard against the girl underneath. But this was different. Everything the hum kept under the surface had come rushing up.

Catra heard it too, beats hiding in the breeze through the crooked window, in footsteps in the corridor outside. A three-beat pattern where there wasn't one. She’d impose it on randomness, then catch herself. Stop. Easy.

She reached out and found Adora's hand on the floor between them. Their fingers tangled. Two people who didn’t know how to be quiet inside their own heads, trying together to sit still without flinching.

Outside, the breeze kept slipping through the gap in the window. No hum, no message. Nothing promised, nothing asked. Just air, arriving unevenly, making them listen.

Adora’s weight settled on her shoulder. Her breathing had slowed little by little. The tight, awake rhythm finally eased into something deeper.

The tension drained from Adora's face. Her brows unknotted, jaw unclenched, the permanent tightness around her eyes smoothed into unfamiliar softness. She looked younger. She looked like

someone Catra had known before war and magic and all the rest of it.

Adora was asleep. Catra wasn’t. The quiet pressed in like it had weight. Catra tracked her own reactions the way she used to track a threat. Only this one was inside her.

Her ears twitched at every sound. Her claws slid out and back at the building settling, the wind's scrape, the distant footsteps of their hosts living lives that didn't involve her. Too fast. Too sharp. Without the hum, she was the danger. She could hurt Adora.

A door closed somewhere in the settlement, wood against stone, and her claws were fully extended before the sound finished landing. Catra stared at her hand, the curved blades catching the dim light. Easy. She forced them back in. One breath. Two.

A branch scraped the window frame. Claws out. No. Claws in.

Adora shifted in her sleep, fabric whispering, and Catra's hand was a weapon before she knew why. She pulled her claws back slowly, deliberately, even as the phantom sensation lingered. Still ready, still wanting.

She was counting. She didn't want to know the number. Her mind kept tally anyway, the gaps getting shorter as her nerves frayed. She couldn’t move without waking Adora. So she stayed, shoulder locked under Adora’s weight, careful not to shift her, counting her own claw releases in the dark.

Adora slept hard. Exhaustion finally won.

She woke gasping.

Catra felt her go rigid, the sharp inhale, the hand that shot out to grasp at empty air. Adora’s eyes went wide and unfocused, searching for something that wasn’t there. No hum met her. No three-beat pattern smoothed the chaos of waking.

Catra watched her wait for it anyway, the expectation in the tight line of her shoulders, the slight tilt of her head, listening.

Adora breathed deliberately, trying to force her own rhythm into the pattern. Her heartbeat was uneven in her chest, arrhythmic, wrong. Something she had trusted about her own body was missing, some fundamental metronome she hadn't known she relied on until it failed to sound. Nothing to meet her halfway anymore. That steady pressure that had told her, wordlessly, you are doing this right, gone.

Catra tried the thing that used to work, forehead to forehead. Too hard. Adora jolted. They both pulled back.

Neither spoke.

Catra's tail curled around her own ankle. Adora's hand landed on the floor beside Catra's. It was close, but not touching. Neither moved to close the gap.

Adora tapped her boot. Catra drummed her claws. Both were off-beat on purpose, ugly and clashing.

“This is worse," Adora admitted softly.

”Yeah," Catra agreed. Then, “Still ours."

Time had passed. They knew this because the light had shifted, gold draining toward amber. Neither had slept again. Neither had spoken.

The summons came as a soft chime from within the wall. They looked at each other, two people who had spent hours dismantling themselves in the dark, and began the work of reassembly.

It happened with practiced speed. They stood, shoulders up and faces on. Adora's hand found the doorframe and used it to pull herself up to her full height, the motion hiding the way her legs trembled.

Catra shook out her limbs, tail going still, ears flattening. They didn't discuss it. They had performed together too long to need negotiation.

Adora's face settled into the expression she used for uncertain allies, open yet slightly guarded. Catra let her eyes go sharp and assessing, the protective threat that balanced Adora's invitation. Two people who knew exactly how to project competence they didn't feel.

The door opened onto late afternoon light, gold and slanting, the settlement's irregular architecture casting shadows that didn't align with any geometry they understood. Their hosts waited in the corridor, watching.

Adora stepped through first. Her stride was steady, her hand resting easy on her hip. Catra followed, positioning herself slightly behind and to the side, close enough to intervene, far enough to observe. Her tail moved in slow, controlled arcs.

They had spent hours failing to find each other. Now they found their roles instead, and the ease of that discovery was like the familiar comfort of a cage.

The inhabitants guided them through the corridor, compensating for the askew architecture without thought, and led them to a space that suggested both welcome and assessment.

Adora's jaw tightened as she worked harder than usual to focus. Without the hum, attention was manual labor. Each moment of concentration now deliberately constructed, maintained through force of will rather than environmental support. She catalogued the inhabitants automatically. The first stood with a measured posture. The second carried years in the set of their shoulders. The third was still and deferential. The analysis arrived slower than it should have, requiring active effort.

Catra's tail swept slow behind her, steady. Not the three-beat pattern. Her own. Something real to hold onto when her head

wanted to run.

They were in a communal space. Low tables, nothing lined up. Cushions were spaced like they didn't trust each other.

The meal was already prepared. There were bowls of things that were maybe edible. They sat. The inhabitants sat. The silence was not hostile, just… total.

They ate side-by-side, like together was just a seating arrangement. Catra watched them, her sharp eyes tracking the gaps. They reached. They ate. They didn't look at each other once.

Catra's breathing started to match the measured inhales of the inhabitant across from her. Habit. The hum's habit. She caught herself. Easy. She felt the disruption like missing a stair.

The inhabitant saw it. Their head turned, too smooth. They frowned, not angry, just assessing.

"You still sync," they said, "Dangerous." Their voice flat, not unkind. They said it like a fact. Like the weather.

Her claws were out just a little. Great. She pulled them back in.

"Working on it." Her voice came out rough. Catra hated that.

The meal ended without ceremony, the clinical one gathering empty vessels with economical movements. Then the older inhabitant spoke, their voice carrying the weight of something rehearsed across years, tested by time.

"It has been with us longer than our written record," they said. "We did not build the buffer to defeat it. You cannot defeat a tide." A pause, the silence itself a kind of emphasis. "We built it to stand beside it without drowning."

Adora leaned forward, the motion automatic, her mind reaching for the actionable, the solvable. "The blocking mechanism, the

resonance damping, how does it…" She stopped. Her jaw tightened, the words coming harder without the hum's organization.

"Work," Catra finished for her.

The inhabitants exchanged something, not quite a glance, not quite communication as Catra understood it. A moment of assessment. Then they chose not to explain.

The clinical one spoke instead of something else. "There is a place. We call it, the nearest translation is the Echo Core. No one who has reached it has returned. We believe it is the source of the hum. Or rather," a correction, clinical and exact, "The hum is its method of collection."

Catra pressed her fingers against stone. It vibrated naturally, not like the hum, but still heavy. Her chest tightened. Like the weight of something leaving while she was still telling herself it wouldn't.

Adora's voice emerged, "Collection of what?"

The older inhabitant spread their hands, a gesture of uncertainty that carried its own history. "We don't know precisely. Whatever each person carries that makes the hum stronger around them."

Silence. Not the quiet from before, people eating side-by-side like furniture. This was different.

Catra didn't move. She sat with it the way she'd learned to sit through incoming fire, teeth tight, waiting for the hit to land.

The distress signal. The station's doors opening before they touched them. The jump coordinates that had just appeared. The attunement sessions. The separation drills. The moon.

She'd thought the magic was messing with them. Turning them against each other. She'd blamed it for the fights, the distance, for how they'd stopped being able to reach each other without the

hum to drag them back into the same beat. But it hadn’t been breaking them. It had been steering them.

Every time the hum felt comforting, every time it felt like a choice, it was just a hand on their backs pushing them forward. They were cargo.

Catra's claws slid out. Easy. She forced them back in. She should have known. She hated that she hadn’t.

Catra’s voice was flat. “And what does it want?”

The older inhabitant spread their hands again, the gesture carrying weight beyond its simplicity. "That we cannot answer. We know what it takes. We don't know what it does with what it takes."

The clinical one spoke, precise as a blade. "What it collects seems to vary. From what we've observed, that depends on what the person is carrying."

Catra let that sink in. The hum had found something in her. The part that needed approval like oxygen. The part that chased warmth until it burned. The part that went small when it should’ve fought. She didn’t know the full price yet. She just knew there was one.

She looked at the older inhabitant watching them, saw the quiet assessment in their eyes. Whatever the hum had shaped, these people could see it on them like bruises.

The older inhabitant paused, letting the quiet stretch. “The ones who came back, the few, over the years, they were never the same. Not because of what they lost. Because of what it showed them about themselves.”

Catra felt all three of them watching now, and saw the fear they weren’t hiding well. Not fear of her claws. Fear of residue. Of something that might still be active. Still reaching. Still looking for a way in.

Outside, the city moved in its careful, ordinary rhythm, streets and angles designed to keep them safe from exactly what Catra and Adora had survived. The buffer held. Whatever was out there waited at the edges, patient.

Catra pressed a claw into her own palm. Not enough to break skin. Just enough to hurt. Just enough to remind herself this pain was hers. Chosen. Real.

The older inhabitant stood, the motion a signal. The clinical one gathered the empty vessels, and the silent one simply ceased to be there. The meeting was simply over. A shift in the room’s weight.

Catra and Adora stood. They followed the corridor back toward their quarters, footsteps echoing on stone. The light shifted cooler.

They walked. The quiet sat on them both, different weights, same pressure. Catra's claw in her palm. Adora's hand on her hip, fingers digging in, holding herself upright. Neither spoke. Neither knew.

Catra kept one hand ahead of her. Ready. Her boots hit stone with soft, uneven percussion. Each step landed with small, definite pressure. Real. Proof she was continuing forward, not knowing toward what.

The quiet had weight. It bore down on the inside of her ears. She kept her claw pressed to her palm. Just enough to keep it hers. Wrong-angled architecture waited outside. The Echo Core waited somewhere beyond. She didn't know what it wanted. She didn't know what it had already taken.

They kept walking. The weight didn't lighten. They carried it anyway.



Chapter 10: Effluence

Chapter Summary

> In trying to prove what is hers, Adora discovers the precise shape of everything that can be taken.

Adora woke to morning light that cut through the misaligned window at an angle she couldn’t quite reconcile. She reached automatically for the hum. There was only the hollowness where it should have been. She heard the distant noise of the city moving through its morning. There was no cadence, just careful, ordinary life.

The truth of the Echo Core still circled in her mind. The magic had been patiently steering them the entire time. She had not only been vulnerable to it, but she had complied. She had wanted what it offered, the competence and certainty. She had wanted it so badly she’d stopped asking where the feeling came from. That was the part she couldn’t let go.

She turned to see Catra already up, watching her.

“I was thinking,” Adora began slowly.

“About it,” Catra replied knowingly.

Adora sat up, “Yeah, how much of it I chose."

Catra was quiet for a moment. "You didn't choose any of it."

“I chose to believe it." Adora paused. "Every time it told me I was competent, I just… accepted it. I didn't ask where the feeling was coming from."

Catra listened for a beat. “You were trying.”

The words settled between them. Catra’s tail flicked, then went still.

They adjusted their helmets and headed out into the city. Adora noticed the settlement differently in morning light. Its asymmetry was less disorienting, more legible, almost beautiful in a way she couldn't access before. Light dappled the worn matte stone, shadows falling at angles that no longer felt wrong, just different. She was beginning to learn how to traverse the uneven ground underfoot without stumbling.

The inhabitants moved with deliberate attention to their surroundings. A craftsperson worked at an angle that required their full attention. A child navigated an uneven step with complete focus. The settlement's sounds were clearer without the filter of yesterday's disorientation, just the normal sounds of everyday life.

Adora found herself thinking about what it might mean to stay. The thought arrived, and she didn’t dismiss it immediately. She thought of the buffer zone's silence, the settlement's deliberate friction, the inhabitants who had built a life beside the hum without being taken by it. This was survivable. They had survived it.

Adora watched the settlement, then turned to Catra beside her. “They built all of this in a thousand years."

“While trying not to get swallowed by a magic tide. Yeah,” Catra replied.

“It's not nothing."

Catra, something complicated in her voice, "No. It's not nothing."

Then, a beat passed before Adora asked, “Do you think they're happy?"

Catra didn’t answer immediately.

They watched an older inhabitant teach a child to navigate an uneven threshold, not catching the child when she stumbled but staying close.

“I think they're here."

Catra's weight shifted. "I need a minute," she said. Her voice was even, but her tail had gone very still.

Adora understood. They'd been working on this, the not-fusing, the choosing to be separate people who came back to each other. She nodded.

Catra hesitated for a second, then headed away. Adora stayed. She felt a flicker of instinct to follow, but didn’t.

Adora stood in the square and let herself be still. The air carried the smell of something cooking, pleasantly sweet and entirely ordinary. Somewhere out of sight, a door opened and closed. Voices passed at a distance, easy with each other, the settlement's language carrying through the air, meaning nothing to her and requiring nothing.

She breathed. It was quiet. She was simply present, no cadence to match or frequency finding her and beginning to learn her. There was just air, moving in and out, hers entirely.

For a moment, she was not the sum of what had been taken or what she still needed to do or what the hum had made of her. She was just a person in a square, in the morning, in the light. She wasn't a rebellion leader or a problem to be solved or a signal being collected. The morning didn't require anything from her except that she be in it.

She noticed the child again, the one she watched navigate the threshold. The child was sitting now against a wall on the far side of the square, one hand cradled against her chest, face tight, trying not to cry. An adult stood nearby, not noticing.

Adora stopped walking. She crossed to the child and crouched down. She checked her hand, not broken but badly scraped, swelling already. The child looked at her with taught wariness.

“I can help.” Adora kept her voice low and calm, projecting safety to someone scared.

Adora didn’t think about transformation, didn’t make a choice. She-Ra simply arrived the way she always had when there was someone in front of her in need. It was an instinct older than the hum, older than the war, older than everything.

She didn’t reach for power. She just reached for the child. She felt the child's hand in hers, small and hurt and real. The child's face shifted from wariness to something else as the healing light came. She-Ra's power moved through Adora toward something that needed it, warmth and presence. The damage was visible and then less so. The child's breathing evened out.

For the first time since the hum began, Adora knew without question that this was hers. It wasn’t the hum's organization of her competence or the attunement sessions' reward for performing correctly. She-Ra was hers. It had always been hers. This was the one thing she could trust. It felt more right than the hum ever had.

The child looked at her healed hand, then up at Adora. She said something in her language that Adora didn’t know but still understood. Adora smiled.

She wasn’t listening for anything except the child. The square’s sudden silence registered wrong, too late.

Adora felt hands, multiple, coordinated, grasping, carrying, restraining. The loss of the ground beneath her feet. Her shoulder slammed against a stone archway. She glanced back at the child, safe. She got that right at least. Whatever came next, she got that right.

Sudden movement that was too fast to track. The city’s geometry was working against her, the asymmetrical corridors that required attention now channeling her somewhere she didn't intend to go. The taste of adrenaline coated her tongue.

She opened her mouth, and Catra's name came out, reflexive and immediate, the way it always did when things went wrong. Nobody answered.

The city sounds pressed from all sides, doors opening and closing, and then all noise suddenly cut off. A door sealed.

Adora found herself somewhere else before she'd fully processed how she got there. It was dark and cold, sending a chill straight through her. Thick stone walls rose on all sides that were different from the city structures, more ancient. The air smelled dank and musty.

The chamber seemed old yet carefully crafted. It had clearly been built over generations, added to, refined. It was not crude. Large, complex pieces of electrical apparatus were built into the walls and floor, connected by a conduit that ran in careful channels cut into the stone.

Adora recognized the logic of it even now. It had been built in determination, born from fear, by people who believed they were solving something that needed to be solved. That didn't make it right. It made it worse, somehow.

The oldest sections of the chamber were at the base, rough-hewn, the joins between stones wide and imprecise, the work of people building something they didn't fully understand yet. Higher up, the construction became more exact. There were smoother surfaces and tighter tolerances. The apparatus became more integrated, more intentional. She could read the generations in the walls the way you could read sediment in rock. Each one had inherited the last one's fear and refined it into architecture.

Adora understood this in her bones. She had done the same thing with her own defenses her entire life. She had just never built them into literal walls before.

The apparatus started to glow.

Adora took in the faces of the inhabitants operating it, focused, not cruel. Some operators looked away. Fingers trembled on a switch.

The sound and feel of a low frequency began to build. It was not the hum's three-beat pattern but a counter. Where the hum invited this forced. She heard it in her bones before she heard it in the air. It was a dissonance rather than a harmony. She felt the magic within her beginning to pull.

She felt a pressure, like something pressing outward from inside her chest. She tasted the magic in her own mouth, which she'd never tasted before because it had never been pulled outward. It was sweet and metallic simultaneously on her tongue, wrong.

Adora tried to map the chamber, assess the operators, look for structural weaknesses, and come up with a plan. She registered that the chamber was built with care and intention. She understood that the inhabitants' fear of magic was so deep, so generationally reinforced, that they responded to an act of care with an act of extraction. They saw magic, and they moved against it regardless of intent. They didn’t understand that She-Ra was different from the hum.

She understood the chamber's logic even as it dismantled her. She had let herself embrace fear to protect, built similar constructs. She had just never been the one inside one.

The hollowness arrived as physical presence rather than absence, something that had moved in where the magic was. It was cold and specific and hers in the worst way, because she could feel its exact shape, the shape of everything that was being taken.

She could feel what was missing precisely because she could feel where it was. The magic. The competence. The certainty. The feeling of being enough. All of it now a hollow that knew what used to fill it.

She was the child counting thunder in the Fright Zone again, wanting to help, terrified she'd fail, paralyzed by wanting to be good. She felt the phantom press of Catra’s hand on her shoulder.

The chamber blurred at the edges. The faces of the operators became harder to read. The light in the chamber doing something she couldn’t track. The frequency was the only thing she heard clearly now. Everything else arrived muffled, delayed.

Thoughts arrived out of nowhere that this loss was a type of peace, a clarity, finally being free. Her fingers tapped one-two-three, and her breath caught when the pattern stuttered. Her eyes searched for Catra in the room's corners even though she knew Catra wasn’t there.

She stopped registering smell. The chamber’s geometry made no sense anymore. Her hands, arms, even the air… nothing responded as it should.

Her hands felt weak, unable to grasp. Her arms hung limp. Her core unable to hold. Strength was leaving her like something being poured out slowly, and she felt every drop going.

The crack in the visor of her helmet was still there, with its silver dust and resin, the fracture widened and held anyway. It had held on the moon. It had held through everything.

It had held…

She tried to remember the chamber's dimensions. She had counted the operators. She had noted the structural… she had noted… she had been noting something. It was gone. She started again. The chamber was… the operators were… Catra would…

Fingers twitched… no control. Muscles refused… Air too thin… body unsure where it ended.

Adora tried to say her own name and couldn’t. Just stuttered sounds, then just breath, then nothing.

She tried to remember the chamber. She had counted. Not counted. The operators. The… The air pressing. The… nothing.

Catra.

Her breathing… no rhythm. Can’t steady.

Tried to say help… heard Catra.
Tried to say no… heard Catra.

Where was her body? Did her hand lift? Was that her…

Light.
Shadow.

Catra.

Toward.

Chapter 11: Convergence

Chapter Summary

Stripped to instinct, Adora crawls toward survival.
Surrendering to fury, Catra tears toward what remains.

A tremor ran through her from head to toe, starting somewhere in the hollow of her chest and radiating swiftly outward. Pain surged in her limbs, not the sharpness of a new injury but a deep, throbbing wrongness, as though her body remembered being something else and ached with the loss. Cold stone pressed roughly against her cheek.

Adora heard the sound of her own breath, far too loud in her ears. She lay weakly on a floor that smelled earthy and stale. There had been a glow. Its specific blue-white radiance had permeated everything, been inside her skin, her bones, her thoughts.

She remembered the crush of intense pressure in her chest and then only the shape of hollowness. It felt almost like she had been turned inside out. The machine had sung. She remembered that too, a harmonic resonance, a counter to the rhythmic hum, that bypassed her ears entirely and vibrated within her bones.

Then, silence. Then, darkness. Then, a single directive re-emerged from the static where her thoughts should be…

Toward.

Not only a word, but a force. The same one that had always urged her toward Catra, now stripped to its basest pull.

She crawled forward, trembling, vision swimming. Her fingers found seams in the stone. She traced them without comprehension, followed them because movement was the only alternative to dissolution.

A draft touched her face, cool air, coming from an opening in the wall. She fell toward a maintenance vent she hadn’t seen, couldn’t have seen, guided by something beyond sight, just gravity and base instincts taking her, small and weak and animal. She was a shivering creature dragging herself inch by inch across a dirty floor.

The vent was a space too narrow, too ordinary. Its edges scraped her palms and her knees, each contact a sharp point of sensation against the numbness at her core. She caught the iron smell of rust where moisture had eaten the metal. Shaking, she crawled slowly forward. The sound of her own ragged breathing trapped and amplified in the tight cylinder of the shaft.

Time meant nothing. There was only the next handhold, the next drag of a thigh, the next breath that proved she was still capable of drawing in air. She became the motion, reduced to forward, to toward, the word stripped of grammar and became only pure verb, pure survival.

Then, hard stone that smelled chalky and mineral and daylight too bright all around her. Her helmet was gone. She didn't remember losing it. Panting and shivering, she curled instinctively, protecting her vulnerable stomach, her exposed neck.

Noises were still muffled, as if she were submerged, words indistinguishable beyond the general shape of concern. She couldn't process them, couldn’t assign meaning. The world was texture and temperature and the terrible openness of space after the vent's confinement.

The shape of an eared shadow cast beside her and she instinctively recognized its familiarity before she could name it, before naming was possible. She noted the set of the shoulders, the particular angle of attention focused entirely on her, filtering out the chaos beyond. Something in her chest that had been clenched since the machine began its work released, just slightly, just enough.

She collapsed toward the warmth, simply following the toward that had guided her through the vent. It was the same toward that had pulled her to the child, the same toward that had always pulled her to people in need, now reduced to just the base instinct of forward and reach.

Adora felt fur under her fingers, coarse and real, a texture that existed in the world she had left rather than the one the machine had tried to make for her. A scent she knew, subtly sweet and a bit musky, activated recognition deeper than language. Soft breath whispered against her temple.

Catra.

The name arrived after the knowledge, a label for what her body had already understood, a feeling of being safe and known.

Adora was shaking violently now, the adrenaline of escape colliding with the reality of survival, her nervous system unable to distinguish. She couldn't stop. Each tremor carried the echo of the machine's harmonic, her muscles remembering the vibration. She chose the warmth.

Catra felt Adora’s fingers sink into her fur. They didn’t grip, too weak to hold.

She had stepped away for one minute to give them both space. Then the square went wrong. Catra had tried to follow, tried to find her, and now somehow Adora was just there again. Catra’s head hadn't caught up to it yet.

Her hand went to Adora’s shoulder. It stopped short, hovered then settled anyway, like a promise. It was whisper light, still Adora flinched like touch hurt, touch took.

A whimper slipped out of her, torn from somewhere deep. The sound went straight through Catra. It seemed to fracture something in the air between them.

Catra had heard Adora in pain before too many times, Horde training and battle injuries, especially the ugly ones that had been Catra's fault. She'd heard the quieter ones too, the nightmares Catra stayed for and then lied about in daylight.

This was different. None of it sounded like this.

"Adora," Catra whispered, the name barely shaped, like speaking might break her. "What happened? Talk to me."

Adora flinched, then moaned, no words, only distress. Her body curled tighter, trying to minimize her surface area against the world, trying to become small enough to escape notice, escape harm.

Her voice when she managed to speak was barely a breath, each word taking visible effort. "N-no… Sh-she-Ra. M-machine…" Her words broke apart between gasps of pain.

She had tried to explain it, the chamber, the operators, the logic of their fear, but the architecture of explanation had been taken too. She was left with only nouns, only damage. The fragments hung in the air, insufficient, accusatory in their incompleteness.

Her eyes, when they met Catra's, held something beyond pain. Shame, maybe. Panic. The horror of being seen like this, half here and slipping.

"Adora…" Catra said again low, too tight. The word stretched into desperation.

She wanted to lift Adora and run. She wanted to fix it with every trick she knew, and whatever she had to make up on the spot.

Adora flinched at her own name, the sound registering as threat, as demand, as something that required a response her body couldn't provide. She couldn't focus her eyes, the pupils blown wide and struggling to contract against the light. She couldn't sit up on her own, her core muscles failing to coordinate, betraying the fundamental architecture of her strength.

Something behind Catra's eyes shattered, restraint breaking.

Catra tried to think. Nothing lined up. No plan, just Adora on the ground, hurt and shaking, and Catra's blood going cold.

"Who did this to you?"

The words came out before thought did. It wasn't a question, not really. Hurt happened. Name it. Locate it. End it.

That building. That machine. That did this. It took She-Ra and gave back an Adora who couldn't even hold herself together. Catra stared it down. Built to take. Built like it expected the world to move out of its way.

Adora's hand twitched, trying for a fist, trying for a fight. Her body didn't have the strength, but the instinct was still there, still her.

Catra's resolve locked in with cold certainty. She watched it happen with a kind of ugly clarity. Her claws pricked and her vision went sharp. Restraint had run out.

She'd spent years proving she wasn't what they said she was. She'd built up walls, practiced pauses, kept claws in to live without leaving blood on the walls. She'd tried so hard.

Now she looked at Adora, hurt by that machine, and all the careful work inside Catra stopped being enough. Her claws slid fully out without thought. The next thing she knew she'd yanked an awning down, throwing it over Adora like a shield.

She was done trying.

She leapt. Not Horde training. Just go. Just forward. The same force that had gotten Adora through the vent, now just claws and speed tearing apart the same seams Adora had traced.

She kicked the wall, glad to feel it give, the impact against stone satisfying in its damage. Her body remembered what her mind

had tried to lock away. She was fast. She was strong. She didn’t need permission.

Claws flashed. Stone cracked under the force of her frustration, helplessness turned into motion. Metal screamed as she found the building's bones. She ripped into its innards and tore them apart with her hands.

Not at them. Not at the city. Just at this.

She shouldered through a conduit, sparks biting into her fur with small, sharp bursts of pain that felt good. Real. She barely heard the noise of the inhabitants in the distance, the shout of warning.

Wires ripped loose in her teeth. Copper and plastic and the bitter chemical burn of insulation flooded her mouth. She spat them out without stopping.

She found the machine's external housing that carried its frequency, and she destroyed that too, not clean, not smart, just thorough. So thorough it could never do this again.

She kept tearing even after it was dead. Some part of her knew exactly what she was doing. It was the same ugly logic as the Fright Zone, as the Velvet Glove. Build it big. Build it hard. Build it to take. Call it protection and pretend that makes it clean.

She was just another monster proving everyone right.

She wouldn’t stop.

The sparks died out on their own. Now it was only her breathing and the building groaning. Her claws found soft places, materials that didn’t even fight back, and she ripped those out too.

Stopping meant thinking. Right now, motion was the only thing that fit in her head.

She turned back to Adora only when her body made her, muscles cramping, lungs demanding air faster than her fury could give it.

Adrenaline still pumped through her, making her shake. The smell of smoke and the copper sting of her own minor wounds clung to her fur.

She was crashing, coming down from the after-burn of violence into what she'd just done, the part of her that had enjoyed how easy it was to break things.

Her boot hit against something hard, familiar. Adora's helmet, cracked dome catching light in the wreckage, silver dust glinting in the line Catra had sealed. The epoxy bead she'd laid down with care was scuffed, but it held.

Catra crouched and lifted it shakily. The weight was wrong, but the shape was right. Proof she'd fixed something. Something that hadn't been taken. She tucked it against her side and turned back.

Adora was still curled small on the ground, hurt and barely coherent. She hadn't moved, or it was only to fold in tighter, though her gaze seemed to have tracked the violence.

The distance between them felt huge all of a sudden, like the steps Catra had taken toward the building had turned into an uncrossable gap on the way back.

Their hands both shook with the same ugly aftershock tremor. Catra didn't know how to touch Adora without making it worse.

Easy. Catra tried to pull her claws in. They didn't listen all the way. Still half out, stubborn, like her body hadn't gotten the message that the danger was over.

She approached slow and obvious, so Adora could see her coming. Gave her time to recognize Catra, time for her body to stop treating everything as a threat.

She stayed just out of reach. Close enough to be there, not close enough to startle. Presence without contact. Adora could choose.

Adora didn’t, or couldn’t. Her breath hitched.
Catra froze for half a second, then made herself move. I’m going to touch you, she tried to say with her hands, slow and visible.

Catra didn’t speak. There weren’t words for this, no neat ones, anyway. Violence had worked and it hadn’t. Adora was alive but it was too late to stop the damage. Catra could feel how shattered they both were, edges that might fit, or cut.

The day kept going around them like it didn’t care. The building smoked behind her. Adora’s breathing came ragged and loud, and Catra listened to every exhale like proof.

Catra turned Adora slightly onto her side, one hand bracing her shoulder, the other at her hip, just enough to ease the rasp. Her worn glove caught on Adora's sleeve. Catra's first instinct was to pull back. She didn't. Just held on. Ragged, half-dangerous, here.

She counted Adora’s tremors because counting was something to do that wasn’t tearing things apart. She stayed right beside Adora, the person she’d destroy anything to keep safe.

Chapter 12: Recurrence

Chapter Summary

> The ship offers safety. The hum offers understanding. They return to what cannot be taken.

The echo of claws on metal still rang in her head. The building groaned behind her. Her fur smelled of smoke and copper and the acrid bite of torn insulation.

A shout cut through the haze, “There! The chamber!” Then more voices piled on top of each other.

Boots on stone. Running. Catra’s head snapped up. Her claws pricked out on reflex. Easy. She pulled them half in.

She leaned in close, voice low and rough. “We have to move.” She pulled her helmet on.

Adora's helmet was still tucked against Catra’s side where she’d carried it out of the wreckage. Catra lifted it with both hands, turning it to check the epoxy seal. Still holding. Silver dust caught in the line of the crack.

She settled it over Adora's head carefully, thumbs pressing until she felt it click. Adora's eyes tracked her hands for a moment. Not quite focused.

Adora’s breathing had steadied a fraction but her eyes were still wrong, too wide, searching for something that wasn't there. Catra pressed her claws into her own palm, the crescent marks reopening. Sharp. Real. Hers.

The pounding boots decided for Catra.

"I'm picking you up," she said. “You’re okay.”

She got an arm under Adora's shoulders and felt her try to help, legs not fully answering. Catra took the weight and moved.

The city fought them, thresholds misaligned and corridors bending wrong, and now Catra didn't have patience for it. Her shoulder clipped a frame, and she didn't slow. Adora's hand fisted in Catra’s suit and held, grip weak but there.

Adora smelled smoke and something sharp, chemical.

Saw a glimpse of sky between two buildings. Not quite any blue she knew.

Stone moved past. Too fast or too slow, she couldn't tell.

Felt warmth at her side where Catra's arm was, the particular angle of being held by someone who was also moving, the slight jostle of each footfall arriving through her ribs.

Her own hands. Distantly. One of them holding tight.

A door sealed ahead, smooth and deliberate, and Catra wrenched them left into a narrower passage without breaking stride, her body doing the angles her brain didn't have room for.

The ship was there. Good. Each boot strike landed ugly on the uneven ground, off-beat and hers.

The ramp was down. Catra's steps echoed on stone, then metal, then the ship's deck. She didn't stop until the airlock sealed. A hiss and then the city was gone.

Recycled air. The faint trace of citrus. The amber-pink lights came on in their usual sequence. The vent rattled twice before evening out. In the engine housing, something clicked and then settled, so ordinary Catra almost laughed. Almost.

Adora felt a whoosh of air on her face. Familiar. Something in her chest recognizing it before she did.

The sound of the seal closing, final and safe.

Catra's breathing, close and fast.

Amber-pink lights, the same as always. Something in her that had been braced released, just slightly, just enough.

Catra set Adora down against the wall and stayed crouched in front of her, one hand steadying her shoulder. Catra pulled her own helmet off, breathing too hard, claws still half out. She could hear the inhabitants on the other side of the hull. Or she couldn't. She couldn't tell anymore what was real and what was the echo of her own pulse.

She got Adora onto the bench then stayed beside her, close enough to catch her if she listed. The ship smelled like itself, warmed alloy and the faint trace of whatever Catra had last burned in the galley. It smelled like theirs. Catra hadn't realized how much she'd needed that until it hit her.

Adora's helmet was still on. Catra reached up, unsealed it and lifted it clear. Adora blinked in the warm light. Her face was pale and the shadows under her eyes were deep but she was here, present in a way she hadn't been in the city. Maybe it was the ship. Maybe it was just getting out.

"Hey," Catra said. It was all she had.

Adora looked at her. Really looked. "Hey," she said back, scraped and slow, like the word had to travel to get there.

Something in Catra's chest unknotted. Just enough.

Catra set the helmet down on the bench beside them. The epoxy she'd sealed caught the light, the silver dust glinting in the line of the crack. It had held. She told herself it meant something. She tried to believe it.

She didn't want to leave Adora on the bench. She did it anyway, crossing to the console, pulling up the liftoff with hands steadier

than she deserved. Muscle memory carried her through. Thrusters cycled up. The ramp retracted. The ship shuddered once, gentle, as it lifted clear of the settlement's uneven ground.

The diagnostic display pulsed softly. Catra glanced at it before she could stop herself, braced for a message, for the three-beat pattern dressed up as something ordinary.

The display read only: ALL SYSTEMS NORMAL.

No beat. Just data. Catra exhaled. Her eyes flicked back to Adora anyway.

The ship settled into ascent, the engine hum cycling through its standard rhythm. The vent released a soft gust of air across the back of Catra's neck. Familiar.

She let herself have that for a moment. Just one.

Then they cleared the buffer.

Catra felt it first, the air going wrong. Something slipped back in under everything. In her teeth. In her ribs. Three beats. A pause. Three beats.

Her hands froze on the console.

Across the ship, Adora's breath caught.

Neither of them spoke. Catra turned and Adora was already staring at her, eyes too bright, recognition sharp, exhausted and shared. The hum settled around them both clingy and waiting.

The weight arrived. Heavy. All at once.

The smell of smoke still clung to Catra's fur. Her claws had left marks on her palms she hadn't even felt. Adora sat still, like she was holding herself together by not moving. She-Ra was gone, and Catra didn't know how gone. She didn't know how to ask without breaking something.

The ship held them both, warm and familiar. The three-beat pattern slid into the engine noise like it belonged. Like it had always belonged.

Catra drifted through the ship. Too tired for efficiency. Her body ached from carrying and breaking things.

She brought water. Adora drank. The swallowing was difficult and deliberate, visible. Catra watched without looking away.

Catra sat back down beside Adora and said nothing. The hum said enough for them.

Catra needed something more to do with her hands. The galley was small, familiar. It didn’t ask anything.

She found the soup packets by feel, ran water from the recycler and waited for it to heat. Her hands moved through the steps without her brain having to follow. Good. Her brain knew too much about what her hands had done an hour ago.

The water heated. She poured, stirred, watched the color deepen. Simple. Predictable.

She hadn’t broken this. Not everything she touched came apart. She caught her reflection in the metallic counter, her tired eyes and matted fur, and looked away before it could change.

The soup smelled like sodium and warmth, trying too hard to be comfort. Catra carried both mugs back to where Adora sat on the bench, still holding herself together like she couldn’t afford to waste anything.

She held one out. "Drink this." Not a question. Just practical.

Adora looked at the mug for a moment, a look that Catra couldn't read. Then she took it. Her fingers closed around the warmth and she held it in her lap without drinking, like the heat was what she needed and the soup was beside the point.

Catra sat back down next to her and drank her own. It tasted like it always did. Like almost enough.

The hum threaded through the silence between them, three beats and a pause, filling the space. Catra finished her soup, set the mug down and didn’t look at Adora's, still full and going cold in her hands.

Catra sat with her back against the bulkhead, knees drawn up, tail tight around her ankle.

The smoke smell wasn't fading. It was in her fur, worked into her suit, and telling herself it didn't matter didn’t help. She'd torn that building apart with her claws, and it had felt like the most natural thing she'd ever done.

Adora was on the bench, breathing with the careful deliberateness of someone relearning a basic skill. She-Ra was gone. Catra couldn’t look at Adora without seeing what had been taken.

I wasn't enough to stop it. The thought landed flat and certain. The worst ones always did.

Adora's fingers moved slightly in her lap. Reaching for something that wasn't there. The hum threaded through the engine noise in its three-beat pattern, and Catra saw Adora tilt toward it a bit.

I'm not enough to fix it. Catra pressed a claw into her palm. The sting was clean. Immediate. Gone too fast.

The hum shifted. Not louder. Just different. It slid into her shame and settled there with a warmth that felt like permission. Of course she was angry. Look at what happened. Look at what they did to her.

Catra felt her jaw loosen. Her claws eased. The anger that had nowhere to go after the machine was dead found a direction, a reason that clicked too cleanly against what she’d done.

Across the bench, Adora had gone very still.
Too still. Wrong. The listening kind, the stillness when something had its hooks in her. Her head had tilted by a degree.

Catra's anger sharpened. Not at the hum. At herself. For noticing and not moving. For sitting here letting that warm permission sink into her ribs while Adora drifted three feet away.

The hum adjusted again. Patient. It had time.

It offered without words. Warmth. Loosened tension. The feeling of being right. The violence had been necessary. Protection.

Adora's fingers were completely still now, not resting. Stopped mid-reach. Like she'd gone searching for something to hold onto and found the hum there instead.

Catra dug her claw in harder. The sting lasted longer this time. Good. Real.

I wasn't enough, she thought again on purpose, and held it up against the warmth like a shield. I wasn't enough and that's true. The hum telling her otherwise was just the hum doing what it did. Catra knew exactly what it was and what it wanted.

She wanted it the way she'd wanted approval in the Fright Zone. Hungry and hollow and embarrassing. Like a habit she'd spent years trying to kill.

Adora exhaled slowly, the sound barely there, like she'd only just remembered to let it go.

The hum moved between them, three beats, listening.

Neither of them spoke.

Adora tried to flex her hand. The fingers responded, but slowly, like they were underwater. They didn't look like hers. Or they looked too much like hers.

She felt a faint sensation behind her sternum, an echo, small and careful and almost nothing. It felt alive, but too faint to answer. Adora held very still and tried not to breathe on it too hard. She-Ra was there. Reduced to almost nothing, but there.

The bench hummed against her hips, up her spine. Usually she didn't notice. Now it was the only thing holding her to the ship, the only anchor saying she was physical, she was here.

She didn't reach for the echo. She was afraid of what she'd find if she did. Afraid it would gutter out under attention, or worse, that she'd reach and find it wasn't quite right, wasn't quite hers, the shape familiar but the substance changed.

The hum shifted. Not its three-beat pattern this time. Something longer, a single sustained tone, steady and low, like a tuning fork held close to a matching frequency. Adora felt it move through her chest toward the echo, not pulling, not pushing. Just meeting it. Just recognizing it.

Her shoulders tensed. She knew what the hum was, what it wanted. Knowing had not always been enough before. She was not sure it was enough now, when she was reduced to one small echo in the dark.

The sustained tone made her feel understood. It felt like it knew what she’d lost. It was the most honest thing the hum had ever offered her. That was what made it terrible.

The echo in her chest reached toward the recognition of the hum. Adora felt it happen and couldn't stop it entirely, could only sit with the knowledge that the part of her that was still She-Ra, still hers, still real, was tired enough to lean toward anything that claimed to understand it.

The tone held. Patient.

The echo stayed. She couldn't tell yet if it was growing or only holding. She sat with that uncertainty.

She felt the bench's vibration. Her pulse in her neck. Her own breathing echoed in the quiet ship. Inhale, exhale, the slight catch at the end where the hollowness lived. She let those be enough. She let them be hers.

Catra moved before she decided to. No words. No plan. Just Adora beside her, the hum filling the space between them, and the ugly certainty that sitting there wasn’t helping. Her hand found Adora's in her lap, covered it with her worn glove, palm to the back of Adora's hand. Careful. Deliberate.

Three squeezes. She tried to make them mean I'm here. I'm here. I'm here.

Her claws didn’t go all the way in. She felt the tips of them press against Adora's skin with each squeeze, not hurting but there. Proof that the anger wasn’t done with her yet, that the violence still lived in her hands whether she wanted it to or not.

Adora's fingers moved on the third squeeze. Twitched, trying to answer. They came wrong, out of sync, half a beat behind. Almost connecting but not quite. Like a call and response where the response came late.

Neither of them adjusted. Neither pulled away.

Catra left her hand where it was, claws and all. Adora's fingers stilled against her palm, not gripping, not answering. Just resting there. Heavy. Spent.

The hum held steady, warm and certain, and Catra felt it try to make something of the contact. It tried to smooth the mistimed fingers and the unretracted claws into something cleaner. Something that felt like repair. She didn't let it.

This was what they had. Broken cadence. Claws that wouldn't listen. Fingers that showed up late to the moment. It wasn't the hum's warmth. It wasn't the attunement sessions' perfect waveform. It wasn't any of the things the hum had offered them and called connection.

It was just her hand over Adora's in the amber-pink light. Real.

The hum couldn't make it mean something it didn't, no matter how long it held its note.

Adora exhaled, catching once in the middle. Catra felt the shift under her palm.

She didn't squeeze again. Didn’t need to. She just stayed. Claws half out. Smoke still in her fur. Her not-enough shame still right where she'd left it. She let the weight of her hand say what she couldn't.

The hum held its tone.

Adora opened her mouth. She didn't know what she meant to say. What came out was smaller than that.

"Still here."

Two words, barely voiced, arriving in the held space between them. Whether she meant herself or Catra or both of them or the fragile thing between them that the machine and the hum hadn't managed to finish, she couldn't have said. It didn't need to be precise. It just needed to be hers.

The hum shifted, trying to make something of it. Trying to inhabit those two words the way it had inhabited everything else, to take credit for the steadiness in them.

Adora felt it try. Felt the echo in her chest hold against it.

Catra's hand tightened once over hers. Claws and all. Not the hum's doing. Not the ship's reward. Just Catra, still there, still holding, still angry and not enough and present anyway.

Adora slept because her body made her. Not rest. Not really. Just the crash after running past capacity. Catra got her to their bed, pulled the rumpled blanket over her, then stepped back before the gesture could become something she'd have to name.

Adora’s hands were still half-fisted. Her breath came in uneven intervals. Too fast. Then too slow. Her body still regulating. Once, she made a sound that wasn't quite a word. Her fingers opened and closed against the blanket, reaching for something in her dream.

The hum moved through in its three-beat pulse. Patient. Low. Already sitting in the space between one breath and the next.

Catra sat across from her in the near dark and watched until exhaustion took her too.

When Adora woke, it was sudden and wrong, a sharp inhale that was almost a gasp, her eyes open before she was fully behind them. She lay still for a moment, breathing, letting the ship reassemble itself around her. The amber-pink lights. The engine cycling through its familiar sequence.

Her hands found the blanket and held it. The echo feeling in her chest was still there. Still small. She checked for it the way she’d check a wound, carefully, half afraid of what the checking would confirm. It held.

Then the rest of it arrived.

The chamber and its vent. She had been reduced to crawling. To being carried. To not being able to say her own name. She-Ra, the thing she had trusted most about herself, the thing she had spent her whole life trying to be worthy of, had been taken out of her.

She had needed saving. The shame of it sat in her chest alongside the echo, heavy and specific, reaching all the way back to the child in the Fright Zone who had wanted so badly to be enough. The machine had found that place and pulled it open, and she had not been able to stop it. Had not been strong enough. Had been exactly as small as her worst fear of herself.

Catra had come anyway.

Adora lay with that. The gratitude was real. So was the fury at needing it. Neither resolved into anything she could use right now.

The hum was there too, warm and close. She felt it recognize her waking with that perfect attentive patience that never faltered, never asked for more than she could give.

She was too tired to resist, too tired to lean in. Just present in the warmth of it, and the comfort of the blanket, and the small echo that was hers, and the sound of Catra somewhere nearby in the dark, awake and watching and not saying so.

She didn't tell herself she was fine. That was something, maybe. Small, but hers.

She sat up slowly. The hum swelled almost imperceptibly, welcoming, and in the dim light Catra's eyes found hers across the room.

Something moved across Catra’s face, a question she didn't ask. She didn’t look away.

Neither of them spoke.

The stillness had a different weight now. Not the hum's managed quiet or the attunement sessions' enforced calm. Just the two of them, in the amber-pink light, with Catra's hand having found hers again, and the smoke smell fading incrementally from her fur and the echo in Adora's chest small and hers.

The hum was still there, but quieter now, waiting for the next opening.

Catra moved first. Starting the day. Her tail traced a slow arc behind her as she headed for the bridge. Adora followed.

Stars slid past the viewport in the uncaring quiet. The hum sat in the space between them. Three beats and a pause. Warm. Unhurried.

The console was right there. Setting a course wasn’t hard. Catra knew the steps. She’d done it a hundred times. Her body didn't move.

Adora's eyes were soft in the amber-pink light. The hum threaded through the engine noise like it belonged. Neither of them said a word. The course didn't get set.

The ship drifted. Just momentum carrying them through the dark. The diagnostic display showed: ALL SYSTEMS NORMAL. The hum settled deeper into their silence. Warm. Waiting.

Catra’s hand hovered over the console. A breath. Then her fingers loosened, like letting go of a ledge.

She moved her hand over Adora's. Not the hum's doing. Never enough. But here.

The echo in Adora's chest held steady. Outside the stars kept moving, indifferent and clean. The ship carried them forward into the dark without being asked.



Chapter 13: Imminence

Chapter Summary

> They drift until gravity offers something unexpectedly familiar. They let the wanting decide.

Ch 13: Imminence

Space stretched, vast and quiet, densely scattered pinpricks of distant light flickering in the endless void through soft bands of deep purplish haze. The stars slid past the viewport, slow and inevitable, the ship carried forward by its own momentum through the indifferent dark. It simply followed the gravity that was there when nothing pushed back.

Adora stood at the viewport and didn't touch the console. No next jump plotted. The hum sat in the ship around her, three beats and a pause, warm and unhurried.

It had stopped feeling like an intrusion. It felt like air now, like something that had always been there. It was a low pattern in the engine rumbles that she took in the way one noticed their pulse.

Adora did not turn around. She knew she would see Catra in the doorway, one shoulder against the frame, her tail flicking in that way that meant she was thinking, or pretending not to think, or both. Neither of them had spoken about the direction they were drifting in. Neither of them had spoken much at all.

The silence had settled between them the way the hum had, gradually and completely. It felt familiar, like the artificial gravity of their ship, just a standard part of an environment they had trained in, lived in, survived in. It held them, patient as the engines.

Adora's hand hovered near the console, not reaching, just near.

Then she saw it.

Not all at once. At first it was only a distortion in the starfield, something that didn't belong to the ordinary scatter of stars, a place where light bent wrong at the edge of the viewport. Then it resolved. The geometry clarified as they drifted closer, and Adora forgot to breathe.

That architecture was unmistakable.

A structure of sleek crystal cut through the void like a memory made solid. Crystalline angles caught and held light even in the dark of space, luminous and familiar as her own hands. Sharp lines of glowing amber-pink and turquoise traversed its every surface.

It had a too-clean geometry, built to survive centuries. Yet something had happened to it in the lasting. The original form was there, precise and intentional, but there was something faded and brittle in its aged, cracking surfaces. It was chipped and dented by centuries of micrometeoroid impacts, its luminosity sanded down from its original glory. Some of the fractures had been fused shut by later crystal growth, thin glowing seams running through like cauterized wounds.

Whatever the First Ones had abandoned here hadn't gone dormant. Something had kept it alive without them.

Parts of it still glowed. Not the clean blue-white of tech at full power, but something dimmer and more irregular. Other sections were dark entirely. It had the sense of a place that had been left too long with something still alive inside it.

Her chest lurched.

Not pain or fear, but something like recognition. It had been here the whole time, patient and massive, waiting for them to drift close enough to see it.

Adora's hand found the viewport glass without her deciding to reach. The cold of it registered against her palm, real and immediate. She pressed harder, like she could feel the distance

between her hand and the structure through the glass, like proximity was already doing something to her.

"Catra," she said quietly.

Not a warning, not quite, just the need to say it, to have Catra's name in the air between them before whatever came next.

Catra felt it before she saw anything. The hum shifted. Different. Stronger.

Her body clocked it first, as it had for years. Shoulders tight. Braced. Ears tuned. That low, constant readiness she'd been living in long before the viewport showed her anything to be ready for.

Now it showed her something.

She knew that shape. Not because she'd studied it. Because she'd studied Adora. Watched Adora's face change around it. The way First Ones tech sharpened her attention. The way it tugged at something deep and specific in her. She knew what Adora looked like when something made by the people who made her found her. Hooked.

Catra's eyes flicked from Adora's hand flat against the viewport glass to the structure beyond it. She marked what she saw with the part of her brain that never turned off. First Ones, yes. Partially lit, partially dark. Something that had been left here and hadn't stopped.

Her tail had gone very still.

The hum rose. It slid in too smooth. Familiar, it suggested. Safe. Her shoulders eased a fraction. She made herself notice.

She hadn't chosen to ease them. She hated that.

"First Ones," she said. Flat. Not a question.

"Yes," Adora said too quickly.

Catra moved to stand beside her at the viewport. Close enough that their arms almost touched. She looked at the structure and made herself really look. Past the hum's smoothing. Past the First Ones angles. At the thing itself.

A thousand years and it still lit. Something kept it going.

Catra pressed her claws lightly into her own palm. The sting came quick and clean. Real. She held it.

"It's still running," she said.

"I know," Adora replied breathlessly.

The pull tightened. It hit the part of Catra that still wanted warmth, even the wrong kind. Even after she'd promised herself she was done doing that.

The hum knew exactly where to press. It always had. It didn't rush. It didn't have to.

Adora felt her attention leave the viewport and turn inward. The echo had been a small thing for days now, a warmth in her chest that was either the faintest sign that She-Ra wasn't gone entirely, or the hollowness itself shaped like hope. She couldn't tell. She had learned to check it gently, to know it was there without asking it to be more.

The hum shifted. Not its three-beat pattern, but the sustained tone beneath the engine noise, steady and low. It moved through her chest toward the echo, just meeting it, recognizing it. The same attentive understanding it had always offered. She let it stay.

For a second, memory rose with it. The sensation of light driven through bone, power too much to hold and too fast to stop. Something vast and ancient forced through her by First Ones tech, using her body as its path.

She pressed her hand to the viewport glass. She felt its cold, a simple sensation. It helped less than it should have.

She thought about the injured child. The way She-Ra had arrived to heal without her deciding. The way that had felt like the one thing she could trust.

She reached for that feeling now and waited. For a moment, the hollow in her chest gave her nothing. Then, it was there, still small and hers.

She needed to understand this. It wasn’t the echo or hum, but the oldest part of her that had never been able to leave a question alone. The part that had made her seek out the sword.

First Ones architecture held its full meaning just out of reach. It had been built with precision and intention, then abandoned. Still, something had endured there, adapted, survived.

What was built here? Why?

What had they abandoned, and what had it become without them? What did it know about her?

She had spent her whole life moving toward understanding, because understanding had always felt like safety and being enough. The structure ahead offered that, wrapped in the old familiarity of First Ones tech.

Catra's arm was warm against hers.

Adora didn't look away from the structure. She didn’t move toward the console. She just stood in the gravity of the thing ahead, the pull of everything she didn’t know yet, and let the wanting be true. It might not be fully her, but it was enough.

Her mouth had gone dry. She drew in a slow breath that didn’t go deep enough. Her stomach dropped but her body leaned forward anyway.

"I think I need to go in," she said quietly, like a confession.

The words landed in the space between them and stayed there.

The hum settled into it, knowing what to do even when they didn’t.

Catra heard it the way she heard most things Adora said that she wasn't ready for. Full force. No buffer. Her tail arced behind her. She didn't stop it.

She should say no.

The part of her that never stopped watching knew exactly what she should say. She'd seen what this kind of thing did. She'd watched Adora come apart on that planet. Watched her go hollow.

Catra knew what the hum wanted. Knew this trick. I think I need to go in, was the hum's best work yet. Personal. Wearing Adora's voice.

Except, Catra also knew it really was Adora's voice. That was the problem.

She’d felt the wanting in Adora for days. The Echo Core hadn't put it there. It had just made itself the answer.

Catra’s hand twitched toward the console. She could say no and mean it. Adora would listen. It wouldn’t change what Adora wanted.

The hum slid through Catra. It knew exactly where to dig. What if she could keep the sharp parts and still be worth staying for?

It was something true. That was the worst part.

Catra's claws were half out. She dug them into her palm. Sting. Fade. Again.

"You think you need to," she said carefully, "or you actually do? Because those aren’t the same thing.”

Adora didn’t answer. Her hand stayed flat against the glass.

Catra hated that more than if she’d argued.

"I don't know if there's a difference anymore,” Adora said softly.

Catra looked at her then. Really looked. The way she had across the room in the dark after Adora woke gasping.

Catra thought about the Fright Zone. About wanting warmth badly enough to walk straight into the burn. Knowing the trick and still pulled by it.

She thought about Adora shaking on the ground. The sound of the machine coming apart under her hands. How natural it had felt. How she still didn't know what that meant.

She thought about being whole. Too easy.

The pull didn’t argue. It just waited.

Her heart thudded.

"Okay," Catra said.

The word felt wrong. Not entirely hers. Maybe entirely hers. Too much like relief. She hated that.

Her ears flattened. She moved anyway. Her body decided before her mind could finish arguing. Not the console. The airlock. Her hand stopped over the panel a moment too long before she hit it.

Adora followed.

Neither of them said we shouldn't. Neither of them said this is what it wanted.

As the ship went through final approach and docking, they suited up without ceremony. The motions were automatic, muscle memory carrying them through steps they'd done too often to think about. The airlock cycled. The hiss of pressure equalizing.

Adora felt the weight of the suit settling around her shoulders like something well-known. She picked up her helmet last.

The crack was still there, silver dust caught in the line of it, but the epoxy was fresh. Laid down recently, carefully, in the way Catra did things when she wasn't going to talk about them. Adora ran her thumb along the seal and felt the slight ridge of new resin. She put the helmet on and felt it click.

The structure waited beyond the airlock. The hum had changed quality again, less ambient now, more like a signal, a frequency with a source and a direction. It was coming from in there. It had always been coming from in there.

A faint tremor ran through the hull beneath their boots, subtle but unmistakable. Catra's helmet caught the light as she turned. Her eyes through the dome were unreadable and very focused. Adora heard her breath through the comm.

The airlock opened onto the dark.

Adora stepped through first. Not because she'd decided to, not exactly. Her body was already moving, the hollow in her chest pointing like a compass toward the promise of answers.

Her breath stuttered. The wanting wasn’t entirely hers. Gravity doesn’t ask permission.

Catra followed. The way she always would. Drawn by the same law, a different mass. It was a trap, but not going with Adora was worse.

The hum swelled once, full and certain. Then the Echo Core took them in and the sound of it changed completely, three beats resolving into something else entirely, a frequency that knew them

fully, that had been learning them since the distress signal, since the station's doors opened before they touched them, since the beginning.

Adora knew they could still leave. The aperture remained open. But leaving meant drift and not knowing, and the hollowness still there. Staying meant understanding.

The airlock sealed.

Chapter 14: Semblance

Chapter Summary

> The Echo Core knows what they carry. It builds from what it finds.

First Ones script ran along the long angled walls in slow blue pulses, and Adora’s eyes followed it with uneasy familiarity. The hum was different here. It came from within the walls themselves, a low frequency vibrating through the crystal and into her boots, strange only in how right it felt.

The air tasted of memory. She breathed in, and it was the Crystal Castle, that specific mineral scent of ancient stone, the faint sparking of active technology, mingling with the impossible impression of warmed moonlight filtering through crystal in a way that had no right to exist here in space. Her chest loosened, but her shoulders stayed tense.

Their bootsteps echoed in a soft cadence against the crystalline floor, shadows stretching long in front of them. Catra’s shoulder brushed hers as they moved forward. Adora didn’t reach for her, but she took comfort in the steady presence at her side.

They stayed slightly off rhythm, as they had learned to do when the hum was at its most pervasive. Adora adjusted her gait instinctively. She shortened her stride by a fraction.

Her attention kept drifting to the script, to the familiar angles of First Ones geometry pulling at something deeper than conscious thought. In some sense, these precise, intentional shapes were what had made her capable of becoming She-Ra. The need to know what they meant here, what they had become, moved below decision, below choice.

"Script's active," Adora said, her voice strange in her own helmet, too intimate, like the crystal carried it back to her before Catra

could hear it. "Not dormant or preserved, but still running."

"Yeah," Catra said. "I see it."

Adora watched the script glide along the angled surfaces, bright branching lines that seemed to swim through the stone itself, pulsing with a gentle luminescence. Moving forward with it felt easy. It seemed so natural to just keep going.

She recognized the enticement. Adora knew she was following it. That awareness sat in the back of her mind and changed nothing about the fact that her feet had already moved.

Each pulse of the script coincided with her heartbeat, a sympathetic rhythm that made continuing feel all the more right. She and Catra moved through the hall together. They were close enough that their shadows overlapped on the glowing crystal, far enough that they didn't touch.

Beyond, the corridor opened into a chamber of crystal shards, their color deepening from amber-pink to rich turquoise. These were the hues of First Ones tech at full activation but dimmed with age, carrying centuries in their glow. The lighting here was purposeful, only illuminating the path forward into the next preferred doorway, the next correct tunnel.

Catra's hand found her elbow, not gripping, just there. Adora leaned into it without meaning to, then caught herself and straightened. She forced her shoulders back into a steadier posture.

Adora walked forward. Catra's shoulder brushed hers again. This time, Adora let her arm drift outward just enough that their hands might touch, might tangle, might hold.

The script pulsed onward. They followed.

Catra felt her shoulders loosen. The hum smoothed over the tension before she could even name it. Her body wanted to lean in. Her mind snapped back.

Soft was where they put the hooks.

Her tail went still. Easy.

She watched their reflections on the glassy blue walls. Two warped figures stretched into something almost elegant by the angles. Hers was all edges. Ears forward. Shoulders high with the constant watchfulness that had kept her alive in a thousand places meaner than this.

It looked safe. Her nerves said liar.

The hum buzzed under her skin, telling her body what her brain refused. It made her want to arch and hiss…

…and also lean into it, stupidly.

Relax, the hum insisted.

Catra didn’t give it an answer.

“You feel it?" Adora asked. "The pull?"

"Obviously." The word came out sharp. Defensive. "It's not subtle."

"But you're still walking."

Catra's reflection watched her from three angles at once, turquoise and blue with a violet bleed at the edges. The angles made her look small. Too young. The child she had been before the Horde had burned the soft out. The hum held that version up like an offer.

"Forward’s the only direction," she said, voice kept steady. "I'm not stopping ‘cause some ancient light fixture wants to cuddle."

Adora's thumb traced a circle against her wrist. Catra let it. Let the warmth in. Let in comfort that was so much like danger.

The hum tried to smooth her down. Catra refused. She kept her edges. Her off-beat steps were quiet, stubborn sabotage.

Let it try. Let it purr and promise.

Catra had walked worse tunnels than this. Survived bait far sharper than glowy walls and soft light. Adora's steps beside her were the only rhythm Catra would trust.

The glowing script kept crawling ahead. Guiding. Always just bright enough to suggest the next step.

Catra placed a worn, gloved hand on Adora's arm.

Then something snagged at her attention. Not sound exactly. A low frequency in her ears. Her head flicked. Her hand slipped.

Adora felt the touch grounding even through their many layers…

…then a sudden absence of pressure as the gloved hand was just gone.

Adora turned. Where Catra had been there was only crystal. Empty space. Unbroken triangular angles. No sign she had ever been there. The separation had happened in a blink, quiet and complete.

"Catra?"

The word echoed back, warped by the crystal. Everything went dark.

Adora's hand rose toward her helmet, on instinct and habit, the check she had performed a dozen times since the crack first appeared. Her fingers found only skin, air, nothing. There was no dome or fracture line to trace, no fresh epoxy ridge laid down in careful silence.

Then the dark resolved. Not the Core's crystal. Not space. She was standing in…

Etheria.

She gasped, soft and involuntary, struggling to orient herself.

A damp, mineral scent filled the air. She stood in an all-too-familiar cave in the Whispering Woods. The entrance was veiled by thick purple fronds, and metal supports ribbed the stone throughout. Bedrolls lay sprawled beneath draped fabric, with battered crates stacked against the walls. Small lamps hung from rusted ceiling beams, their flickering light leaving most of the cavern in shadow.

This was a resistance hideout. She had spent only a few days here before defeating Horde Prime. Why would it want her back here?

Her shoulders loosened. The cave wanted her to believe it was safe, that she could stop moving, stop bracing, and stay. Adora recognized the hum's sway and didn't fight it. Not right now.

This was a simulation. She knew that. She'd been through illusions before with Light Hope and when she took the failsafe to the Heart.

She looked down and noticed her hands were dirty, the ground-in, chronic kind of dirty, nails cracked and skin scarred. She wore the familiar compression top and red jacket, but the sleeves were torn and worn in. She pressed her palm flat against her chest and found nothing, no glow from the failsafe.

A damaged comms unit sparked in the corner. On the wall, the map showed territory lost in red ink bleeding across the continent. Entrapta hunched over a console in the back, muttering equations that sounded like funeral dirges. The supply stacks had become a system, not the improvisation of a camp, but the infrastructure of people who had accepted they weren't leaving soon.

Adora's shoulders ached with the specific burn of months spent sleeping on hardened ground. When she touched the cave wall, her fingers found tally marks carved into the stone, dozens of them, deep and weathered, counting days she'd never lived. It all

carried the semblance of months, pressed into her body until the ache felt earned.

This was wrong. The thought felt distant, like shouting down a well.

She should have been afraid. This was more sophisticated than Light Hope's illusions. This was lived-in, a false world that seemed to have aged around her. But the hum stroked down her spine, quieting every rising alarm.

In her version of things, Catra had been here too. Sometimes she skulked at the edges, sometimes she slept against Adora's side, warm and solid and trembling with nightmares. Adora scanned the cave, but found no twitch of ears in the shadows, no tail flicking from behind the crates.

Instead came the echo of memory, the feeling of having pushed Catra away, a metallic taste in her mouth, heat rising behind her eyes. She was being made to feel the shame of a choice she had never made until the distinction began to blur.

She looked again, still expecting to see Catra in the corner, at the entrance, anywhere. She only saw the cave walls. The silence pressed at her ears like a low-frequency drone.

Now Adora reached for the small, fragile echo of She-Ra she had been checking so carefully. Maybe here she could summon her magic fully once more. Her breath caught with anticipation.

She extended one arm forward, fingers splayed. The magic stirred, then the smallest spark. She pushed for more, but it didn't come. The flicker collapsed back into that barely there echo.

Her stomach sank. She swallowed around the sudden lump in her throat. She had hoped the simulation might restore her, might make her whole in this one way. It hadn't.

Adora tried to hold on to the memory of the Echo Core, to the feel of Catra's hand warm on her arm even through many layers of

fabric. It felt like a dream compared to the grit under her fingernails and the ache in her shoulders. For a moment, she couldn’t be sure which was the illusion. She shook it off.

She stood in a cave the rebellion should never have needed this long, wearing scars she hadn’t earned, Catra's absence where Catra should have been, and no way to transform. The hum rose warm and sure with its lullaby frequency, telling her that this was still workable. That she could still fix it. That there was some decision she hadn't made yet that could still change everything.

Adora almost believed it.

…

Catra took one step and everything went dark. Her hand grabbed at empty air. Warm fabric gone.

The ground vibrated beneath her. A sharp, militarized beat caught her pulse and dragged it into time. Acrid air burned the back of her throat. Sickly green flooded everything.

The Fright Zone.

“Adora?” Catra called. She hated how thin her voice sounded.

No answer.

Hair brushed her neck as she turned. Her hand shot up. Claws threaded through long, thick strands that should’ve been cropped. Wrong.

She looked down. Black fingerless gloves. One short, the other running up to her shoulder. A look she hadn’t worn in years. Her stomach tightened.

Green struts. Pipes. Angled monitors. The control room she’d used a hundred times. Different now.

The couch was gone. In its place, a single armchair. Framed in pipes and freshly upholstered. Almost regal.

Like someone built a throne and waited.

Not real. A simulation. Like the Crystal Castle.

Her muscles tensed. Why here? Why without Adora?

She made herself focus on the room. The air felt pre-set. For her. Humidity, temperature exactly right.

The wrongness should've spiked her pulse. Instead, the hum slid down her spine. Her shoulders dropped into that familiar, dangerous looseness.

Consoles sparked with readiness. Maps lined the walls. Territory gained in red ink spreading across the continent. Everything in its place. Everything built to last.

A war room. Her war room. And she was winning. Of course she was.

This used to be the place.

No leash. No watching. The world moving because she said so.

It should've hit. The bite of it. She expected to feel larger. Loud enough to make people move.

It didn't.

Nothing.

Just control without heat. No pulse in it. Freedom-shaped. Empty.

A monitor flashed. Adora.

But wrong. A distant rebel fighter. Eyes hollowed with that look that used to make Catra want to set fires. Not angry. Not defeated. Just… sad Catra was still here.

Flickering. Out of phase. Half-transparent. A witness to a choice already made.

The warmth closed in. Still useful, it whispered. No softness to perform. Just this.

It tasted smug. Like victory.

Like ash.

She tried to hold onto the real version. When Adora’s thumb traced a slow circle on her wrist. When Catra could be all edges and still let someone close.

This place wanted her to believe the opposite. That alone equalled free.

Anger knotted in her chest. It would be so easy to put the armor back on. Sink claws into the armrests. Take the throne. To be the monster they feared. Because monsters didn’t get left behind.

Monsters were obeyed.

Catra’s ears twitched. Forward. Then flat against her skull. She caught something in her ears. Ragged and low. More felt than heard. A soft rush of air. Vent-like, but off. Catra knew the control room’s sounds. This wasn’t one of them.

The hum pressed closer. Like it could crowd her into a choice she hadn’t made yet. There’s still a way to be safe, it whispered. Just pick it.

The armchair waited. Open. Like it was sure.

Catra’s tail lashed once. It cracked against the metal strut behind her. The sound rang sharp in the empty room. Too loud. She didn’t move. Didn’t give it the satisfaction of forward or back.

Her claws pricked at her palms, half out. Ready to dig in and claim. She could already feel it. Worn leather. Warm from waiting.

Fitting her grip like a trap. Perfect.

The hum settled between her shoulder blades. Pressure. Steady. Like a hand she used to trust.

It knew her frequency. Knew every spike of anger, every hungry low. Knew the exact second she reached the edge of giving in. It wouldn’t take its hand off.

Catra stood still. The throne waited.
She shifted forward. Then held.

Her claws stayed out.

Chapter 15: Submergence

Chapter Summary

> The simulations press. The layers build. The pressing back gets harder.

Three rebels stumbled through the purple fronds, each footfall stirring the sediment of a dozen retreats and desperate escapes in a war that had dragged on longer than it should have. They wore the strain on their faces and in their clothing, patched and carrying the marks of previous missions. They turned toward her.

Adora didn't decide to take charge. She never decided. It just happened because someone needed steadying and she was there and the alternative was unthinkable. She had to make things right.

“Report,” she said with a stabilizing calm. She felt the three-beat in her chest as confidence.

The one in front did the talking. She was steadier than the other two, the kind of steady that had calcified into something she'd be carrying for a while. "Eastern route's compromised. Full unit, thirty bots at least. Reconfigured. Faster than the old models." A beat that answered before the words did. "They were waiting for us."

"Thank you," Adora said. She meant it.

She was already at the map.

The eastern route marker was still the color that meant viable. She changed it. Stood back and looked at what that cost them. She traced the ripple of it outward, the northern settlements, the timing, the supply window closing. Thirty reconfigured bots didn't move themselves into position. Someone had fed Prime's forces their route. Right now there was a unit in their eastern corridor and a gap in their line.

She traced the alternative with one finger held just above the surface, not touching, measuring. Reroute through the northern forest and they added three days minimum, patrol frequency reduced, blind spots accepted. Or strike the patrol's forward base tonight, before they consolidated, take the unit out, reopen the route before Prime's forces could respond to the gap.

She should lead it. The reasoning assembled itself without effort. She knew the terrain, and if it went wrong the risk should land on her.

The logic was clean. Something in her chest agreed, warm and certain, like a hand at the small of her back.

She straightened. "We need to move out," she said to the cave. "Strike team. I'll take point. We go back and we clear it."

…

Three Horde soldiers clanked in through the auto-retracting door, every step rang off reflective metal. Strain sat on their faces and in the careful way they held themselves. They turned toward her.

Catra didn't choose to speak. The room required it.

"Report," she said. The word landing like habit. Three beats in her chest. Certainty.

The one in front talked. He was the most assertive of the three. Low bar. “The supply route’s failing in the eastern sector. Rations are short. The forward unit is requesting reallocation.”

She looked at him until he finished. Then she was already moving. Instinct and the hum.

The throne sat behind her, green leather and metal, waiting. Catra walked past it to the maps, her claws clicking against the wall as she analyzed the troop movements, supply lines, the next push. Monitor light painted her fingers a sick green. The soldiers knew

better than to move. They would wait until she was done. The plan snapped together. Quick. Ugly. Obvious.

She‘d lead it. The alternative was sitting in that chair and feeling it settle around her.

Catra turned. The soldiers straightened.

Something in her chest went quiet with the decision. Warm. Certain.

"Move out," she said. “I’ll take point.”

…

They moved through forest in the dark. Three rebels plus Adora in point, light and fast the way she'd planned it. If something went wrong, she would know first. She would fix it first.

Bow's voice was in her ear comm, low and careful. "Patrol signature ahead, two hundred meters.”

Glimmer added, “Eastern perimeter’s showing quiet.”

“Copy,” Adora said.

The patrol base came into view through the treeline. Active, lit, movement at the edges suggesting they'd been expecting company. Her jaw tightened. She revised in two seconds. Not a strike, not anymore. Harassment and withdrawal. Preserve force. She hated accepting the loss.

She signaled forward anyway.

….

They moved through forest in the dark. Three soldiers plus Catra in point. Tight. Lean. If something went wrong, she would know first. It would hit her first.

Behind her, they scrambled to keep up. Crimson Waste muscle that understood exactly one thing, fear. The horned one was already drifting. Of course.

Catra didn't waste words. Her hand found the back of the goon's collar and yanked her into line without breaking stride. Heat surged up Catra's throat. She swallowed it down. The forest stayed quiet.

The rebel blockade came into view. Fortified. Catra's ears flattened. Two seconds and the shape of the problem changed in her head. Bad intel. More resistance. Different angle needed.

She signaled forward.

…

The engagement was fast and wrong in the specific way engagements went wrong when the enemy was too prepared. Adora fought at the front without She-Ra, her staff out, precise and protective. She moved to put herself between her people and whatever was coming.

A blade caught her forearm, blood immediate against her sleeve. She noted damage, adjusted her grip, continued. The wound was not disabling, just inefficient.

She pushed forward. If she could just get to the unit's communications array, just cut their coordination, the whole patrol structure would fall. She lunged, and felt something sharp in her side when a bot's elbow caught her ribs hard. The world went white for a moment.

The hum in her ear shifted to its single sustained tone. This is what competence costs. She kept swinging.

The route stayed blocked. The array was further in than she could reach. They weren't getting there tonight.

"Pull back," she said. Her voice was even. For one second she stood in the dark with her jaw so tight it ached, staring at the array she couldn't reach.

“Controlled withdrawal. Mission over. Now.”

…

The fight went fast and loud in the way it did with goons who thought they were good at this. Catra fought at the front where they could see her. Fast. Controlled. They needed to believe she was unstoppable. If she stopped, she’d feel what stopping meant.

A blade bit her shoulder. A quick hot sting. Catra laughed, turned on the rebel, knocked him out. The laugh was real. The joy in it terrified her.

One of her soldiers froze at the edge of the barricade, fire coming in, courage draining out of him.

Her nerves spiked. A flash of fear. Useless.

"Move!" Catra snapped. She felt heat building in her throat. Familiar. Her vision narrowed. Her jaw locked.

She let it ride.

She was on him before she knew it, her claws at his throat, her face inches from his. "Move now,” she hissed. “Freeze again and I end you. Got it?”

His eyes were wide.

He moved. Good. Better scared than dead.

The hum slid warm through her muscles and her shoulders dropped.

Catra didn't stop. She drove them through on sheer will until the barricade fell. They had what they came for. She stood in the

aftermath and watched her goons do their loud little victory thing.

She flicked the signal. Withdraw.

…

The cave settled into its nighttime quiet. Rebels to their tasks, their bedrolls, wherever they went when she stopped needing them to be somewhere specific.

Adora stood at the map. The markers were the same as before. She hadn't changed them yet. She made herself change them now, the eastern route still blocked, the supply window narrower, the northern settlements a problem that was getting worse while she stood here.

She sat at the command station, and wrote a report. Mission failed. Eastern route remains compromised. Recommend immediate strategic pivot.

Her forearm stung. The gash crusted into a dark line along her skin. Her side throbbed with every breath.

The failure sat heavy, the route she couldn't retake and the sting of her wounds that hadn't been enough to achieve success.

She felt the hum rise to meet her disappointment, warm and patient.

She clenched her jaw until her teeth ached. The hum retreated.

The cut throbbed in time with her pulse. She felt, for a second, the phantom pressure of fingers gentle on the wound, Catra’s fingers. But the whispered touch was too soft compared to the pain of the cut. The physical ache felt more honest than the dream of comfort.

When she tried to hold the memory of Catra’s hand on her arm, it blurred.

She closed her eyes. Just for a second. Just to find the quiet where a voice still lived.

"I failed," she told the darkness. "I know you'd tell me I'm being an idiot."

She opened her eyes. She planned next steps until her jaw locked, until the hum stopped whispering, until the wounds were just inefficient data again.

…

The control room emptied. The goons scattered to wherever muscle went when they weren't needed.

Catra stood at the console. It had worked. The numbers lined up. Clean. Simple. She updated the tactical display to show the gain.

She moved to the command station and wrote a report. Mission successful. Eastern sector stabilized. Recommend aggressive expansion.

Her tail went still.

Still in the way it did when she was making herself not react to something. She'd been doing that since the forest. Since the frozen soldier. Since the anger that came up so fast it felt like it had been waiting.

She knew this feeling. The part where breaking things felt good. The part where it felt right. Like that was all she was built for.

The laugh kept replaying. That real laugh, bubbling up when the blade bit. She'd felt right in that moment.

And then the soldier freezing at the barricade. Her claws at his throat. The way he moved when she threatened to end him. The sick, hot relief of being obeyed.

She hadn't wanted to be that person.

Too bad. She was good at it.

She felt the hum rise to meet her, warm and offering.

Catra looked at her hands. Too clean. She let the hum slide down her spine and quiet the shame. It was easier right now than fighting it.

She didn’t know what she needed. Something warm. Someone who looked at her like she wasn’t a weapon to be aimed.

Adora, she thought, and the name was an ache worse than her wound. Catra touched her own shoulder and felt Adora's soft fingers instead.

Catra blinked and found she’d been staring for an hour. Or maybe a second.

“I’m sliding back,” she said to the darkness. “I’m making it easy.”

She planned next steps until the shame went numb. The hum filled the empty space where Adora's name had been.

…

The second mission failed worse than the first.

Her ribs ached with every step back to the cave, the gash on her arm weeping through the field dressing she'd applied without stopping. She'd pushed past the point where pushing made sense, stayed in longer than the objective warranted, called for She-Ra and found only the small quiet echo that didn't answer. The medical supplies were gone, destroyed in the firefight before she could reach them.

She sat on her bedroll. The bandage on her arm had bloomed dark through the cloth. Her ribs pulled with every breath, something deep and bruised that rest would fix and she wouldn't give it.

Perfuma came and crouched beside her, just present in that specific Perfuma way that meant she was going to be here regardless.

"Let me look at those."

"I'm fine."

"Adora."

"I need to plan the northern tunnel approach before the window closes." She heard the sharpness in her own voice a half second after it landed. She saw Perfuma absorb it, the small careful stillness of someone deciding not to react.

Perfuma stood. Her footsteps retreated, unhurried, giving Adora every chance to call her back.

Adora didn't call her back. She pressed her hand flat against her ribs and felt the swelling under her palm and stared at the map and thought about the northern tunnel.

She reached for Catra. The specific cadence of “You’re doing it wrong, dummy.” But the memory sounded like it came from the bottom of a well, distant and swallowed by stone. She leaned toward it. The hum rose to meet her before she could get there and she let it, because the alternative was learning how far down the voice had gone.

"I know you'd tell me to rest," she said quietly. To the space beside her. "I know exactly what you'd say."

The space didn't answer. She turned back to the map. Her ribs pulled with every breath and she planned the northern tunnel until the pulling became background rhythm.

…

The second mission succeeded.

Catra’s shoulder was healing clean. She stood at the console and updated the markers. Western sector handled. No losses. The numbers lined up. Clean. Easy.

Kyle's voice came from the doorway, hesitant in the specific Kyle way that meant he'd been standing there awhile, deciding if it was worth speaking.

"Commander. Can I… there's something. About the western sector. I think the way the prisoners were…”

"Did I ask you to think?" She turned, and saw him shrink back. The anger rose. Eager. Familiar. “Kyle, your job is to follow orders. Got it?"

"I just… yes. Yes, Commander."

“Out."

He left. She heard his footsteps. Careful. Quiet. Smaller. Catra turned back to the display.

The shame followed. Hollow. She let it sit. She didn't smooth it away. Didn't let the hum take it yet. She just let it be there while she finished the report.

She reached for Adora. For anything. What she'd think. This room. This report. Kyle's careful footsteps.

She felt a faint hint. Less than before. More hole than her.

"You'd have listened to him," she said. Quiet. To the room. To whatever was left of what she was reaching toward. "You always listened."

It wouldn’t hold. The hum filled the space.

She dragged up the next problem and made herself solve it.

…

The mission briefing had been simple. Return to the ship and retrieve fuel cells, ration bars, medical supplies, and a working comm unit.

She entered and the ship knew her immediately. Lights coming on in proper sequence and the vent rattling twice before evening out. The specific quality of the air, recycled and faintly citrus, hit her before she was ready for it and she stood for a moment doing nothing.

The blanket on the bench was folded. Not rumpled, not draped across one end the way it always ended up, just folded, neat and uninhabited. She stood in front of it for a moment longer than she meant to.

She made herself move.

Adora walked through the corridors alone, her ribs twinging with every breath, her arm throbbing beneath fresh bandages. The supplies were easy to find. She kept moving through the ship, tracking, cataloging, making sure she hadn't missed anything useful she told herself.

She entered the main cabin without deciding to go there.

The bunk was narrow and made for one. She knew without touching it that it would be cold, no indentations. Something was missing. Something learned by touch. Something that hadn't needed words.

She made herself look away.

She walked back toward the airlock with the supplies.

A helmet on the bench pulled her attention. She picked it up and turned it. The dome was perfect. No crack, no silver dust worked into a fracture line, no epoxy ridge under her thumb where someone had sealed it carefully without being asked.

She turned it again. Ran her thumb along the dome's edge where the crack should have been.

Nothing.

The wrongness persisted, located somewhere in her chest, a pressure she couldn't name or optimize away.

She set the helmet down.

The cabin smelled right. The ship sounded right. Everything was exactly as it should be, and none of it was right and she couldn't locate the specific thing that was wrong except that the blanket was folded and the helmet had no crack and the air tasted of citrus and something else she kept almost identifying before it slipped.

She reached. Not for She-Ra, just sideways, the muscle memory of a gesture that kept arriving without her permission. Her hand found empty air. She stopped it.

She stood in the middle of the cabin and felt the wrongness and let the hum smooth it over because the alternative was staying in it.

She gathered the supplies. She went back down the ramp.

…

The perimeter check should’ve been routine. Something in the lower sectors felt off, the kind of thing that needed eyes.

Catra went alone. Of course she did. She knew these corridors the way she knew her own hands.

She knew them differently now. Worse.

She moved through the repaired sectors, shoulder healed but still complaining in the cold. The walls were fixed where she remembered damage. Blast marks gone. Cracked panels replaced.

Everything smoothed and made pretty like it had never happened. Like the place could erase itself if it tried hard enough. Liar.

Most people wouldn’t see what was underneath.

Catra did. She knew exactly where to look. She walked past the seamless surfaces and felt the old damage sitting under the new skin.

She kept moving.

She found a shock-prod in a side corridor. Standard. Old. Left on the floor like someone expected it to grow legs and walk back to the rack. Sloppy.

She picked it up.

The weight was exactly right. Of course it was. Her hand knew it. Her body remembered the way it remembered these corridors. Complete. Unwanted.

She'd been small the first time she’d carried one. Tail twitching. Eyes bright. Too ready. Too afraid. She'd pressed her face against a warm shoulder whispering that she was scared she'd break everything she touched. Small hands had held her anyway.

The hum rose. The memory dimmed at the edges.

Catra pushed back. Made the hum go jagged in her ear. She pressed her hands to her eyes and tried to keep the memory.

She held the prod a second longer. Then set it on a shelf where it belonged. She kept walking.

The repaired walls went on for two more sections. Catra moved through them without stopping. She knew what was under there. That was enough.

Perimeter was clean. Of course it was. There probably hadn't been anything there to begin with.

She walked back through the lower sectors and up through the building's familiar corridors, trying to find the part of her that had whispered into a warm shoulder and been scared of her own hands.

She was there. Somewhere. Buried under layers. Under the control room.

Catra stood in the corridor and tried to push through it anyway. The hum was warm, offering the easy way.

She took it.

Because the real thing was further down every time she reached, and she was tired of digging.

She went back to the control room. She paused. She heard breathing. Not hers. The hum rose and swallowed it.

…

Glimmer found her at the map. She didn't come in with anything to say about the mission or the markers. She came in looking at Adora's arm, the bandaging dark through the cloth, the way Adora was holding her ribs without seeming to know she was doing it.

She stopped beside her.

"When did you last let someone look at those."

Not a question.

"They're fine."

"Adora." Just her name.

"I need to finish mapping the northern…"

"I know you do." Glimmer's voice stayed even. "I'm asking about your arm."

Adora looked at the map. "It's been looked at."

"By you. In the field. That's not the same thing."

Silence followed. Adora felt the waiting like pressure against her ribs, which already hurt.

"I'll have it looked at after the meeting," she said.

Glimmer didn't move. "There's always an after."

Adora turned back to the map. Her hand found the edge of the table and gripped it.

Glimmer's footsteps moved away. Unhurried. Giving her every chance.

Adora didn't call her back. She pressed her hand flat against her ribs and felt the swelling and stared at the northern tunnel approach and told herself she'd have it looked at after.

The hum settled warm around her focus. She was doing what needed doing. That was what mattered.

…

Lonnie came into the control room like she'd already decided and was moving before she could back out. She wasn't bringing a report. She stopped a few paces away, far enough to stay safe, close enough to matter.

"You've got good soldiers," Lonnie said. Not a compliment. An opening.

Catra didn't answer. She let the silence do the work.

"Kyle's one of them. He's not… he's not trying to undermine anything. He just…" Lonnie paused, choosing. "He sees things. Sometimes what he sees is worth hearing."

"I heard him."

"You dismissed him."

"Close enough." Catra’s voice came out flat.

Lonnie looked at her. There was history in it.

"It's not," Lonnie said. Quiet. Not pushing. Leaving it there.

Catra didn't answer. The silence stretched until Lonnie nodded once and turned to go. No salute. On purpose. Just leaving.

…

Adora moved to her bedroll and stared at her hands, bruised and too human, and felt the shame settle into her bones. She checked for She-Ra, briefly, and found the echo smaller than yesterday, or what felt like yesterday, she couldn't be sure how long she'd been here.

She was failing the memory of something she couldn't quite hold. She reached for it anyway, grasping at shadows.

I'm sorry, I'm trying, she thought.

No answer. Only the cave. The war. The next mission waiting to be planned.

She felt a small warmth beside her that registered only as something missing. She pressed toward it and the hum rose and she took the hum because she was tired.

She couldn't tell if the something had always been unreachable or if she'd simply stopped reaching far enough. The sediment between her and the answer was very deep.

Her hand moved sideways. Found nothing.

…

Catra’s tail flicked. She stopped it. Stood in the space where Lonnie had been for one breath longer than she needed to. She

felt what Lonnie handed her. What she'd shoved back.

She was turning into the thing she'd hated. Worse, she was good at it. The missions worked. The soldiers obeyed. The Horde was winning.

She reached for something. A memory of stars. Of hands that touched her without flinching.

No answer. Only the Fright Zone. The war. The next mission waiting to be planned.

Her hand hung in the air. Empty. She couldn't remember the last time it had found something.

The hum was warm. Patient. Pleased.

She let it be pleased.

The display showed the plan. Clean. Solvable. Catra forced her eyes to stay on it until that was all she could see.

She pressed her palms to the console. Vibration. Real. Solid.

…

The cave was full of faces she was failing.

Adora stood at the center of the rebel hideout and felt every eye on her like a weight. She'd cleaned herself up as best she could with fresh bandages, a clean shirt to hide the bruises, her hair pulled back to show a confidence she didn't feel.

"The northern tunnel is our priority," she said, and her voice was steady, commanding. A performance. "We'll move in three teams. Bow, you'll take the eastern approach…"

"Adora." A voice from the crowd. "The last two missions…"

"The last two missions encountered unexpected resistance." She cut them off smoothly, smiling the smile of a leader who had

everything under control. "This time will be different."

"How?" Another voice. "You can't even…"

"I can," she said, and the certainty in her voice was a lie so perfect it almost felt true. "I will."

She assigned positions and outlined tactics across maps on the cave wall with steady hands. She looked like a commander. She sounded like a commander.

…

The control room was full of faces that belonged to her.

Catra stood at the center of them and felt their fear hit like a drug in her veins. Steadying. Too good. She'd dressed carefully for this. Uniform clean. Claws sharp. Face set in the mask that she'd learned from the worst monsters of her past.

"The rebels are moving on sector four," she said, and her voice was steady as steel. "We'll be waiting. Rogelio, your squad takes the high ground. Kyle, you'll…"

"Commander." A soldier she didn't know. "The last mission. The prisoners..."

"Were handled."

"Some of us are wondering…"

Catra moved closer. Not fast. Not dramatic. Just enough to make him feel it. To make him smell his own fear.

"Were you?" she asked, quiet, "Wondering?"

He swallowed. "No, Commander."

"Good."

She turned back to the room like he’d never spoken. She laid out the ambush plans, angles, timings. Maps flared onto the screen under her hand. Efficient. Precise. Like this was what she was built for.

…

They filed out to prepare, and Adora was alone with the shadow and stone.

She reached for a warmth she could remember but couldn’t name beneath the sediment of shame.

Still, she reached.

…

They cleared out to prep, and Catra was alone with the buzzing screens.

She reached for warmth, for safety, for a voice saying you don't have to be this anymore.

Her hand closed on empty air.

Chapter 16: Cognizance

Chapter Summary

Her body moves before thought. Catra fights for what’s real.

Catra stared into the wash of control room monitors, one hand braced against the console as she worked out tactics for the next mission. Her ears flicked on instinct toward a soft, uneven sound. She forced them still.

“No,” Catra muttered.

Her tail snapped once, and she stopped that too. Eyes on the display. On the plan.

The hum rose warm and smug, pressing her back toward the neat flat certainty of the screen where everything still looked simple.

Her ears swiveled again before she could stop them.

The low sound cut through the hum's rhythm and under the control room's noise.

Breathing.

It was faint and ragged, coming from beyond the vent. It hit before thought, straight into the part of her that had learned one person too well without meaning to.

Adora.

She knew the slow, controlled exhale that fogged her cracked helmet when Catra teased her. The synced cadence of their wordless work. The shallow, careful inhale of someone managing.

This was different. Shaky. Wrong. That catch in the throat, small and stubborn and trying not to be heard.

Catra knew it from the Fright Zone, when they were kids and Adora tried to swallow pain like it was nothing. From the Heart. From waking in the dark of their ship after a nightmare.

The hum surged, crowding her ears to drown out the uneven sound and push her toward the display, the mission, the soldiers waiting. Here, being sharp and effective had been the closest thing to being wanted. Now it was just a trap.

Her body had already turned.

Her claws clicked against the console as her hand slipped free. Instinct locked in, sharp and clean. Thought showed up late. She was moving toward the sound while the control room blurred.

This wasn't real. That breathing was real.

Structures started to flicker. She refused the illusions, and they thinned, then faded. The map dissolved mid-detail, like a dream on waking.

The throne was the last thing to hang on. Green leather. Patient.

Then it was gone, and the air turned cold against her fur. Catra staggered half a step.

The Echo Core snapped back into place, all angled walls and glowing symbols and too much open space.

The hum lost its warmth, leaving only rhythm. Three beats trying to reassert. Failing.

The corridor ahead stood empty, blue light breaking across angled walls.

Catra’s ears stayed locked on the breathing, clearer now, with no simulation noise to hide it. Distance lay between her and the sound, but it was still there, uneven and ahead.

She took one step toward it. The thud echoed off the angled walls and her shadow stretched long.

A blink of red light.

It cut out of the corridor like a glitch. First Ones. Sleek. Purpose-built, with its jagged mouth agape, slitted eyes, and six insect-like legs skittering.

One second the path was open. The next it was all metal and bladed legs, clogging the whole space. No clean way through.

Loud clicks of metal on stone swallowed the breathing. The thing’s head kept snatching toward sound as it fully blocked her path. Its front legs braced wall-to-wall, leaving only a wedge of floor beneath it.

Catra's claws were out instantly, reflex snapping her into a stance her body knew better than her brain. Of course the Core had found the oldest bait in her. Make her useful. Point her at something to break.

The thing pulsed with the hum's rhythm, pushing at that hungry spot.

No. Her ears locked forward. The breathing was behind the robot, and Catra moved.

Unlike the simulation's flooding anger, this had a target. It drove her toward need. The robot was in the way, and that was the only fact that mattered.

Too tight to circle, only forward or back. She dropped low and lunged straight for the gap under its body before it could crouch and seal it off.

She dodged and slipped between its quick-moving legs. Light bounced off its plates. It was fast. She was faster.

She fought without the hum's fuel, without it rewarding each strike, without that approval settling around her shoulders. Comfort was right there if she would just stop.

No. Out of the way.

She heard one torn inhale through the scrape of metal, and when the robot lurched and swallowed it again, vicious heat rose under her skin.

Give her back.

The machine still filled the corridor. Her right shoulder scraped cold stone. On her left, one bladed leg kept striking close enough to shear fur. The walls threw the thing’s reflections back at her until the fight felt bigger than it was, all noise and flashing edges.

The front leg swung out toward Catra. She ducked under it, not cleanly. It scored fire across her left shoulder, and slammed her sideways into the wall. Stone bit into her hip. She shoved off and kept hunting the sound ahead.

The robot turned with a shriek of metal. Rage hit, sharp and protective. The sound of Adora had been silenced. Catra reacted.

She crouched and sprang, her back foot kicking off the corridor wall for height before landing on its head. She clung to the narrow metal ridge over its eyes. Her claws slid out with a snick. She drove them in and ripped plating back to get at its wiring. Sparks bit. The thing bucked, trying to throw her. She dug in and tore deeper until the rhythm stuttered.

Scrapes burned across her arms. Fine. One ragged inhale cut through the metal shriek. Catra clawed into the machinery until it went silent.

The robot went down.

Its weight slammed into the floor as it crashed sideways, its legs folding in on themselves and opening a narrow lane along the

right wall. The corridor rang with metal settling and sparks spitting from beneath the robot's torn shell.

She was good at this. That had always been the problem.

Her pulse was loud in her ears. The Echo Core's blue walls threw sound back, sharp and stripped of direction.

She listened for the breathing and found nothing, not even a trace buried under the crackles of dying circuitry. One hand braced in the wreckage, sparks ticking past her wrist, she strained for that shaky inhale, that stubborn effort to keep pain quiet.

She had lost her.

Catra's throat tightened as cold flooded her chest and her pulse kicked up. The corridor suddenly felt too big.

The hum slid in at once, trying to make her calm and still. She swayed toward it for half a heartbeat.

Her claws flexed. "No," she said, the word scraping out.

Her chest was so tight it hurt. The pounding under her skin could've been fear or fury. Both bit the same.

Looking was useless now. The corridor lit and pulsed the wrong way, trying to drag her attention anywhere but the sound.

Liar.

The Core wanted her eyes, so she shut them. She stood in the middle of the ruined corridor, between cold stone and cooling metal, sparks dying at her feet, and made herself go still.

The three-beat rhythm pressed into the silence, insistent. Catra listened through the hum and static. A thin inhale dragged through a tight throat, uneven, pausing on the same catch. Unmistakable.

Adora.

Her knees nearly gave out. Catra bared her teeth instead. Her eyes snapped open and ears pitched forward.

Catra ran.

The hurt places from the fight throbbed dully, but she shoved it down. Later. The breathing first.

Light slipped over the angled walls, making the corridor seem to open and fold ahead of her. The ragged sound stayed, a single real thing pulling her forward.

A long, low note followed, tried to show it understood.

Catra kept moving.

Reflections doubled, angles went sharp, and the light stuttered.

Ahead, the corridor opening had been sealed over by a sheet of blurred crystal. It stretched wall-to-wall, thin and wavering. The air tasted charged. The fur along her arms prickled.

The hum's three-beat pattern broke as she got close. One beat clean. One dragging. The third shredding into static before restarting with a weak push.

The air brushed her skin in uneven waves of cool and warmth and cold again. The Core's metallic tang sharpened on her tongue and her shoulders tightened.

Up close, Catra heard the strain more clearly. Every inhale caught deep and kept going anyway. Stubborn. So Adora it made her chest hurt.

Warmth slid through gentler now, almost pleading, false tenderness urging her to rest and let it take over. Adora was safe enough.

Catra bared her teeth at the shimmering part of the wall.

“Move,” she said, low and mean. At the Core. At herself. It didn't matter.

The surface ahead rippled, blue light skittering across it in warped rings. The air pushed back before she’d even touched it. Still it looked fragile enough that one hard shove would rip it open.

Adora’s inhale hitched again.

That decided it. It didn’t matter if it hurt. She would tear it apart if she had to.

Catra stepped in close until the charged air pressed against her full-on. Every muscle locked. Her claws flexed. It buzzed around her, static crawling over her skin like it was trying to figure her out. For half a second, her body braced for a drop she couldn’t see.

She pressed one hand to the surface. It bowed inward without breaking, cold at first then burning, elastic with resistance.

Catra leaned forward, and it hit all at once.

Static cracked over her in a white-hot sheet. Her fur lifted. Her ears flattened. Then there was only noise, light, and the sick drag of being forced through something too tight.

Her shoulder broke through first. The blue glow of the corridor gone behind her, and rough ground suddenly beneath her feet.

She stumbled into a cave of damp stone, cold metal, low lights, purple fronds shifting at the entrance.

The hum was still here, but wrong in a different way now. Tuned to someone else.

It smelled like an old rebel camp with grimy fabric and stale rations, and too many people surviving on too little for too long. A

map hung on the wall, covered in markers, edges worn soft from too many hands. Bedrolls lined the far wall.

Catra went still. There she was.

The sight of her hit hard enough to make Catra unsteady. She locked up before it could show.

Adora sat on a bedroll, knees drawn up, the bandage on her arm gone dark through the cloth. One hand was braced over her ribs like she'd gotten so used to pain she didn't even notice it anymore. Her fingers twitched once, curling inward just enough to whiten the knuckles.

Then her hand moved, reaching sideways without looking, muscle memory carrying it toward the empty space beside her.

It found nothing.

Adora looked wrecked. Hurt, yes, but also tired all the way through from trying to hold too much together for too long and refusing to drop any of it.

When Adora stood, her shoulders went back, and the mask slid into place. She crossed to the map, and her eyes moved over the markers with that hard, focused look she got when she tried to turn things into a problem she could solve. Just find the right angle. Push harder.

Adora hadn't noticed her.

Catra stood still for a second, watching the rise and fall of her chest. Even now, the catch was still there under the act.

Then she stepped in close and reached out. Her hand landed between Adora's shoulder blades.

Warm. Real.

Everything narrowed to that touch. For one unguarded second, the shock of finding her solid hit so hard it hurt. Adora was here.

Catra’s whole body locked tight at the contact, then jolted loose in a helpless shiver she couldn't stop. Her claws slipped out on instinct, then pulled back before they could bite. Her ears flattened. Her tail lashed once behind her, sharp and impossible to hide.

Catra kept her palm there between Adora’s shoulder blades and held still.

That stubborn catch of breath warmed her cheek, and Adora did not turn.

Chapter 17: Credence

Chapter Summary

> The hum offers certainty. Catra offers only herself. Adora must choose what hurts or what's easy.

Adora had learned to read damage quickly. It was a necessary skill for a leader in a struggling rebellion, in a cave full of people who looked to her for steady reassurance. She needed to be the one who could look at the map and find the next right move, who could project the certainty that one even existed.

Warmth pressed between her shoulder blades like a hand on her back. It rested there with a stillness that felt deliberate. Want moved through her too quickly to examine, and she flattened it at once. The hum always knew how to press where she was weakest. She kept her eyes on the map's markers and waited for them to resolve into something she could work with. Her ribs pulled with every breath.

"You can stop, Adora."

The voice beside her was low and raspy.

Adora glanced over her shoulder. She had reached for that face before and found nothing.

"You're not here," her voice came out flat. "You can't be here." Adora drew a breath and before she could stop herself more slipped out, "I haven't done enough, I…"

Adora focused back on the map, "I have to finish the plan."

"Maybe not the way you want. Still me."

The hum slid in at once with its warmth smoothing the edges of everything Catra's voice had disturbed. Adora felt herself steady.

Certainty settled back in like all she had to do was just keep going long enough for the answers to appear.

“I know. I just need to get this next plan right,” Adora said.

The answer landed crooked, aimed past Catra and at the map. The hum had already started sanding her smooth.

“Adora. Look at me. I’m not telling you to keep going.”

Catra’s stomach turned hard. She hated that. Hated that the hum had looked at her and decided Adora would trust her most as something easy that kept her working. Adora was still staring at the map like it could save her if she just kept feeding herself into it. Too far in. Too hurt. Breathing like every word cost her.

Push harder, Catra figured, and she’d just be one more demand. Argue and she’d sound too clean, too much like the hum. So she swallowed the first sharp thing and stayed where she was, rough edges and all.

When Adora reached back toward the map, Catra stepped slowly into her line of sight. She caught her wrist, brief and gentle, just enough to still it.

“I’m here. A mess, but it’s me.”

Adora looked away, “Just let me think. I can still fix this.”

“Okay,” Catra said. “I’m not going anywhere.”

Adora kept her eyes on the map because it contained the problem, and problems could be solved if she could just keep them in front of her long enough.

Her next breath dragged against her ribs. She ignored that too.

“I know what went wrong,” she said. The words came too fast, thin around the strain in her chest. “Prime shifted the line before I could lock it in. I was compensating for the wrong break. If I just

reroute the transport path, I can still hold the area long enough to get everyone out."

Catra's fingers loosened. "Adora."

"I said I know." She swallowed and the next breath caught harder. Her hand came up to brace her bruised ribs before she thought better of it. "I almost had it."

The hum thrummed, low and pleased, warmth sliding up Adora's spine. It wrapped around the words and made them feel tidy and true. Stay here and finish this. The next answer is close.

Adora fixed her stare on the map's lines. "I just need a minute."

Catra was silent long enough for the quiet to scrape.

"Okay," she said at last. "Fine. Take the minute. But stop pretending that's all this is."

The words went through Adora like a crack suddenly spreading through glass. Her mouth tightened. She looked back at the map so fast it almost hurt. "I'm not pretending anything."

"No?" Catra asked.

"No." The answer came too sharp. "I'm trying to fix it."

Catra let that sit there.

The hum pressed more firmly between Adora's shoulders. Yes. This is what you are for.

Her breathing had gone ragged now, each inhale tugging against her bruised ribs. She could hear it, hated that she could hear it, hated more that Catra could too.

"It kept falling apart," she said, words coming now whether she wanted them to or not. "Every time I got one thing under control, something else went. Every time I thought I had a path open,

Prime’s forces closed it.” She pressed harder at her side, fingers digging uselessly into the ache there. “I just needed one thing to hold.”

Catra didn’t speak, just listened.

That silence was unbearable.

“I was supposed to hold it together,” Adora said, quieter now. “That was the whole point.”

Catra’s voice came back, roughened at the edges. “For who?”

Adora laughed once, thin and breathless. “Everyone.”

“For who, Adora.”

She shut her eyes. The map stayed behind them anyway, burned there in lines and choke points and collapsing ground. Her shoulders had gone rigid. She could feel exactly where Catra stood, exactly where the hum’s warmth pressed, exactly how little space there was left inside her for both.

“For them,” she said. “For the rebellion. For everyone in this cave. For the ones who kept looking at me like I would know what to do.”

“And for me?” There was no accusation in it.

Adora’s throat tightened. “Don’t.”

Catra let that sit.

Adora’s next breath hitched sharply enough to make her fold a little around the pain in her side. Her hand braced there again, automatic, and this time she did not have enough control left to hide it.

“I failed the mission,” she whispered. Then even quieter, “I failed you.”

The hum surged at once, warm and urgent. No. Keep moving. Don’t stop now. There’s still work to do.

Adora’s attention was drawn back to the map. Catra saw it. Adora knew she did.

“You don’t get to do that,” Catra said softly.

Adora stared at the map. “Do what?”

“Hand yourself back to it every time this starts to hurt.”

Something in Adora’s chest gave a little, not enough to break, enough to make the strain worse.

“I don’t know what else to do.”

There it was.

Not a grand confession. Not the whole truth. Just the torn edge of it, exposed.

The hum faltered for one beat.

Catra went very still, then moved slowly enough that Adora could have pulled away if she wanted. She stepped into the space beside her. Their shoulders touched, light and deliberate. Catra angled herself carefully, keeping clear of Adora’s bruised side. The contact was small. Not something that asked to be leaned on. Just there.

Adora’s breath caught. Not from pain.

Because the hum never did this exactly.

The hum soothed in broad strokes. It pressed from nowhere and everywhere, folding her back into the role until the edges disappeared.

This was different. Catra was all edges, tired and uneven, and breathing a little too fast herself. She was close enough that Adora

could feel the strain she was trying not to show, close enough that the touch had to be adjusted around pain rather than pretending it away.

“There,” Catra murmured. “That’s all.”

Adora didn’t look at her, but she did not pull away either.

The map blurred.

“I didn’t want you to see me like this,” Adora said, barely a whisper, her eyes downcast.

Beside her, Catra’s shoulder stayed steady against hers. “Yeah,” Catra said. “I know.”

Adora’s mouth trembled once before she locked it down. “I kept thinking if I just fixed one more thing, it wouldn’t be this. It wouldn’t be me standing here with nothing left but...” She swallowed. “This.”

Catra let the words sit there, ugly and unfinished.

When Adora finally turned, Catra looked wrecked and real. Her fur was scorched in places, her hair mussed, her eyes too tired. Nothing was polished, nothing arranged to make this easier.

The hum reached out again with its three-beat reassurance.

Adora felt it. And for the first time, felt the difference.

“What happened to you,” she said, not quite a question.

“Same thing that happened to you,” Catra said. “More or less.”

The hum wanted the answer smoothed flat, but there was too much friction in Catra, too much wear for that.

Adora let herself look at her, really look.

The tired set of Catra’s eyes. The tension still hooked through her body. The way she held herself like someone who had fought to get here and had not yet stopped fighting. The small care of the contact between them, adjusted around Adora’s pain instead of erasing it. None of it was neat.

Catra was not the hum because the hum could not be this true.

Adora’s breath came in raggedly. Her ribs ached. The map still burned at the edge of her vision, bright and demanding, lines waiting to be solved. The hum pressed warm insistence against her spine. Finish it. Just one more answer. Just one more correction. Turn back.

But Catra’s shoulder stayed there, real in a way the warmth could not imitate. It was slightly unsteady, held on purpose, choosing her back.

Adora swallowed. “I don’t know if you’re real, but you seem like you.” Her voice shook once and steadied only because she made it. “I’m choosing you anyway.”

The hum hit her hard for that.

The map almost seemed to pulse. The markers snapped into brutal clarity. Paths opened all at once, false and perfect and begging to be taken. Warmth surged through Adora in three pounding beats, reassurance sharpening into command. This way. Look here. Stay useful.

Adora’s whole body wanted to answer out of habit. Her hand twitched toward the map. Her ribs pulled sharply when she stopped it. Beside her, Catra tensed but did not grab for her again.

“Adora.”

“I know.”

Things started to flicker and fade as Adora concentrated on Catra, on the realness of her. Catra’s shoulder against hers, warm

through strain. Her breathing, a little off. The patience she was forcing into place over fear. Adora fixed on it all with desperate focus.

The map stuttered.

Its neat lines shook and split. It began to break apart at the edges.

The hum surged again, stronger, less careful now.

Warmth flooded through her back and neck and skull, trying to drag her gaze forward. It offered relief so sweet it felt like belonging. If she would only turn away. If she would only let it take this choice from her. If she would only go back to being the one who solved and endured and did not have to be seen.

Adora stayed turned away.

The effort of it trembled through her. She leaned just slightly into Catra's shoulder instead, barely enough to count, but there.

The hum broke rhythm.

Cave structures started to flicker.

The map went first, its glowing paths pulling apart like threads cut loose. The cave walls behind it trembled, losing depth, losing certainty, their false rock skin thinning into brightness and then into nothing.

The Echo Core's real architecture returned.

A large corridor, angular and hollow. Reflective blue surfaces emerged with glowing symbols marked too precisely into the walls. The hum was still there but reduced now, stripped down from atmosphere to source, smaller and rawer and trying to reassert itself in agitated pulses that faltered before they could fully catch.

Cold air cut through Adora’s awareness.

Weight settled across her body all at once. The pressure of the suit returned. She suddenly felt all her aches, the drag of damage she had not been allowed to feel clearly inside the simulation. Her helmet was still cracked, the corridor’s harsh brightness reflecting off the visor. Her own breath rebounded inside it, uneven and ragged. Every bruise, every strain, every raw place came back wearing the sharper edges of truth.

Beside her, Catra staggered half a step and steadied.

Her suit was marked up too, scored and singed. Catra reached out with her worn glove, loose threads lifting from the damaged fabric where it had been used and kept and used again instead of replaced. Her hand landed on the repaired crack in Adora’s visor, thumb brushing over the scuffed epoxy still holding the damage in check.

Her hand dropped to Adora’s uninjured arm. It grazed her forearm, then her wrist, and finally her hand like she was relearning the exact coordinates of her through layers of damage and disbelief.

Adora felt it.

She felt the pressure of that worn glove through suit material, through lingering distortion, through every layer the Echo Core had put between them.

“You’re really here.”

“Yeah.”

The words moved between them strangely in the helmets, a little flattened by comms distortion, but Catra still sounded like Catra. Wrecked and steady by force.

There was a large tear at one shoulder of Catra’s suit and singed marks lined the arms. Her eyes were too bright with exhaustion

and adrenaline and something more vulnerable than either that she was clearly not interested in naming right now.

“You’re hurt,” Adora said.

Catra’s gaze took in the way Adora held herself too carefully around her ribs, to the way one glove hovered near her side as if the pain there had become part of her posture.

“You’re worse.”

Adora’s chest felt lighter and her shoulders loosened. This was small and real and shared. The hum’s broad warmth couldn't feel like this.

It tried anyway, pulsing in shaky waves as if repetition alone might rebuild its trap. A few strands of light shivered at the end of the corridor trying to entice. The old reassurance attempted to gather itself and failed, then tried again, weaker.

Catra’s hand tightened around hers.

Adora held on just as hard.

For a second they only stood there breathing through their helmets, both of them a little off-balance, both carrying too much damage to make any of this graceful. Their suits were scuffed and torn. Shame still clung to Adora like a second skin. Whatever Catra had dragged out of her own simulation still shadowed the set of her mouth, the line of her body. None of it gone. None of it fixed.

And still.

Their hands stayed linked. The worn glove against her own damaged one. Catra reaching her through every layer. Adora answering.

“Don’t let go.”

“Not planning to.”

They stayed there a moment longer with the Echo Core shuddering faintly around them and the hum trying, failing, trying again to become larger than it was. But it could not get between them now in the same way. Not while Adora could feel the loose threads under her glove, the tremor Catra was not fully hiding, the reality of her reaching through all that damage and still choosing to stay.

Adora drew in one more ragged breath and let herself lean the smallest bit closer, helmet brushing Catra’s shoulder with a muted tap. It wasn’t elegant or healed or anything the hum would have designed.

It was just shared damage and shared presence, just the small, stubborn fact of each other.

Chapter 18: Munificence

Chapter Summary

> They try to leave. The rhythm keeps reaching. This time, they answer.

The hum rose, trying to fill the space around them. It came in uneven pulses now, catching on itself, breaking before it could fully form. Then it rushed to try again, quicker this time, as if correcting the failure before it could settle. It searched for the spaces it had learned, the places where Adora braced and tried to hold everything steady. It pressed against her like a voice with no words, insisting.

They moved anyway, out of its simulations now and trying to get back to their ship. Catra's hand stayed locked in hers, grip firm and a little uneven. Adora held on just as tightly, anchoring in that contact instead of the pull at her chest. The hum pressed closer as they went, crowding their steps, slipping between breath and motion, urging hesitation. It swelled once, catching at her stride, asking for stillness.

Corridor light bent around them in shallow curves that didn't resolve. It shifted along the walls in slow, uncertain gradients, trying to disorient them. Catra stayed close, closer than strictly necessary, not close enough to slow them. Adora matched her pace, keeping her steps off-rhythm, careful with the weight of her body, her pulse rising with the pressure around them.

The hum followed and tracked them. It changed as they moved, tightening around them, gathering itself where Adora faltered. It tried to meet her where she was, adjusting too quickly, overcorrecting as it strained to become an answer.

She needed something more to resist it. Adora reached inside, pushing past hesitation before it could settle into doubt. She

closed her eyes for half a second, just enough to try and find alignment rather than control, and reached for She-Ra.

The hum spiked sharp enough to steal her breath, pressure closing in on her, as if her reaching had given it something to seize on.

Then, the echo within her answered, but only barely, just a flicker. It brushed the edge of her awareness and failed to stay, slipping before she could take hold of it, before it could take hold of her. Gone before she could decide if she had done it wrong.

Adora staggered, catching herself on the wall.

For a moment, there was something quieter, thinner than the hum but real in a way the hum never reached. Just the shape of a word, forming and unforming too quickly to keep, slipping away before anything could close around it.

Then the hum surged again, filling the space where it had been.

Catra caught her before she could slide any farther. Her hand moved to brace Adora's elbow, firm through her glove, claws held carefully away. Her other hand hovered near Adora's side and then settled there too, slow enough for Adora to feel it coming.

"Hey," Catra said through the comm. Her voice was low, controlled with effort. "Stay with me."

Adora pulled in a breath. The hum tried to take it, tried to smooth it into the rhythm it wanted, pressing for something steadier, more correct. She forced the exhale out unevenly. "I'm here," she said, pushing the words out before they could thin or shift into something less certain.

Catra's eyes narrowed behind the curve of her helmet. Her gaze flicked from Adora's face to the walls, then back again. "It reacted," Catra said.

Adora swallowed. Her hand stayed braced against the wall. The crystal beneath her palm pulsed once, faint and blue beneath the surface. “I know.”

“No, I mean it reacted to you trying to call She-Ra.” Catra’s voice sharpened, though she kept it quiet. “It was scared.”

Adora looked at her then.

The hum pressed harder, indignant and wounded all at once. For the first time, its desperation seemed less like control and more like pain.

Corridor light shifted. A seam opened along the wall beside Adora’s hand, thin at first, then widening into a narrow passage cut through the crystal. The air that moved through it was colder, older, carrying the mineral taste of First Ones tech.

The hum faltered.

Adora straightened slowly, still leaning a little into Catra’s hand.

“That wasn’t the way back,” Catra said.

“No,” Adora answered.

The new passage was different than the other corridors of the Echo Core. It was lined with panels etched with fading diagrams and strings of First Ones’ writing. Adora stepped closer despite the tremor still in her legs.

Catra stayed with her, shoulder nearly touching hers. “Adora.”

“I can read some of it.” The shapes were already arranging themselves in her mind, meaning surfacing before she could stop it. “Magic source isolated,” Adora read aloud. Her brow furrowed, and her fingers hovered just above the surface. She read the next line twice. Her chest tightened. “Subject…” Her voice caught slightly. She forced it steady. “Subject continues to call.”

The words lingered.

The hum moved through the passage in a shudder, low and strained, no longer beautiful, no longer soothing. It sounded like something scraping itself raw against a sealed door.

Adora’s breath caught.

“It wasn’t just collecting,” she said.

Catra’s attention sharpened. “What?”

Adora didn't look away from the wall. “They trapped it here.”

The hum swelled around them, but this time it did not feel like a command. It felt like it was responding to hearing itself named for the first time in a very long while, and not being corrected.

Adora kept reading, each phrase assembling with effort. “Stronger containment required.” Her fingers hovered closer to the etched surface, as if proximity might change what it said. Her chest drew tight. “Subject seeking external organic anchor.”

Catra went very still.

“Organic anchor,” she repeated.

Adora’s mouth felt dry. “Us. Maybe everyone it reached before us.”

The crystal wall beside the panel pulsed. Three beats, then a pause.

Catra's fingers tightened at Adora's elbow. "It was using people to get out."

"Maybe," she said. "Or it learned using from being used. And kept doing the only thing it knew."

Catra went quiet. Her eyes moved to the walls, then back to Adora. "That's not the same thing."

"No," Adora said. "It's not."

Neither answer absolved it or made what it had done harmless. The hum had manipulated them, separated them, fed on the places they were most vulnerable. It had worn comfort like a mask and called it care.

But underneath that, beneath the simulations and the attunement and the false steadiness, something had been trapped long enough to forget the difference between reaching and taking.

Adora felt the fragile echo in her chest flicker.

This time the hum did not spike. It listened. The hum shifted. It drew closer, smoothing the edges of the corridor, light aligning so it asked less of her. Another seam opened along the wall beside Adora's hand, an entry into a chamber filled with pulsing, crackling light and energy.

They stepped a few steps forward and into the room. High above them a series of translucent blue crystal structures surrounded the light, containing it.

Adora stilled, her hand rising without thought, to the dome of her helmet, her fingers finding the smoothed over part. The crack sat beneath her touch, worn and familiar under her hand. It held in place with quiet certainty. For a moment, it felt like it could carry the weight for her. Her hand stayed there, and she understood.

"I wanted it to be real," Adora said. Her voice came out quiet, but it held.

The hum pressed closer, warm and certain, as if it could take the words back before they finished becoming true, before they could settle into something it couldn't change.

"I wanted what it gave me. I wanted to feel steady. Useful. Like I could always know what to do." Her fingers stayed on the crack in the helmet. "And I was afraid if you saw that, really saw it, you'd understand that I've been pretending."

Catra went very still beside her.

Adora swallowed, hesitating for just a beat. “That I’m scared all the time. That I don’t know how to be enough unless I’m protecting someone, solving something, or fixing things before anything can fall out of place.” The words hurt more once they were outside her. “I thought needing help meant I had already failed.”

The hum faltered.

Adora kept her hand against the crack. “I thought if you saw how much I wanted to let the hum carry me, you’d pity me. Or, maybe leave. Or realize there wasn’t much here without all of that.” She breathed in, unsteady and real. “Just me.”

Catra did not answer right away.

For one breath, Adora thought that was it. That the silence meant everything she had been afraid of.

Then Catra moved closer, slowly, clearly giving Adora time to see it happen. Her hand came up and her worn glove covered Adora’s where it rested against the crack in the helmet. “I know,” Catra said.

Adora’s breath caught.

Catra’s fingers tightened around hers. “I know you’re scared.”

The hum shifted, restless now, its warmth turning thin at the edges.

“I know you wanted it to be real.” Catra’s voice stayed low. “I wanted it too. I knew it was a trap. I reached anyway.”

Adora looked at her then.

Catra’s ears were angled back, but she did not look away. “And I’m still here.”

The words landed softly. They still hit hard.

“I’m not here because you’re useful,” Catra said. “Or because you always know what to do. I’m here because it’s you.”

Adora’s hand trembled under hers.

The crack in the helmet warmed beneath their joined fingers.

Catra glanced toward the center of the chamber, where the trapped light folded over itself again and again, bright and strained and furious.

“It’s scared too. Same as us,” she said.

The hum flared.

Catra flinched, but she held on.

“It got trapped doing whatever it could to survive.”

Adora’s eyes burned.

Catra’s mouth twisted, not quite a smile.
“I know something about that too.”

The light snapped hard across the walls.
Catra turned toward it, still holding Adora’s hand.

“I used to think the anger was all there was. That if I let it out, I’d become what they made me. A weapon. A monster. Just there to hurt everyone.”

Her claws flexed once against Adora’s glove, then eased.

“But anger can stop.”

The chamber went still around the words.

“It protects. Then it stops. It breaks one door without wrecking everything after,” Catra continued.

The trapped magic shuddered. The hum lost its rhythm, three beats falling out of alignment.

Adora felt warmth rise beneath her palm, present and asking nothing. Just there.

Catra looked back at her.

“And you can need help and still be you.” She held the words between them, leaving space.

Adora’s breath broke.

The crack beneath their fingers brightened as a thin line of gold lit through it, filling the fracture and recognizing it rather than repairing or erasing it.

Light gathered at the edge of Adora’s vision, familiar in a way the hum had only ever imitated. It arrived like a hand offered back, a presence returned to her, open and waiting.

Adora closed her eyes. For once, she did not reach for certainty. She reached for Catra. And She-Ra returned, meeting her where she stood.

The light rose gently and free of pressure. It remained open around her, asking nothing.

Adora drew in a breath that shook.

“There you are,” Catra said lowly.

The chamber held that breath with her. The hum wavered. It brushed at her edges, offering alignment, the kind that came from everything falling into place too quickly.

Adora felt it. She did not lean into it.

Her fingers tightened once against Catra’s, then eased.

The hum faltered.

Adora opened her eyes.

The core pulsed at the center of the chamber, light folding in on itself, bright and strained, cycling through shapes that never held. Each one reached for balance before faltering, tightening, and folding back into the same contained loop, as if it could not allow itself to hold.

Adora stepped forward. She did not take her hand away. Catra moved with her, grip unchanged.

The hum rose, volume steady, sharpening in insistence.

It reached for Adora in the ways it had learned she would answer. It smoothed the air, aligned the light, offered her a place inside it where everything resolved.

Adora felt the pull of it, the part of her that wanted to rest, the part that wanted to be certain. She let herself feel all of it. Then she spoke through it. “You were trying to survive,” she said, and let the words go without asking anything back.

The core stuttered. Light fractured across its surface, uneven, like something adjusting to a new weight.

Adora took another step.

“You were contained,” she said. “You learned how to last.” She kept her voice steady and let the truth stand.

The hum lost a beat, then another. The intervals did not close again. They held open, like silence that no longer needed to be filled. It reached again, but it couldn't find her there.

“You don’t have to do that anymore. I’m not asking for anything,” Adora said. “Just telling you what’s true.”

The chamber shifted, moving in small waves. The space between each structure widened through allowance rather than distance, as if the room had stopped trying to hold everything in place and

begun uncertainly to let it be. Lines that had been held too tight eased. The light stopped folding so sharply. The edges of the space softened into something that could move.

Catra’s hand tightened once with steady presence.

Adora did not look away from the core. “You can be angry,” she said, her voice stabilizing as she went. “You can feel what was done to you.”

The light flared, bright and wild and unsteady.

Adora held her ground. “And you can stop,” she said.

The flare held for a moment, then changed, as if it finally had something else to give. It didn’t rush. It stayed there, uncontained, as if waiting to see if anything would force it back.

The light stretched outward, no longer striking or seeking. It expanded past the structures that had held it. The chamber filled with it, bright and steady in a way it had never been allowed to be.

The hum broke with a soft unraveling, letting go of what it had held. The rhythm slipped apart, the pattern loosening until it could no longer hold itself together.

Something in Adora's chest eased. She hadn't even known it was clenched until it wasn't. She felt the specific relief of a grip released past the point of knowing you were holding it, muscles unknotting all the way down. Beside her she heard Catra exhale, long and uneven, felt her shoulder drop just slightly against hers.

The Core opened, yielding all at once.

The light that had been folded inward for longer than either of them could comprehend unfurled outward in slow, steady motion, learning how to take up room again. It moved past the chamber walls, no longer bound to a center that required it to stay.

Silence followed, real silence allowed to stand on its own.

Adora lowered her hand. Catra tightened her grip, worn glove against her own, loose threads and all, choosing.

The silence shifted, and for the first time, what moved through was not a hum asking to be obeyed, but a three-beat song like a voice, finally answering because it could.

Chapter 19: Consonance

Chapter Summary

They make it back to their ship. This time, they hold.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Touch remained after the light had gone. Adora felt it first as Catra's hand still clasped around hers, warm through the worn leather, claws resting carefully against the back of her glove. The contact settled in her chest in a steady way that only asked her to feel it there. It stayed without demand, without needing to be held in place.

The Core stood open before them, its fractured light thinning into the chamber in quiet bands, light that no longer struck, only settled. Nothing pressed at her now or filled the spaces between her thoughts. They remained open, unclaimed, as if they belonged to her again.

The silence had texture still. She heard the sounds of breathing, the faint settling of the walls, the feel of Catra's thumb moving once against her knuckle. The quiet settled around them in small shifts, each sound finding its place without crowding the others. It held without closing in, leaving room for her to stand inside it and choose what to notice. Her shoulders eased a fraction, the tension slipping without anything pushing back.

Adora waited for the next thing to manage. The thought came by habit, small and familiar, already focusing on what might need to be held together, corrected, kept from slipping. Her shoulders started to tighten. Then Catra's fingers shifted in hers, and Adora let that be the thing. She answered with a soft press, just meeting her touch.

Catra’s ears tipped back when Adora stayed still. The quiet stretched and nothing rushed in to break it. “Hey.”

Adora looked over too quickly. “I’m okay.”

Catra didn't fully buy that. Her fingers tightened. She was used to the moment after, when something snapped back or had to be held in place. The absence of it left her with nowhere to put it. Her shoulders stayed set for one beat longer, like her body was still waiting for impact.

Adora’s mouth softened. “I mean it.” A breath. “I’m just… looking.”

Catra watched her again, waiting for the usual signs. None came. The chamber held steady around them.

Catra made herself breathe once, slow and deliberate, and let her grip ease. She nodded. “Okay. Looking, then.”

She stayed where she was, close enough to feel the warmth of Adora’s hand and nothing else trying to pull it away.

They walked out of the chamber off-rhythm. Adora noticed it after the third turn. Catra’s steps came quick and light beside hers, then slowed when the corridor narrowed. Adora’s boots landed heavier, less certain, catching in a pattern that matched nothing the place had tried to instill in her.

It should have felt like failure. Before, she would have made it one. Now, it just felt like walking. Her steps found their own weight without asking to match anything else.

Catra’s shoulder bumped hers at the next bend, casual and warm.

“Watch it,” Catra muttered.

Adora smiled. “You bumped me.”

“Sounds fake.”

The corridor gave no answer. The silence held. They continued forward through the last long stretch.

Adora glanced over when they reached the airlock. “You got quiet.”

Catra huffed, but there was little bite in it. “Yeah. Sometimes I do that.”

Adora’s shoulders lifted a fraction.

Catra saw the questions forming in Adora’s thoughts. Are you angry? Are you leaving? Did I miss something?

She pressed the airlock control with the heel of her hand. “I’m still here.”

Adora let her breath out.

Catra looked away first, her tail giving a small, restless flick behind her, because seeing that much relief on Adora’s face still did things to her chest. “Just thinking.”

“About what?”

The airlock opened with a familiar hiss.

“That it’s weird when something ends and nobody’s yelling.” Catra said it like she didn't quite trust the quiet yet.

The airlock sealed behind them with a low, familiar thud. They passed through into the bridge. Amber-pink lights flickered on in their unhurried sequence, filling the deck with the warmth of their glow.

The ship answered in small sounds, the engine cycle rattling the vent a few times before evening out and the console ticking softly from the bridge, familiar and unmanaged.

A slight hum.

Adora stopped. Catra stopped with her.

For one breath, Adora listened for pressure, for the smooth, terrible certainty of being told where to stand inside herself.

The ship only kept running. It held its rhythm without reaching for her. This hum didn't resolve into three beats.

It sounded like home because it wanted nothing from her.

They pulled off their helmets and let them fall onto the bench. Air rushed back in with that faint scent of warmed alloy and recycled citrusy disinfectant.

On the bridge, the lights were exactly as Catra remembered. Too bright along the upper panels, too dim near the left console. Perfect.

Adora stood just inside the doorway, eyes moving over everything like she was afraid to touch it too hard.

Catra lifted her hand and brushed Adora’s cheek with the back of her worn glove.

Adora leaned into it by the smallest amount.
Catra’s tail stilled and her chest went tight. She let it, without trying to soften it into something easier to carry.

“There you are,” she said, rougher than she meant.

Adora looked at her. “Here I am.”

Adora almost asked what needed doing. The question rose automatically, shaped by years of battlefields and rooms where standing still meant someone else might decide what she was worth. She didn't speak.

Catra moved to the console and tapped one readout with a claw.

The diagnostic display read ALL SYSTEMS HAPPY.

“Systems are fine,” Catra reported. She didn’t dress it up. Didn’t make it sound better than it was.

“Fine?”

“Yeah.” Catra glanced back. “Annoying, right?”

Adora laughed once, surprised by it.

Catra leaned forward, already moving through the next sequence, hands quick over the controls.

For a moment, Adora felt the old distance open, the sense that she had missed a step and Catra had gone on without her. The thought settled before it could take hold. Catra’s shoulder brushed hers as she shifted, not looking away from the console. Adora let the contact answer it.

Catra keyed in the pull back sequence.

The Echo Core grew small in the viewport. Neither of them said anything. It got smaller, then smaller still. Then it was just another shape in the dark, and then it wasn't anything anymore.

Catra pulled up the jump coordinates. Her own hands this time, her own choice of where. She entered them without asking.

Adora watched her do it and let the moment pass without reaching for the controls. She recognized that nothing would fall apart if she didn't act. She didn’t need to steady the course to trust this.

She let that stand.

"Ready?" Catra said.

"Yeah."

The jump took them.

Light streaked across the viewport in long bright lines, the kind that made the ship feel like it was dissolving and arriving at once.

The helmet sat where Adora had left it on the bench beside the airlock. The crack visible at the base caught the jump light. The epoxied fracture lit gold for a second, the light catching in the uneven line instead of hiding it. Catra watched Adora see it.

Old fear hit Catra before she could stop it. The kind that expected Adora to fold inward, apologize to an object, make herself smaller next to proof she'd survived.

Adora reached for the helmet.

Catra held still. Her claws flexed once inside her glove, then eased. She wanted to reach for Adora, to stop the old fear before it got loud, but she stayed where she was. This time, staying still didn't feel like doing nothing. It felt like trust.

Adora touched the crack in the helmet and felt no pull to hide it or need to make it useful. It was just evidence that something had happened, and they had held. The epoxy stayed smooth under her thumb.

She set the helmet down where both of them could see it.

The jump light settled. Stars, different ones, unhurried and clean, not something to track or count.

The ship adjusted around them in small corrections. The vent gave its familiar uneven rattle overhead, too loud on the second shake and too soft on the third. Somewhere beneath the floor, the engine corrected with a low, imperfect murmur. Nothing in it tried to lead them or asked to be followed.

Catra's hand found hers on the edge of the bench. Adora turned her palm up. Their fingers fit together imperfectly, warm and familiar, glove against glove.

Catra squeezed once. Adora squeezed back. Catra squeezed a third time, softer.

Trust me. Trust us. Trust this.

Keeping this didn't feel like a fight. For a while, neither of them moved. Catra’s thumb rested against Adora’s pulse.

Adora let herself feel the small, living rhythm of it and didn't count. The three beats now reclaimed. The press of their hands did not match perfectly. They did not need to.

The ship hummed around them, uneven and ordinary and theirs. This time, Adora let the sound remain what it was. Just home, in the quiet off-rhythm harmony of every touch they kept choosing.



Chapter End Notes

I created this story as both art and therapy. Artistically, I wanted to experiment with anchoring each chapter around a central motif, and with carrying symbolic objects for each character all the way through the piece in a way that stayed meaningful rather than decorative.

At its core though, this story is about shame. I wanted to explore it from multiple angles and consider how it could function not just as a theme, but as an active force shaping behavior. Adora's fear and hypervigilance come from a place that feels very familiar to me, and this was a way to examine how those patterns take hold and how difficult they are to release.

Catra's arc runs alongside that in a different direction. Her fear centers on not knowing how to exist as herself without causing harm or being rejected. I felt like this arc is also very relatable.

If this story resonated with you, if you recognize yourself in the need to perform or to stay guarded, I hope it offers a small sense that you're not alone.

I'm still working on believing that love and life can hold without perfection. This story didn't solve that, but it helped me move a little closer.

End Notes

Thanks for reading! Comments are always appreciated!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!